Learner Guide

Faculty of Information Technology

Business Communication 500

Year 1 *Semester 2*

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FACULTY OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

LEARNER GUIDE

MODULES: BUSINESS COMMUNICATION 500 (2ND SEMESTER)

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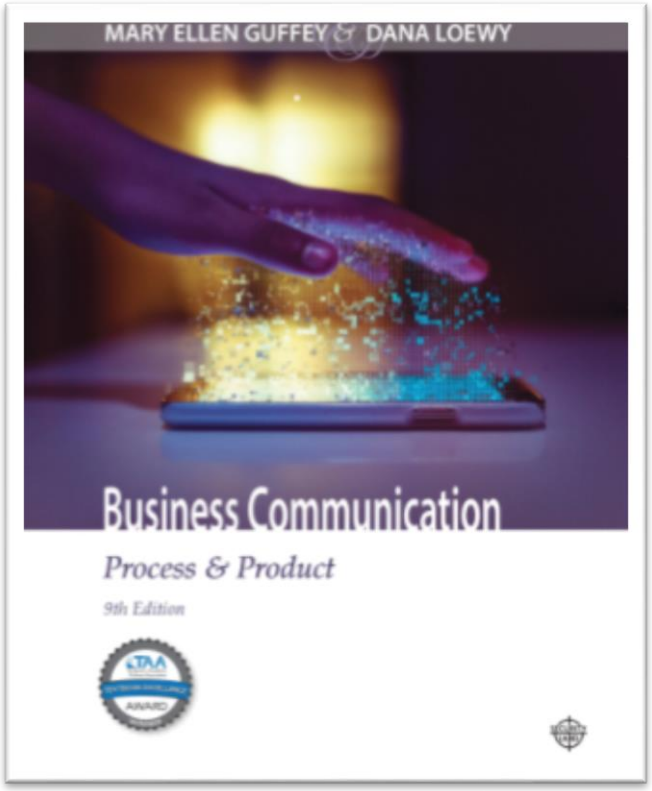
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Chapter 1: Communication Foundations

Chapter 2: The Writing Process in the Digital Era

Chapter 3: Workplace Communication

Chapter 4: Reports, Proposals, and Presentations

Chapter 5: Employment Communication

Chapter 6: Interviewing and Following Up



LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Explain how communication skills fuel career success, and understand why writing skills are vital in a digital, mobile, and social-media-driven workplace.
- Discuss effective practices and technologies for planning and participating in face-to-face meetings and virtual meetings.
- Understand the powerful effects of globalization and the major trends fuelling it.
- Define culture, name its primary characteristics, and explain the five key dimensions of culture: context, individualism, time orientation, power distance, and communication style.

Introduction

What kind of workplace will you enter when you graduate, and which skills will you need to be successful in it? Expect a fast-paced, competitive, and highly connected digital environment. Communication technology provides unmatched mobility and connects individuals anytime and anywhere in the world. Today's communicators interact using multiple electronic devices and access information stored in remote locations, in the cloud. This mobility and instant access explain why increasing numbers of workers must be avail- able practically around the clock and respond quickly. Nordstrom and other technology-savvy businesses have recognized the power of social media networks and seek to engage their customers and other stakeholders where they meet online.

1.1 Communicating in the digital world

Over the last decade, employer surveys have consistently shown that strong communication skills are critical to effective job placement, work performance, career advancement, and organizational success. In making hiring decisions, employers often rank communication skills among the most desirable competencies.

Writing skills can be your ticket to work—or your ticket out the door, according to a business executive responding to a significant survey. Writing has been variously called a "career sifter," a "threshold skill," and "the price of admission,"12 indicating that effective writing skills can be a stepping-stone to great job opportunities. Poorly developed writing skills, however, may derail a career. Writing is a marker of high-skill, high-wage, professional work, according to Bob Kerrey, former university president and chair of the National Commission on Writing. If you can't express yourself clearly, he says, you limit your opportunities for many positions.

When we discuss communication skills, we generally mean reading, listening, nonverbal, speaking, and writing skills. In addition, workers today must be media savvy and exercise good judgment when posting messages on the Internet and writing e-mails. To be successful, they must guard their online image and protect the reputation of their employers.

Writing in the Digital Age

Long gone are the days when business was mostly conducted face-to-face and when administrative assistants corrected spelling and grammar for their bosses. Although interpersonal skills still matter greatly, writing effectively is critical. Ever since the digital revolution swept the workplace, most workers write their own messages. New communication channels appeared, including the Web and e-mail, followed by instant messaging, blogs, and social media networks. The mobile revolution is stimulating huge economic growth and has profoundly changed how we communicate; it has become the fastest-adopted technology of all time. Figure 1.1 displays the emergence of new communication technology and the rapid growth of Internet users over the last two decades. So far, the number of Internet users has roughly doubled every five years.

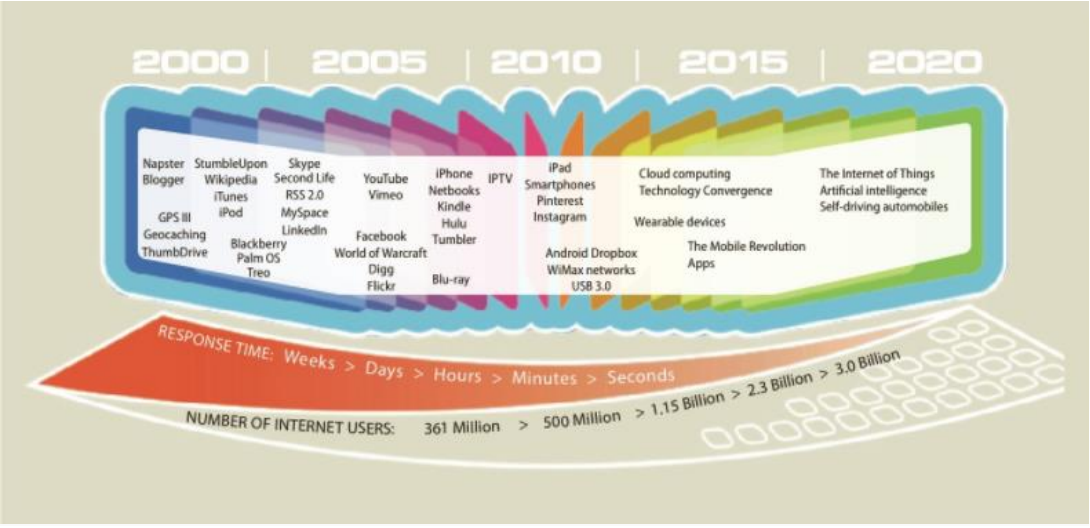


Figure 1.1: Time Line: Communication Technology and Social Media

1.2 Trends and Challenges in the Information Age Workplace

Although interacting with others on Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, WhatsApp, FaceTime, or Twitter may seem a daily necessity to you, social media are still relatively new and untried communication channels for some small businesses. Larger organizations, however, are completely plugged in and have created a positive presence with the help of both traditional and social media.

Quite logically, social media networks first attracted industries built on communication and technology, such as mainstream media outlets and information technology firms. New communication technologies also quickly took hold among marketers, in public relations, and in advertising. Even so, many businesses relying on traditional media seem to be waiting to figure out how the new media might benefit them to justify the investments.

However, even the most reluctant late adopters of technology eye the explosive growth of social media networks in the last decade with some interest. After all, online communities continue to draw huge numbers of people from all over the world. The 302 million active users of Twitter, the microblogging site, clock an average 500 million tweets per day. Ordinary citizens can organize protests and boycotts within hours, even minutes. Bad customer service experiences can lead to lifelong grudges. In short, word of mouth, positive and negative, can travel instantly at the speed of a few mouse clicks.

The various social media are maturing and yielding undeniable advantages. However, even their most avid users are learning that their favorite technologies also come with significant downsides—for example, data breeches and identify theft, as Figure 1.2 illustrates.



Figure 1.2: Communication Technology in a Mobile and Social world – Costs and Benefits

At the very least, even if they still pass on social media, nearly all businesspeople today in some way rely on the Internet to collect information, serve customers, and sell products and services. Figure 1.3 illustrates many new office and communication technologies you will meet in today's workplace.

Read

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Communication Technologies at Work

Becoming familiar with communication technology can help you succeed on the job. Today's digital workplace is shaped by mobile devices, mobile apps, social media networks, superfast broadband and wireless access, and other technologies that allow workers to share information, work from remote locations, and be more productive in or away from the office. With today's tools you can exchange ideas, solve problems, develop products, forecast future performance, and complete team projects any time of the day or night and anywhere in the world.

Cloud Computing and Web 2.0

Increasingly, applications and data are stored in remote locations online, in the cloud.

Cloud computing means that businesses and individuals no longer need to maintain costly hardware and software in-house; instead, they can centralize data on their own remote servers or pay for digital storage space and software applications offered by providers online. Photo- and video-sharing sites such as Picasa and Flickr keep users' photos in the cloud. Similarly, Dropbox, a popular file-synchronization service, and online backup provider Carbonite allow users to edit and sync files online independent of the device used to access them. The term *Web 2.0* means that websites and Web applications have shifted from one-way, read-only communication to two-way, multidirectional, read-write communication. This profound change has allowed workers to participate, collaborate, and network in unprecedented ways.

Telephony: VoIP

Savvy businesses are switching from traditional phone service to voice over Internet protocol (VoIP). This technology allows callers to communicate using a broadband Internet connection, thus eliminating long-distance and local telephone charges. Higher-end VoIP systems now support unified voice mail, e-mail, click-to-call capabilities, and softphones (Web applications or mobile apps, such as Google Voice, for calling and messaging). Free or low-cost Internet telephony sites, such as the popular Skype and FaceTime, are also increasingly used by businesses, although their sound and image quality is often uneven.

Open Offices

The widespread use of laptops, tablets, and other smart devices, wireless technology, and VoIP has led to more fluid, flexible, and open workspaces. Smaller computers and flat-screen monitors enable designers to save space with boomerang-shaped workstations and cockpit-style work surfaces rather than space-hogging corner work areas. Smaller breakout areas for impromptu meetings are taking over some cubicle space, and digital databases are replacing file cabinets. Mobile technology allows workers to be fully connected and productive on the go.

Smart Mobile Devices and Digital Convergence

Lightweight, ever-smaller devices provide phone, e-mail, Web browsing, and calendar options anywhere there's a cellular or Wi-Fi network. Tablets and smartphones such as Android devices and the iPhone and iPad allow workers to tap into corporate databases and intranets from remote locations. Users can check customers' files, complete orders, collect payment, and send out receipts without returning to the office. Increasingly, businesses are issuing smartphones to their workers, abandoning landlines completely. At the same time, the need for separate electronic gadgets is waning as digital smart devices are becoming multifunctional and highly capable. With streaming video on the Web, connectivity between TVs and computers, and networked mobile devices, technology is converging, consolidating into increasingly powerful devices. Many smart devices today are fully capable of replacing digital point-and-shoot still photography and video cameras. Mobile smart devices are competing with TVs and computers for primacy.

Mobile Apps

Mobile apps are the software that enables smartphones to run and accomplish amazing feats. Despite their natural size limitations, mobile apps rival the capabilities of full-fledged software applications on laptops, on desktops, and in the cloud.

Wearable Devices

The most recent trend in mobile computing is wearable devices. Fitbit, Google Glass, Apple Watch, and similar accessories do more than track fitness activities. They are powerful mobile devices in their own right that can sync with other smart electronics.

Voice Recognition

Computers equipped with voice recognition software enable users to dictate up to 160 words a minute with accurate transcription. Voice recognition is particularly helpful to disabled workers and professionals with heavy dictation loads, such as physicians and attorneys. Users can create documents, enter data, compose and send e-mails, browse the Web, and control their notebooks, laptops, and desktops—all by voice. Smart devices can also execute tasks with voice command apps.

Electronic Presentations and Data Visualization

Business presentations in PowerPoint, Prezi, or Keynote can be projected from a laptop or tablet, or posted online. Sophisticated presentations may include animation, sound effects, digital photos, video clips, or hyperlinks to Internet sites. In some industries, PowerPoint slides (decks) are replacing or supplementing traditional hard-copy reports. Data visualization tools such as SAS can help businesses make sense of large amounts of complex data.



Social Media

Broadly speaking, the term *social media* describes technology that enables participants to connect and share in social networks online. For example, tech-savvy companies and individuals use Twitter to issue up-to-date news, link to their blogs and websites, or announce events and promotions. Microblogging services, such as Twitter and Tumblr, also allow businesses to track what is being said about them and their products. Similarly, businesses use social networks such as Facebook, Instagram, and others to interact with customers and build their brands. Companies may also prospect for talent using social media networks. Efforts to launch corporate social networks have seen mixed results. So far workers have been slow in embracing SharePoint, Jive, Yammer, Telligent, and similar enterprise-grade collaboration platforms, social networks, and community forums.

Collaboration With Blogs, Podcasts, and Wikis

Businesses use *blogs* to keep customers and employees informed and to receive feedback. Company news can be posted, updated, and categorized for easy cross-referencing. An audio or video file streamed online or downloaded to a digital music player is called a *podcast*. A *wiki* is an Internet or intranet site that allows multiple users to collaboratively create and edit digital files as well as media. Information can get lost in e-mails, but wikis provide an easy way to communicate and keep track of what's said. Wikis for business include Confluence, eXo Platform, Socialtext, and Jive.

Web Conferencing

With services such as GoToMeeting, WebEx, and Microsoft Live Meeting, all you need is a computer or a smart device and an Internet connection to hold a meeting (*webinar*) with customers or colleagues in real time. Although the functions are constantly evolving, Web conferencing currently incorporates screen sharing, chats, slide presentations, text messaging, and application sharing.

Videoconferencing

Videoconferencing allows participants to meet in special conference rooms equipped with cameras and television screens. Individuals or groups see each other and interact in real time, although they may be far apart. Faster computers, rapid Internet connections, and better cameras now enable 2 to 200 participants to sit at their computers or mobile devices and share applications, spreadsheets, presentations, and photos. The technology extends from the popular low-end Internet application Skype to sophisticated videoconferencing software that delivers HD-quality audio, video, and content sharing.

Gamification

Gamification is a trend that uses game design techniques to increase motivation and engagement. Much like exciting computer games, gamification platforms in business are designed to be fun and in turn increase productivity as well as revenue. Gamification techniques include using badges or points to tap into people's natural desires for competition, status, and achievement but also altruism, collaboration, and more. Gamification is used in marketing, sales, customer retention, training, and similar business applications.

Figure 1.3: Communication and Collaborative Technologies

1.3 Ethics in the Workplace Needed More Than Ever

Ethics refers to conventional standards of right and wrong that prescribe what people should do. These standards usually consist of rights, obligations, and benefits to society. They also include virtues such as fairness, honesty, loyalty, and concern for others. Ethics is about having values and taking responsibility. Ethical individuals follow the law and refrain from theft, murder, assault, slander, and fraud. Figure 1.4 depicts some of the influences that form our awareness of ethics and help us develop a value system that guides our decisions. In the following discussion, we examine ethics in the work- place, study goals of ethical business communicators, and learn tools for doing the right thing.

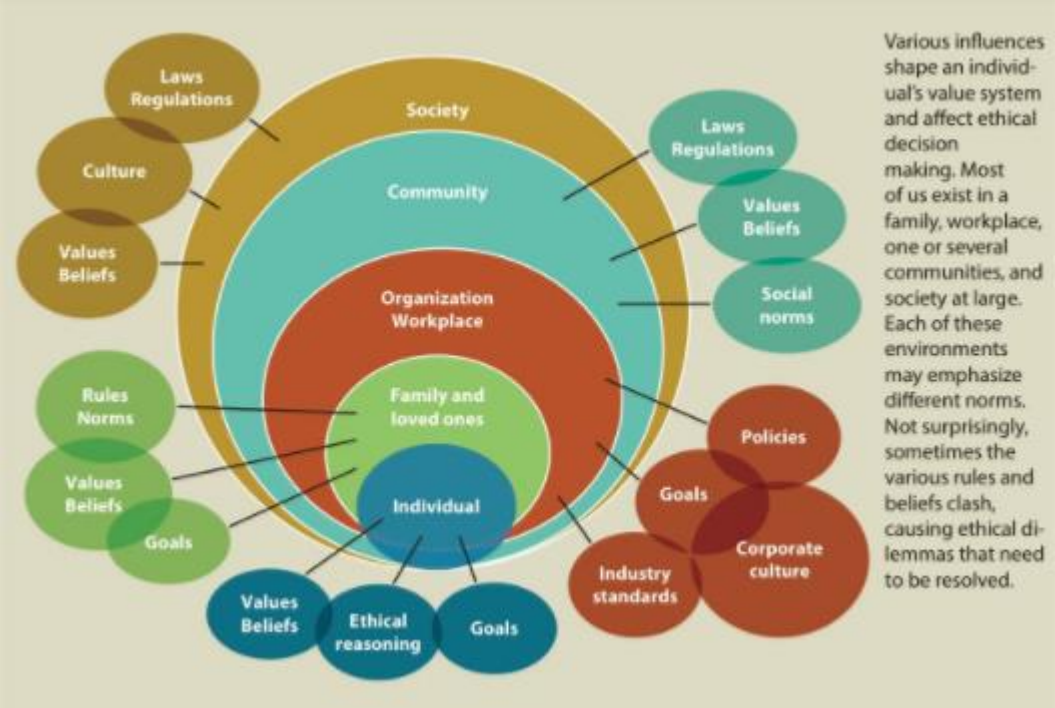


Figure 1.4: The Context of Ethical Decision Making

As a business communicator, you should understand basic ethical principles so that you can make logical decisions when faced with dilemmas in the workplace. Professionals in any field deal with moral dilemmas on the job. However, just being a moral person and having sound personal or professional ethics may not be sufficient to handle the ethical issues you may face in the workplace. Consider the following ethical dilemmas:

• **E-mail message**: You accidentally receive a message outlining your company's restructuring plan. You see that your coworker's job will be eliminated. He and his wife are about to purchase a new home. Should you tell him that his job is in danger?

• **Customer e-mail**: You are replying to an e-mail from to a customer who is irate over a mistake you made. Should you blame it on a computer glitch, point the finger at another department, or take the blame and risk losing this customer's trust and possibly your job?

• **Progress report**: Should you write a report that ignores problems in a project, as your boss asks? Your boss controls your performance evaluation.

• **Sales report**: Should you inflate sales figures so that your team can meet its quar- terly goal? Your team leader strongly urges you to do so, and you receive a healthy bonus if your team meets its goal.

• **Presentation**: You are rushing to prepare a presentation. On the Web you find perfect wording and great graphics. Should you lift the graphics and wording but change a few words? You figure that if it is on the Web, it must be in the public domain.

• **Proposal:** Your company urgently needs a revenue-producing project. Should you submit a proposal that unrealistically suggests a short completion schedule to ensure that you get the job?

• **Résumé**: Should you inflate your grade point average or give yourself more experi- ence or a higher job title than your experience warrants to make your résumé more attractive? The job market is very competitive.

Doing What Ethical Communicators Do

Taking ethics into consideration can be painful in the short term. In the long term, however, ethical behavior makes sense and pays off. Dealing honestly with colleagues and customers develops trust and builds strong relationships. The following guidelines can help you set specific ethical goals. Although these goals hardly constitute a formal code of conduct, they will help you maintain a high ethical standard.

• **Abiding by the Law**. Know the laws in your field and follow them. Particularly important for business communicators are issues of copyright law. Under the concept of fair use, individuals have limited rights to use copyrighted material without seeking permission. To be safe, you should assume that anything produced privately after 1989—including words, charts, graphs, photos, and music—is copyrighted.

• **Telling the Truth**. Ethical business communicators do not intentionally make statements that are untrue or deceptive. On a personal level, however, we all may lie and deceive in various ways. We say things that are not so. We may exaggerate to swell the importance of our assertions.

• **Labelling Opinions**. Sensitive communicators know the difference between facts and opinions. Facts are verifiable and often are quantifiable; opinions are beliefs held with confidence but without substantiation. It is a fact, for example, that women are starting businesses at two times the rate of men.97 It is an opinion, though, that the so-called glass ceiling has held women back, forcing them to start their own businesses. Such a cause-and-effect claim would be difficult to prove. Assertions that cannot be proved are opinions, and stating opinions as if they were facts is unethical and, well, foolish.

• **Being Objective**. Ethical business communicators recognize their own biases and strive to keep them from distorting a message. Honest reporting means presenting the whole picture and relating all facts fairly.

• **Communicating Clearly**. Ethical business communicators feel an obligation to write clearly so that receivers understand easily and quickly. Some states have even passed plain English (also called plain language) laws requiring businesses to write policies, warranties, and contracts in language comprehensible to average readers.

• **Giving Credit**. Ethical communicators give credit for ideas by (a) referring to originators' names within the text; (b) using quotation marks; and (c) documenting sources with endnotes, footnotes, or internal references.

Choosing Tools for Doing the Right Thing

It's easy to commit ethical lapses because of natural self-interests and the desire to succeed. In composing messages or engaging in other activities on the job, business communicators can't help being torn by conflicting loyalties. Do we tell the truth and risk our jobs? Do we show loyalty to friends even if it means bending the rules? Should we be tactful or totally honest? Is it our duty to make a profit or to be socially responsible? Acting ethically means doing the right thing given the circumstances. Each set of circumstances requires analysing issues, evaluating choices, and acting responsibly. Resolving ethical issues is never easy, but the task can be made less difficult if you know how to identify key issues. The five questions in Figure 1.5 may help you resolve most ethical dilemmas. The checklist begins by asking whether an action is legal. You should go forward only if the action complies with the law. If it does, then test the ethical soundness of your plan by asking the remaining questions: Would you proceed if you were on the receiving end of the action, and can you rule out better options? Even if the answer is yes, consider then how a trusted mentor or your family, friends, and co-workers would view your decision.



Figure 1.5: Five Questions to Guide Ethical Decisions

1.4 Adding value to professional teams

Employers are typically interested in four key areas: education, experience, hard skills, and soft skills. Hard skills refer to the technical skills in your field. Soft skills, however, are increasingly important in the knowledge-based economy of the digital era. Desirable competencies include not only oral and written communication skills but also active listening skills, appropriate nonverbal behaviour, and proper business etiquette. In addition, employers such as Lyft want efficient and productive team members. They want managers and employees who are comfortable with diverse audiences, listen actively to customers and colleagues, make eye contact, and display good workplace manners. These soft skills are immensely important not only to be hired but also to be promoted.

Hiring managers naturally expect you to have technical expertise in your field and know the latest communication technology. Such skills and an impressive résumé may get you in the door. However, your long-term success depends on how well you communicate with your boss, co-workers, and customers and whether you can be an effective and contributing team member. Even in fields such as information technology, employers are looking for soft skills. Staffing firm Robert Half Technology surveyed chief information officers and found that IT (information technology) hiring managers "are seeking candidates who not only possess technical abilities, but can also meet deadlines and work well with customers and colleagues.

Excelling in Teams

You will discover that the workplace is teeming with teams. You might find yourself a part of a work team, project team, or some other group to accomplish specific goals.

It's no secret that one of the most important objectives of businesses is finding ways to do jobs better at less cost. This objective helps explain the popularity of teams, which are formed for the following reasons:

• **Better decisions**. Decisions are generally more accurate and effective because group and team members contribute different expertise and perspectives.

• **Faster responses**. When action is necessary to respond to competition or to solve a problem, small groups and teams can act rapidly.

• **Increased productivity**. Because they are often closer to the action and to the customer, team members can see opportunities for improving efficiency.

• **Greater buy-in.** Decisions arrived at jointly are usually better received because members are committed to the solution and are more willing to support it.

• **Less resistance to change**. People who have input into decisions are less hostile, aggressive, and resistant to change.

• **Improved employee morale**. Personal satisfaction and job morale increase when teams are successful.

• **Reduced risks**. Responsibility for a decision is diffused on a team, thus carrying less risk for any individual.

Understanding the Four Phases of Team Development

Regardless of their specific purpose, teams normally go through predictable phases as they develop. The psychologist B. A. Tuckman identified four phases: forming, storming, norming, and performing, as Figure 1.6 illustrates.

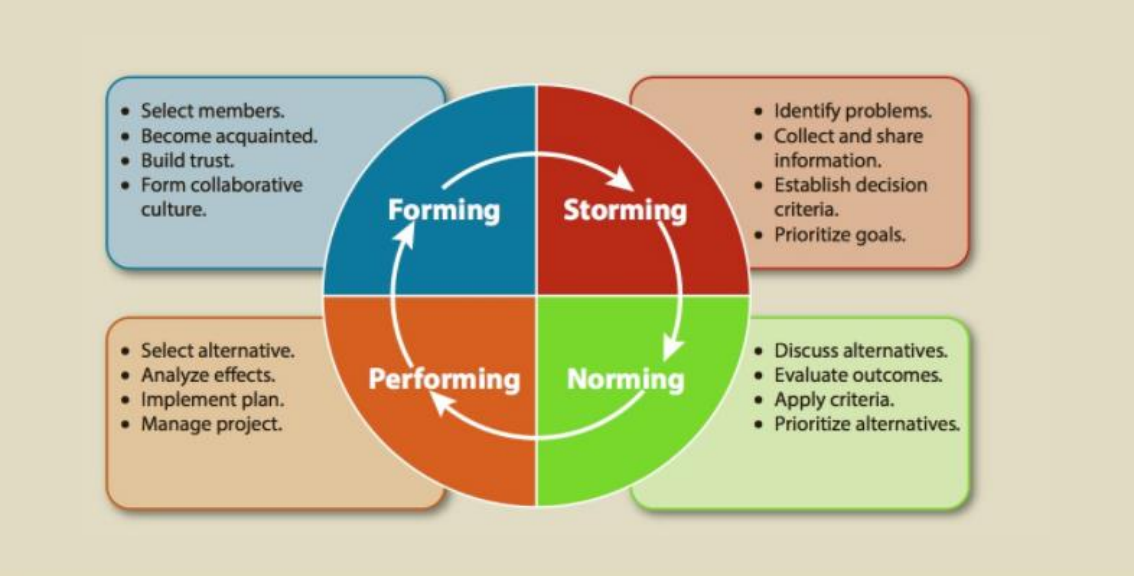


Figure 1.6: Four Phases of Team Development in Decision Making

• **Forming**. During the first stage, individuals get to know each other. They often are overly polite and feel a bit awkward. As they search for similarities and attempt to bond, they begin to develop trust in each other.

• **Storming**. During the second phase, members define their roles and responsibilities, decide how to reach their goals, and iron out the rules governing how they interact. Unfortunately, this stage often produces conflict, resulting in storming. A good leader, however, should step in to set limits, control the chaos, and offer suggestions.

• **Norming.** Once the sun returns to the sky, teams and groups enter the norming stage. Tension subsides, roles are clarified, and information begins to flow among members. The group periodically checks its agenda to remind itself of its progress toward its goals.

• **Performing**. In Tuckman's team growth model, some groups never reach the final stage of performing. For those that survive the first three phases, however, the final stage is gratifying. Group members have established routines and a shared language. They develop loyalty and a willingness to resolve all problems. A can-do mentality pervades as they progress toward their goal.

Identifying Positive and Negative Team Behaviour

To be a productive and welcome member of a group, be prepared to perform the positive tasks described in Figure 1.7. Avoid the negative behaviours.



Figure 1.7: Positive and Negative Group Behaviours

Reaching Group Decisions

The way teams reach decisions greatly affects their morale and commitment, as well as the implementation of any team decision.

• **Majority**. Group members vote and a majority wins. This method results in a quick decision but may leave an alienated minority uncommitted to implementation.

• **Consensus**. Discussion continues until all team members have aired their opinions and, ultimately, agree. This method is time consuming; however, it produces creative, high- quality discussion and generally elicits commitment by all members to implement the decision.

• **Minority**. Typically, a subcommittee investigates and makes a recommendation for action. This method is useful when the full group cannot get together to make a decision or when time is short.

• **Averaging**. Members haggle, bargain, wheedle, and negotiate to reach a middle position, which often requires compromise. With this method, the opinions of the least knowledge- able members may cancel the opinions of the most knowledgeable.

• **Authority rule with discussion**. The leader, boss, or manager listens to team members' ideas, but the final decision is his or hers. This method encourages lively discussion and results in participatory decision making. However, team members must have good communication skills. This method also requires a leader who is willing to make decisions.

Defining Successful Teams

The use of teams has been called the solution to many ills in today's workplace.22 Someone even observed that as an acronym TEAM means Together, Everyone Achieves More. Experts who have studied team dynamics and decisions have discovered that effective teams share some or all of the following characteristics.

• **Stay small and embrace diversity**. Teams smaller than ten members tend to agree more easily on a common objective and form more cohesive units. The key business advantage of diversity is the ability to view a project from multiple perspectives. Many organizations are finding that diverse teams can produce innovative solutions with broader applications than homogeneous teams can.

• **Agree on a Purpose**. An effective team begins with a purpose. Working from a general purpose to specific goals typically requires a huge investment of time and effort. Meaningful discussions, however, motivate team members to buy in to the project.

• **Establish Procedures**. The best teams develop procedures to guide them. They set up intermediate goals with deadlines. They assign roles and tasks, requiring all members to contribute equivalent amounts of real work. They decide how they will make decisions, whether by majority vote, consensus, or other methods discussed earlier. Procedures are continually evaluated to ensure movement toward the attainment of the team's goals.

• **Confront Conflict**. Poorly functioning teams avoid conflict, preferring sulking, gossiping, or backstabbing. A better plan is to acknowledge conflict and address the root of the problem openly using the six-step plan outlined in Figure 1.8.

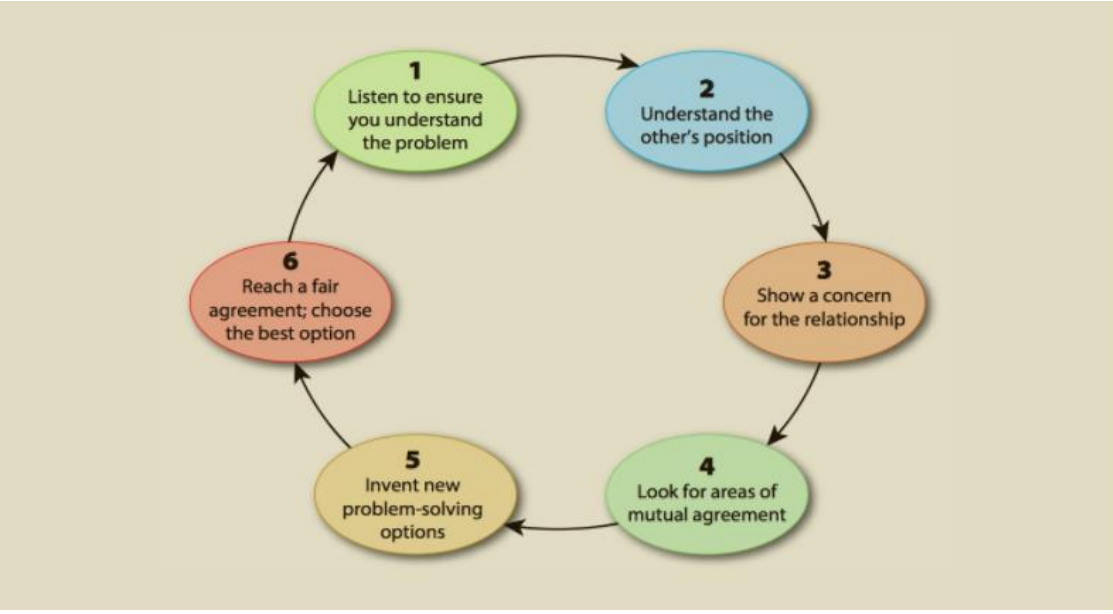


Figure 1.8: Six Steps for Dealing with Conflict

• **Communicate Effectively**. The best teams exchange information and contribute ideas freely in an informal environment often facilitated by technology. Team members speak and write clearly and concisely, avoiding generalities. They encourage feedback. Listeners become actively involved, read body language, and ask clarifying questions before responding. Tactful, constructive disagreement is encouraged.

• **Collaborate Rather Than Compete**. Effective team members are genuinely interested in achieving team goals instead of receiving individual recognition. They contribute ideas and feedback unselfishly. They monitor team progress, including what's going right, what's going wrong, and what to do about it. They celebrate individual and team accomplishments.

• **Accept Ethical Responsibilities**. Teams as a whole have ethical responsibilities to their members, to their larger organizations, and to society. Members have a number of specific responsibilities to each other. As a whole, teams have a responsibility to represent the organization's view and respect its privileged information. They should not discuss with outsiders any sensitive issues without permission.

• **Share leadership**. Members with the most expertise should lead at various times during the project's evolution.

1.5 Planning and participating in face-to- face and virtual meetings

As you prepare to join the workforce, expect to attend meetings—lots of them! Estimates suggest that workers on average spend four hours a week in meetings and consider more than half of that time as wasted. Managers spend even more time in meetings. Studies of executives in Europe and the United States reveal that nearly 60 percent of managers devote 21 to 60 percent of their workweeks to meetings with the average meeting lasting nearly three hours. In one survey, managers considered over a third of meeting time unproductive and reported that two thirds of meetings fell short of their stated objectives. Business meetings consist of three or more people who assemble to pool information, solicit feedback, clarify policy, seek consensus, and solve problems. However, as growing numbers of employees work at distant locations, meetings have changed. Workers cannot always meet face-to-face.

Determining the Purpose of a Meeting

A face-to-face meeting provides the most nonverbal cues and other signals that help us interpret the intended meaning of words. Thus, an in-person meeting is the richest of available media. No meeting should be called unless it is important, can't wait, and requires an exchange of ideas.

• **Selecting Meeting Participants.** The purpose of the meeting determines the number of participants, as shown in Figure 1.9. If the meeting purpose is motivational, such as an awards ceremony for sales reps of cosmetics giant Avon or nutrition supplement seller Herbalife, then the number of participants is potentially unlimited. However, to make decisions, the best

number is no more than eight participants, as studies suggest. For high-stakes decisions, consultants recommend limiting the session to three to six key executives. Ideally, decision makers and people with the information necessary to make the decision should attend. Also attending should be people who will be responsible for implementing the decision and representatives of groups who will benefit from the decision. Let's consider Timberland and its signature employee volunteer program. Company leaders might meet with managers, employee representatives, and community leaders to decide how best to green a community center, improve school grounds, or frame houses for families of tornado victims. Inviting key stakeholders who represent various interests, perspectives, and competencies ensures valuable input and, therefore, is more likely to lead to informed decisions.

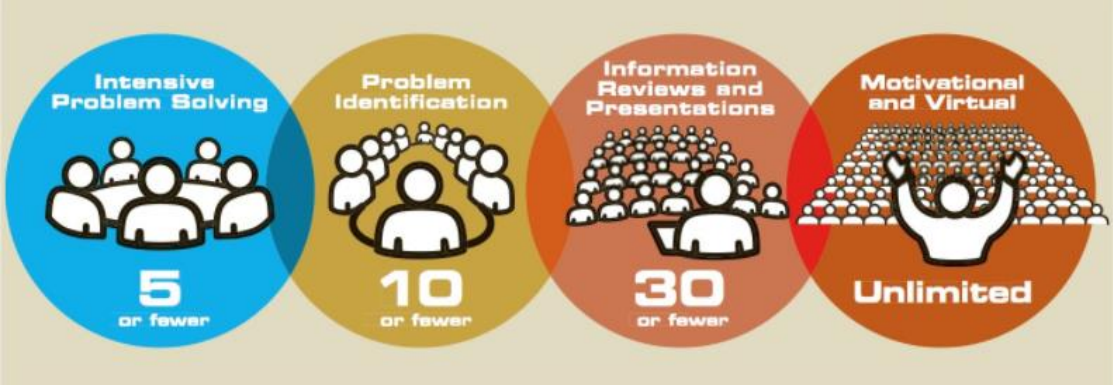


Figure 1.9: Meeting Purpose and Number of Participants

• **Using Digital Calendars to Schedule Meetings.** Finding a time when everyone can meet is often difficult. Fortunately, digital calendars make the task quick and efficient. Popular programs and mobile apps are Google Calendar, Apple Calendar, and the business favorite, Outlook Calendar (shown in Figure 1.10). Online calendars and mobile apps enable users to make appointments, schedule meetings, and keep track of daily activities.

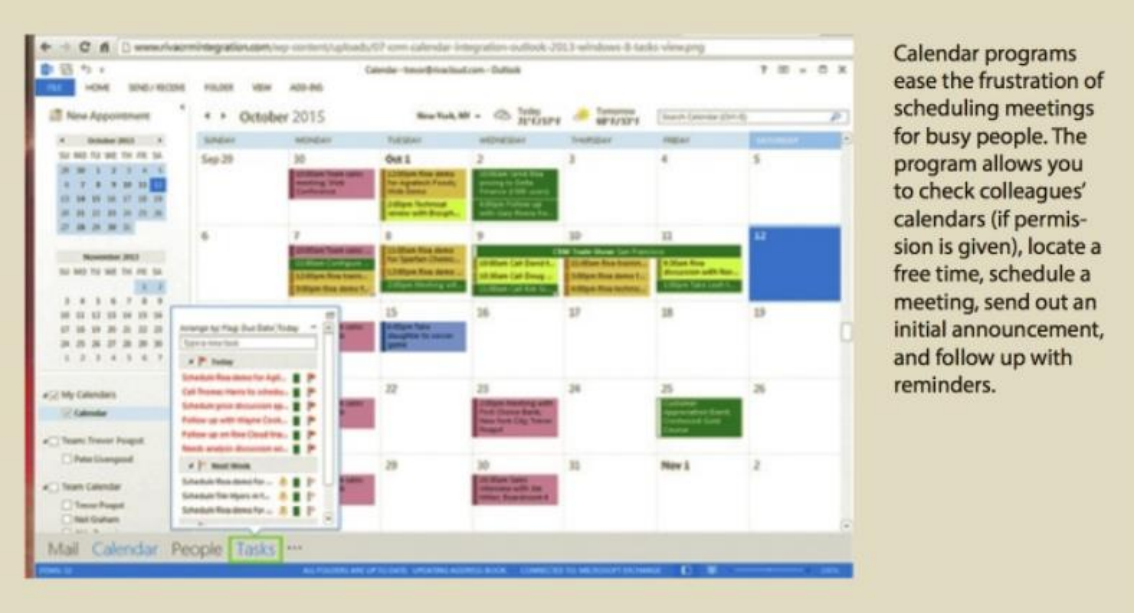
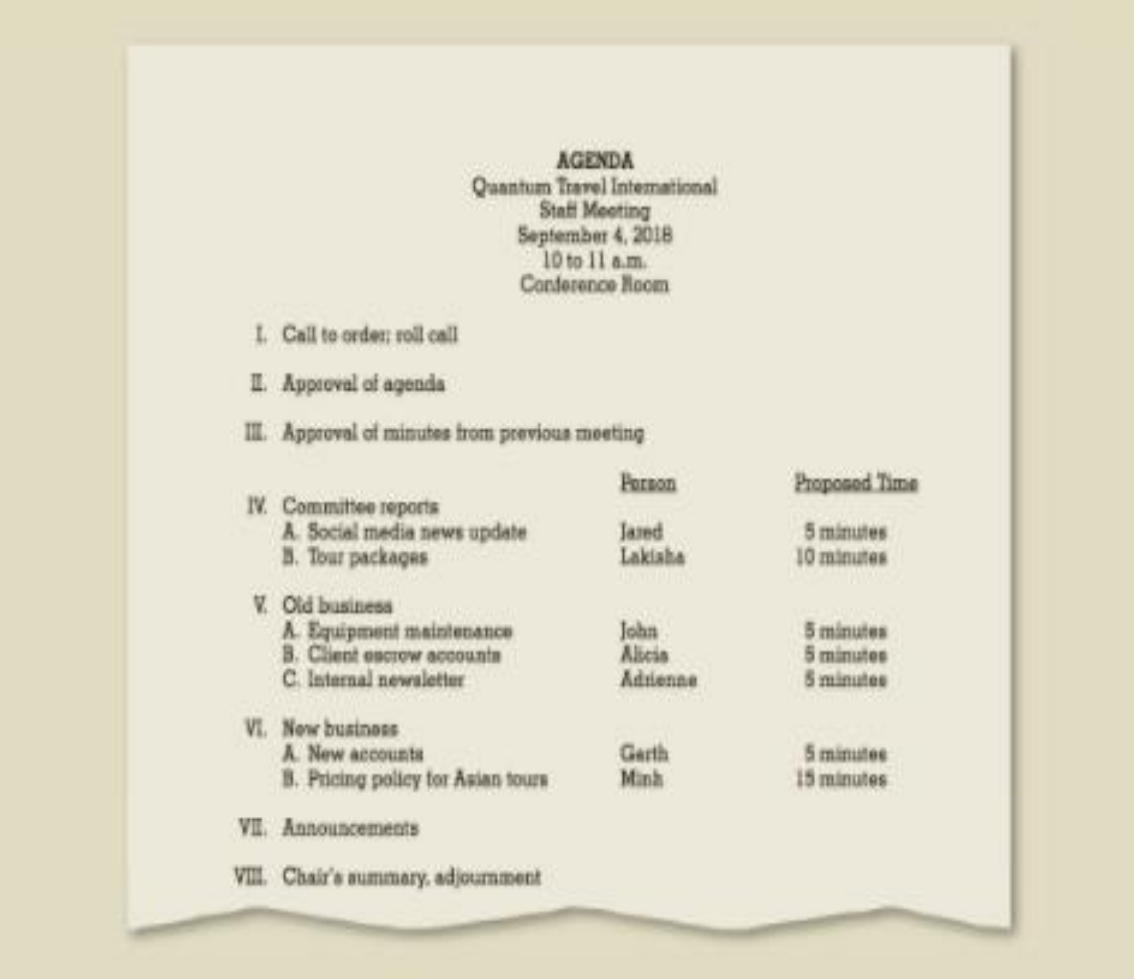


Figure 1.10: Using Calendar Programs

• **Distributing an Agenda and Other Information**. Prepare an agenda that includes the date and place of the meeting, the starting and ending time, a brief description of each topic, the names of the people responsible for any action, and a proposed time allotment for each topic.

A good agenda, as illustrated in Figure 1.11, covers the following information:

- Date and place of meeting
- Start time and end time
- Brief description of each topic, in order of priority, including the names of individuals who are responsible for performing some action
- Proposed allotment of time for each topic
- Any premeeting preparation expected of participants



AGENDA
Quantum Travel International
Staff Meeting
September 4, 2018
10 to 11 a.m.
Conference Room

I. Call to order; roll call

II. Approval of agenda

III. Approval of minutes from previous meeting

	Person	Proposed Time
IV. Committee reports		
A. Social media news update	Jared	5 minutes
B. Tour packages	Lakisha	10 minutes
V. Old business		
A. Equipment maintenance	John	5 minutes
B. Client escrow accounts	Alicia	5 minutes
C. Internal newsletter	Adrienne	5 minutes
VI. New business		
A. New accounts	Garth	5 minutes
B. Pricing policy for Asian tours	Minh	15 minutes

VII. Announcements

VIII. Chair's summary, adjournment

Figure 1.11: Typical Meeting Agenda

Managing the Meeting

Whether you are the meeting leader or a participant, it is important to act professionally during the meeting. Meetings can be more efficient and productive if leaders and participants recognize how to get the meeting started, establish ground rules, move the meeting along, and handle conflict.

• **Getting Started and Establishing Ground Rules.** Even if some participants are missing, start meetings promptly to avoid wasting time and irritating attendees. For the same reasons, don't give quick recaps to latecomers. Open the meeting with a three- to five-minute introduction that includes the following:

- Goal and length of the meeting
- Background of topics or problems
- Possible solutions and constraints
- Tentative agenda
- Ground rules to be followed

• **Moving the Meeting Along.** An effective leader lets others talk and tries to involve all participants. If the group has one member who dominates, the leader might say, Thanks, Gary, for that perspective, but please hold your next point while we hear how Rachel would respond to that. This technique also encourages quieter participants to speak up.

• **Participating Actively and Productively.** Meetings are an opportunity for you to show- case your abilities and boost your career. To get the most out of the meetings you attend, try these techniques:

- **Arrive early.** You show respect and look well organized when you arrive a little early.
- **Come prepared.** Bring the agenda and any distributed materials. Study the topics and be ready with questions, comments, and good ideas.
- **Have a positive attitude.** Use positive body language; speak energetically.
- **Contribute respectfully.** Wait your turn to speak; raise your hand to be recognized.
- **Wait for others to finish.** Show respect and good manners by not interrupting.
- **Keep your voice calm and pleasant, yet energetic.** Avoid showing anger as this focuses attention on your behaviour rather than on your ideas.
- **Give credit to others.** Gain allies and enhance your credibility by recognizing others in front of peers and superiors.
- **Use your cell phone, tablet, and laptop only for meeting-related tasks.** Focus your attention on the meeting, not on answering e-mails or working on your computer.
- **Help summarize.** Assist the meeting leader by reviewing points you have noted.
- **Express your views IN the meeting.** Build trust by not holding post meeting sidebars that involve criticism and judgments.
- Follow up. Send the signal that you are efficient and caring by completing the actions assigned to you.

• **Handling Conflict in Meetings.** As you learned earlier, conflict is natural and even desirable. However, it can also cause awkwardness and uneasiness. In meetings, conflict typically develops when people feel unheard or misunderstood. If two people clash, the best approach is to encourage each to make a complete case while group members give their full attention. Let each one question the other. Then, the leader should summarize what was said, and the participants should offer comments. The group may modify a recommendation or suggest alternatives before reaching consensus on a direction to follow.

• **Concluding and Following Up.** End the meeting at the agreed time or sooner. The leader should summarize all decisions, assigned tasks, and deadlines. It may be necessary to ask attendees to volunteer for completing action items. All participants should understand what was accomplished. One effective technique that encourages full participation is a round-robin in which people take turns summarizing briefly their interpretations of what was decided and what happens next. Of course, this closure technique works best with smaller groups. The leader should conclude by asking the group to set a time for the next meeting. He or she should assure the group that a report will follow. Finally, the leader should thank participants for attending. If minutes were taken, they should be distributed within a couple of days of the meeting. Meeting management programs and mobile apps offer a structured template such as that shown in Figure 1.12, which includes brief meeting minutes, key points and decisions, and action items. The leader needs to ensure that decisions are executed. The leader may need to contact participants to remind them of their assignments and to solicit help if necessary.

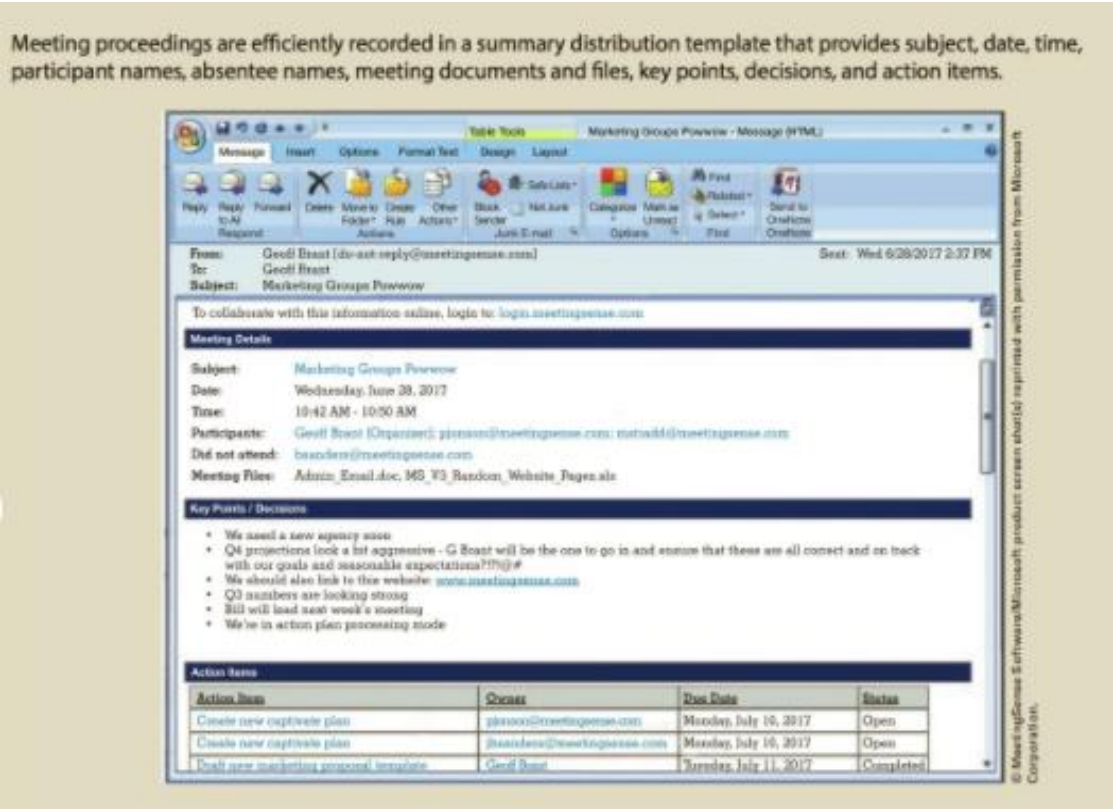


Figure 1.12: E-Mail Meeting Minutes

Preparing for Virtual Meetings

Virtual meetings are real-time gatherings of dispersed participants who connect with communication technology. As travel costs rise and companies slash budgets, many organizations are cutting back on meetings that require travel. Instead, people may meet in audioconferences using telephones or in videoconferences using the Internet. Steady improvements in telecommunications networks, software applications, and bandwidth continue to fuel the shift to virtual meetings. These meetings have many purposes, including training employees, making sales presentations, coordinating team activities, and talking to customers.

The following best practices recommended by experienced meeting facilitators will help you address premeeting issues such as technology glitches, scheduling across time zones, and language challenges.Creating ground rules, anticipating limited media richness, managing turn-taking, and humanizing the interaction with remote members all achieve the best results during virtual meetings.

• **Select the most appropriate technology.** Decide whether audio- or videoconferencing is needed. Choose the appropriate program or application.

• Ensure that all participants are able to use the technology. Coach attendees who may need help before the session begins.

• **Encourage participants to log in 15 minutes early.** Some programs require downloads and installations that can cause immense frustration if not done early.

• **Be aware of different time zones.** Use Coordinated Universal Time (UTC) to minimize confusion resulting from mismatched local times. Avoid spanning a lunch hour or holding someone overtime.

• **Rotate your meeting time to be fair to all dispersed group members.** Ensure that everyone shares the burden of an inconvenient time.

• **Decide what language to use.** If the meeting language maybe difficult for some participants, think about using simple expressions and repeating major ideas. Always follow up in writing.

Read
Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 2: Page56

1.6 Developing professionalism and business etiquette skills at the office and online

Not everyone who seeks a job is aware of the employer's expectations. Some new-hires have no idea that excessive absenteeism or tardiness is grounds for termination. Others are surprised to learn that they are expected to devote their full attention to their duties when on the job. One young man wanted to read Harry Potter novels when things got slow. Many employees don't realize that they are sabotaging their careers when they sprinkle their conversation with like, you know, and uptalk (making declarative statements sound like questions). Projecting and maintaining a professional image can make a real difference in helping you obtain the job of your dreams. Once you get that job, you are more likely to be taken seriously and much more likely to be promoted if you look and sound professional. Do not send the wrong message with unwitting or unprofessional behaviour. Figure 1.13 reviews seven areas you will want to check to be sure you are projecting professionalism.

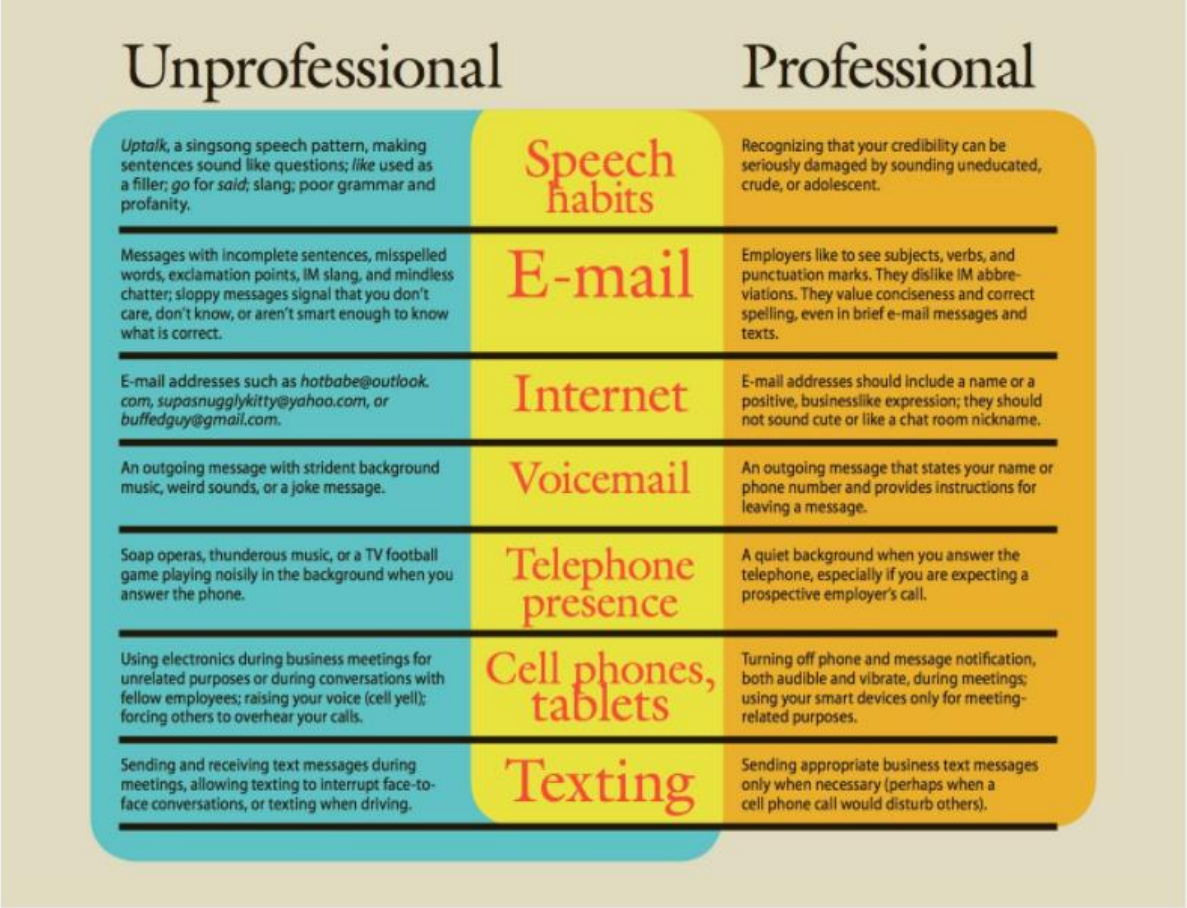


Figure 1.13: Projecting Professionalism When You Communicate

Gaining an Etiquette Edge in a Networked World An awareness of courtesy and etiquette can give you a competitive edge in the job market. Etiquette, civility, and goodwill efforts may seem out of place in today's fast-paced offices. However, when two candidates have equal qualifications, the one who appears to be more polished and professional is more likely to be hired and promoted. As workloads increase and face-to-face meetings decline, bad behaviour is becoming alarmingly common in the American workplace and may exact a high cost "of whittling away at people's health, performance, and souls." One survey showed that 71 percent of workers said they had been insulted, demeaned, ignored, or otherwise treated discourteously by their co-workers and supervisors. Employers, of course, suffer from the resulting drop in productivity and exodus of talent. Employees, too, suffer. They worry about incidents, think about changing jobs, and cut back their efforts on the job. Workplace rudeness also turns customers away. Businesses are responding to increasing incidents of desk rage and cyberbullying in American workplaces by establishing policies to enforce civility. In short, it is not hard to understand why employers are looking for people who are courteous, polite, respectful, and well mannered. Figure 1.14 summarizes the many components of professional workplace behaviour and identifies six main dimensions that will ease your entry into the world of work.



Figure 1.14: The Six Dimensions of Professional Behaviour

Good manners, on the other hand, convey a positive image of an organization. People like to do business with those who show respect and treat others politely. Most of us also like to work in a pleasant environment.

You don't have to become an etiquette nut, but you might need to polish your social competencies a little to be an effective businessperson today. Here are a few simple pointers:

• **Use polite words.** Be generous with words and phrases such as please, thank you, and you're welcome.

• **Express sincere appreciation and praise.** Tell co-workers how much you appreciate their efforts. Remember that written and specific thank-you notes are even better than saying thanks.

• **Be selective in sharing personal information.** Avoid talking about health concerns, personal relationships, or finances in the office.

• **Don't put people down.** If you have a reputation for criticizing people, your co-workers will begin to wonder what you are saying behind their backs.

• **Respect co-workers' space.** Turn down the ringer on your business phone, minimize the use of speakerphones, and turn your personal cell phone down or off during business hours. Avoid wearing heavy perfumes or bringing strong-smelling food.

• **Rise above others' rudeness.** Don't use profanity or participate in questionable joke-telling.

• **Be considerate when sharing space and equipment with others.** Clean up after yourself.

• **Choose the high road in conflict.** Avoid letting discussions degenerate into shouting matches. Keep a calm voice tone and focus on the work rather than on personality differences.

• **Disagree agreeably.** You may not agree with everyone, but you should respect their opinions.

1.7 The growing importance of intercultural communication

To drive profits, many organizations are expanding overseas. The global village predicted many years ago is here, making intercultural communication skills ever more important. Especially in North America, but also around the world, the movement toward a global economy has swelled to a torrent. If you visit a European or Asian city, you will see many familiar U.S. chains such as The Gap, Subway, Abercrombie & Fitch, Guess, Dunkin' Donuts, Apple, and KFC. To be immediately competitive, some companies formed multinational alliances. For example, Starbucks joined forces with Tata Global Beverages to form a joint venture called Tata Starbucks Limited, operating as Starbucks Coffee, A Tata Alliance.

However, as Walmart and many others learned, expanding companies sometimes stumble when they cross borders and are forced to surmount obstacles never before encountered. Confusion and clashes can result from intercultural differences. You may face such intercultural differences in your current or future jobs. Your employers, co-workers, or customers could very well be from other countries and cultures. You may travel abroad for your employer or on your own. Learning more about the powerful effect culture has on behaviour will help you reduce friction and misunderstanding in your dealings with people from other cultures. Before examining strategies for helping you overcome intercultural obstacles, let's take a closer look at globalization and the trends fuelling it.

Major Trends Fuel Globalization

Although some companies fail, many domestic and international businesses are rushing to expand around the world. As summarized in Figure 1.15, aside from shrinking domestic markets, several trends fuel global expansion including favorable trade agreements, growing numbers of middle-class consumers in emerging nations, transportation advancements, and increasingly sophisticated information and communication technologies.



Figure 1.15: Trends Fuelling Globalization

• **Favourable Trade Agreements.** A significant factor in the expansion of global markets is the passage of favourable trade agreements. The General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) promotes open trade globally, and the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) expands free trade among Canada, the United States, and Mexico. NAFTA has created one of the largest and richest free-trade regions on earth. Additional trade agreements are causing markets to expand. At this writing the United States has 14 free trade agreements (FTAs) in force with 20 countries, with more to come, most prominently the Transatlantic Trade and Investment Partnership (TTIP) between the European Union and the United States. These agreements significantly open global markets to imports and exports.

• **An Emerging Global Middle Class.** Parts of the world formerly considered developing now boast robust middle classes. Once known only for cheap labor, many countries with emerging economies are now seen as promising markets. Estimates suggest that 70 percent of world growth over the next few years will come from emerging markets.

•**Advancements in Transportation and Logistics.** Of paramount importance in explaining the explosive growth of global markets are advancements in transportation and logistics. Supersonic planes carry goods and passengers to other continents overnight. Breakthroughs in transportation technology also push the drive toward globalization. For example, digital wireless sensor telemetry keeps shippers informed of vital information en route. Senders can track the destination, the speed of movement, and even the temperature of a shipment's environment. This technology expands markets by enabling senders to monitor shipments and learn of delays or harmful conditions for the goods being shipped.

•**Growing Reach of Information and Communication Technologies.** Probably the most significant factor fuelling globalization is the development of information and communication technologies. These technologies have changed the way we live and do business with the help of the Internet, wireless networks, smartphones, mobile electronic devices, and other

communication media. High-speed, high-capacity, and relatively low-cost communications have opened new global opportunities that make geographic location virtually irrelevant for many activities and services. Workers have access to company records, software programs, and colleagues whether they're working at home, in the office, or at the beach.

1.8 Becoming interculturally proficient

Remember that culture is learned. Developing cultural competence often involves changing attitudes. Through exposure to other cultures and through training, such as you are receiving in this course, you can learn new attitudes and behaviors that help bridge gaps between cultures. Following are some suggestions to help you boost your intercultural savvy.

•**Building Cultural Self-Awareness.** Begin to think of yourself as a product of your culture, and understand that your culture is just one among many. Take any opportunity to travel or study abroad, if possible. You will learn much, not only about other cultures but also about your own.

•**Building Cultural Self-Awareness.** Begin to think of yourself as a product of your culture, and understand that your culture is just one among many. Take any opportunity to travel or study abroad, if possible. You will learn much, not only about other cultures but also about your own. Ethnocentrism causes us to judge others by our own values. We expect others to react as we would, and they expect us to behave as they would. Misunderstandings naturally result.

•**Understanding Generalizations and Stereotyping.** Most experts recognize that it is impossible to talk about cultures without using mental categories, representations, and generalizations. These categories are sometimes considered stereotypes. A stereotype is an oversimplified behavioural pattern applied uncritically to groups. Although they may be exaggerated and overgeneralized beliefs when applied to groups of people, stereotypes are not always entirely false. Often they contain a grain of truth. When a stereotype develops into a rigid attitude and when it is based on erroneous beliefs or preconceptions, however, then it should be called a prejudice. Some people object to making any generalizations about cultures whatsoever. It is wise to remember, however, that whenever we are confronted with something new and unfamiliar, we naturally strive to categorize the data to make sense of them. In categorizing these new data, we are making generalizations.

•**Being Open-Minded.** One desirable attitude in achieving intercultural proficiency is that of tolerance. Closed-minded people cannot look beyond their own ethnocentrism. But as global markets expand and as our own society becomes increasingly multi-ethnic, tolerance becomes especially significant. To improve tolerance, you will want to practice empathy. This means trying to see the world through another's eyes. It means being less judgmental and more eager to seek common ground. One way to promote greater understanding is to work toward a common goal and, as a result, learn about each other.

•**Saving Face.** In business transactions North Americans often assume that economic factors are the primary motivators of people. It is wise to remember, though, that strong cultural influences are also at work. Saving face, for example, is important in many parts of the world. Face refers to the image a person holds in his or her social network. Positive comments raise a person's social standing, but negative comments lower it.

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 3: Page 96

1.9 Culture and ethical business practices

As companies do more and more business around the globe, their assumptions about ethics are put to the test. Businesspeople may face simple questions regarding the appropriate amount of money to spend on a business gift or the legitimacy of payments to agents and distributors to "expedite" business. They may also encounter out-and-out bribery, child labor abuse, environment mistreatment, and unscrupulous business practices.

Today most companies that are active in global markets have ethical codes of conduct. These codes are public documents and can usually be found on company websites. They are an accepted part of governance. The growing sophistication of these codes results in ethics training programs that often include complicated hypothetical questions. Ethics trainers teach employees to solve problems by reconciling legal requirements, company policies, and conflicting cultural norms.

Ethical Decision Making Across Borders

Instead of trying to distinguish good ethics and bad ethics, perhaps the best plan is to look for practical solutions to the cultural challenges of global business interaction. Following are suggestions that acknowledge different values but also respect the need for moral initiative.

• **Broaden your view.** Become more sensitive to the values and customs of other cultures. Look especially at what they consider moral, traditional, practical, and effective.

• **Avoid reflex judgments.** Don't automatically judge the business customs of others as immoral, corrupt, or unworkable. Assume that they are legitimate and workable until proved otherwise.

• **Find alternatives.** Instead of caving in to government pay offs, perhaps offer nonmonetary public service benefits, technical expertise, or additional customer service.

• **Refuse business if options violate your basic values.** If an action seriously breaches your own code of ethics or that of your firm, give up the transaction.

• **Embrace transparency.** Conduct all relations and negotiations as openly as possible.

• Don't rationalize shady decisions. Avoid agreeing to actions that cause you to say, this isn't really illegal or immoral, this is in the company's best interest, or No one will find out.

• **Resist legalistic strategies.** Don't use tactics that are legally safe but ethically question- able. For example, don't call agents (who are accountable to employers) distributors (who are not).

1.10 Workforce Diversity: Benefits and challenges

While North American companies are expanding global operations, and adapting to a variety of emerging markets, the domestic workforce is also becoming more diverse. This diversity has many dimensions—race, ethnicity, age, religion, gender, national origin, physical ability, sexual orientation, and others. No longer, say the experts, will the workplace be predominantly Anglo oriented or male.

Diversity and Its Advantages

As society and the workforce become more diverse, successful interactions and communication among identity groups bring distinct advantages in three areas.

Consumers. A diverse staff is better able to read trends and respond to the increasingly diverse customer base in local and world markets. Diverse consumers now want goods and services tailored to their needs. Teams made up of people with different experiences are better equipped to create products that these markets require. Consumers also want to deal with companies that respect their values and reflect themselves.

•**Work teams.** Team members with different backgrounds may come up with more innovative and effective solutions than homogeneous teams.

•**Business Organizations.** Companies that set aside time and resources to cultivate and capitalize on diversity suffer fewer discrimination lawsuits, fewer union clashes, and less government regulatory action. Most important, though, is the growing realization among organizations that diversity is a critical bottom-line business strategy to improve employee relationships and increase productivity.

Improving Communication Among Diverse Workplace Audiences

Harmony and acceptance do not happen automatically when people who are dissimilar work together. This means that organizations must commit to diversity. Harnessed effectively, diversity can enhance productivity and propel a company to success.

• **Seek training.** Especially if an organization is experiencing diversity problems, aware-ness-raising sessions may be helpful. Spend time reading and learning about workforce diversity and how it can benefit organizations. Look upon diversity as an opportunity, not a threat. Intercultural communication, team building, and conflict resolution are skills that can be learned in diversity training programs.

• **Understand the value of differences.** Diversity makes an organization innovative and creative. Diversity in problem-solving groups encourages independent and creative thinking.

• **Don't expect conformity.** Gone are the days when businesses could say, "This is our culture. Conform or leave." Paul Fireman, former CEO of Reebok, stressed seeking people who have new and different stories to tell. "And then you have to make real room for them, you have to learn to listen, to listen closely, to their stories. It accomplishes next to nothing to employ those

who are different from us if the condition of their employment is that they become the same as us.

• **Make fewer assumptions.** Be careful of seemingly insignificant, innocent workplace assumptions. For example, don't assume that everyone wants to observe the holidays with a Christmas party and a decorated tree. Celebrating only Christian holidays in December and January excludes those who honor Hanukkah, Kwanzaa, and the Lunar New Year. Moreover, in workplace discussions don't assume anything about others' sexual orientation or attitude toward marriage. For invitations, avoid phrases such as managers and their wives. Spouses or partners is more inclusive. Valuing diversity means making fewer assumptions that everyone is like you or wants to be like you

• **Build on similarities.** Look for areas in which you and others not like you can agree or at least share opinions. Be prepared to consider issues from many perspectives, all of which may be valid. Accept that there is room for different points of view to coexist peacefully. Although you can always find differences, it is much harder to find similarities. Look for common ground in shared experiences, mutual goals, and similar values. Concentrate on your objective even when you may disagree on how to reach it.



Chapter Summary/Review

1. Explain how communication skills fuel career success, and understand why writing skills are vital in a digital, mobile, and social-media-driven workplace.

• Communication skills matter more than ever before as communication technology has provided businesspeople with unprecedented mobility and workers write more, not less.

• Superior communication skills are critical to job placement, performance, career advancement, and organizational success; they can set you apart from other candidates.

2. Identify the tools for success in the hyper-connected 21st-century work- place; appreciate the importance of critical-thinking skills and personal credibility in the competitive job market of the digital age; and discuss how your education may determine your income.

• Accessing and sharing various digital media from a vast network of sources and distributing them nearly instantly to widespread audiences have never been easier.

• Expect to be a knowledge worker who must think critically and develop opinions backed by evidence.

3. Explain and apply active listening techniques.

• Most of us are poor listeners; careers and organizational success depend on active listening.

• A fast processing speed allows us to let our minds wander; as untrained listeners, we are easily distracted.

4. Understand how effective nonverbal communication can help you advance your career.

• Be aware of nonverbal cues such as eye contact, facial expression, and posture that send silent, highly believable messages.

• Understand that how you use time, space, and territory is interpreted by the receiver, who also reads the eye appeal of your business documents and your personal appearance.

5. Grasp the complexities of ethics across cultures, including business practices abroad, bribery, prevailing customs, and methods for coping.

- Doing business abroad, businesspeople should expect differing views about ethical practices.
- To uphold sound ethical principles abroad, businesspeople should broaden their understanding of values and customs in other cultures and avoid reflex judgments regarding the morality or corruptness of actions.

6. Explain the advantages and challenges of workforce diversity, and address approaches for improving communication among diverse workplace audiences.

- A diverse workforce can benefit consumers, work teams, and business organizations.
- Diversity can also cause discord among identity groups.



Review Questions (Short)

1. What could be the career fallout for someone who is unwilling or unable to train to become a better communicator? Can workers today be successful if their writing is and remains poor?
2. Sharing various digital media impulsively can lead to embarrassment and worse. Have you or has someone you know ever regretted posting a comment, photo, or other media online?
3. What arguments could you give for or against the idea that body language is a science with principles that specialists can interpret accurately?
4. It is quite natural to favour one's own country over a foreign one. To what extent can ethnocentrism be considered a normal reaction, and when could it become destructive and unproductive? Provide examples to support your answer.
5. Some economists and management scholars argue that statements such as diversity is an economic asset or diversity is a new strategic imperative are unproved and perhaps unprovable assertions. Should social responsibility or market forces determine whether an organization strives to create a diverse workforce? Why?

Review Questions (Long)

1. Your instructor wants to know more about you, your motivation for taking this course, your career goals, and your writing skills.
Send an e-mail or write a memo of introduction to your instructor. See Appendix In your message include the following:

a. Your reasons for taking this class
b. Your career goals (both temporary and long-term)
c. A brief description of your employment, if any, and your favourite activities
d. Discussion of your current communication skills, including your strengths and weaknesses.

2. What do employers request when they list job openings in your field?
3. When hiring future workers, employers look for hard skills and soft skills. Studies have divided soft skills into four categories:

• Thinking and problem solving
• Oral and written communication
• Personal qualities and work ethic
• Interpersonal and teamwork

Using the preceding categories to guide you, identify your own soft skills, paying attention to those you think a potential employer would value. Prepare lists of at least four items in each of the four categories.
4. In light of what you have learned in this chapter, how should you act in the following situations? Are the actions legal or illegal?

a. Your company is moving toward final agreement on a contract in Pakistan to sell farm equipment. As the contract is prepared, officials ask that a large amount be included to enable the government to update its agriculture research. The extra amount is to be paid in cash to the three officials you have worked with. Should your company pay?
b. You are trying to collect an overdue payment of $163,000 on a shipment of milk powder to the Dominican Republic. A senior government official asks for $20,000 as a collection service fee. Should you pay?

Case Studies / Projects

Lyft Epitomizes the Sharing Economy and Teamwork

Today's sharing economy, an economic model in which individuals rent or borrow an asset owned by another, is upending entire industries, especially transportation. While Uber started the game-changing idea of ride sharing, the irreverent company Lyft, known for its magenta mustache branding, epitomizes the upheaval. The high-tech, San Francisco–based business is itself a model of sharing. Consumers request a ride using the Lyft app, and minutes later a Lyft driver in the area appears. Riders avoid the hassle of driving, and drivers make some cash. The simple idea is working, as the company has enjoyed a fivefold growth in its first two years of existence and shows no signs of slowing down. This success can be attributed in no small part to teamwork. Lyft so values teamwork that part of the test new-hires must pass is a culture fit to determine whether they share the Lyft ethos of collaboration and mutual respect. Cofounder and CEO Logan Green says, "When we build a team, we look for incredibly smart, compassionate people who are all motivated by the same goal."

REQUIRED:

• What is meant by the term culture fit, and why is it beneficial for both employer and employee?

• What individual behaviours lead to effective teams?

• What factors unique to virtual teams contribute to their success?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 2: Page 43



LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Understand the nature of communication and its barriers in the digital era.
- Analyse the purpose of a message, anticipate its audience, and select the best communication channel.
- Generate and organize ideas resulting from techniques such as brainstorming and brainwriting along with social media techniques such as crowdsourcing, crowdstorming, and crowdfunding.
- Improve your writing techniques by emphasizing important ideas, employing the active and passive voice effectively, using parallelism, and preventing dangling and misplaced modifiers.
- Recognize proofreading problem areas, and apply effective techniques to catch mistakes in both routine and complex documents.
- Evaluate a message to judge its effectiveness.

Introduction

No one would argue that the digital revolution has not profoundly changed the way we live, the methods we use to conduct business, and especially the way we communicate. For instance, staff members and college interns use videos, Facebook, Twitter, blogs, and e-mail to communicate with each other and create buzz with customers and fans.

As the world becomes increasingly interconnected, people are sending a staggering number of messages often delivered over social media platforms. However, even as we have accepted instant messaging, texting, Twitter, and other interactive media, the nature of communication remains unchanged. No matter how we create or send our messages, the basic communication process consists of the same elements. It starts with an idea that must be transmitted.

2.1 Understanding the communication process

In its simplest form, communication may be defined as the transmission of information and meaning from a sender to a receiver. The crucial element in this definition is meaning. The process is successful only when the receiver understands an idea as the sender intended it. How does an idea travel from one person to another? It involves a sensitive process, shown in Figure 2.1. This process can easily be side-tracked resulting in miscommunication. The process of communication, however, is successful when both the sender and receiver understand the process and how to make it work. In our discussion we are most concerned with professional communication in the workplace so that you can be successful as a business communicator in your career.



Figure 2.1: The Communication Process

Barriers That Create Misunderstanding

The communication process is successful only when the receiver understands the message as intended by the sender. It sounds quite simple–yet it's not. Most messages that we send reach their destinations, but many are only partially understood. You can improve your chances of communicating successfully by learning to recognize barriers that are known to disrupt the

process. Some of the most significant barriers for individuals are bypassing, differing frames of reference, lack of language skill, and distractions.

• **Bypassing**. An important barrier to clear communication involves words. Each of us attaches a little bundle of meanings to every word, and these meanings are not always similar. Bypassing happens when people miss each other with their meanings. Let's say your boss asks you to help with a large customer mailing. When you arrive to do your share, you learn that you are expected to do the whole mailing yourself. You and your boss attached different meanings to the word help. Bypassing can lead to major miscommunication because people assume that meanings are contained in words. For communication to be successful, the receiver and sender must attach the same symbolic meanings to their words.

• **Differing Frames of Reference**. Another barrier to clear communication is your frame of reference. Everything you see and feel in the world is translated through your individual frame of reference. Your unique frame is formed by a combination of your experiences, education, culture, expectations, personality, and other elements. As a result, you bring your own biases and expectations to any communication situation. Because your frame of reference is different from everyone else's, you will never see things exactly as others do. Wise business communicators strive to prevent miscommunication by being alert to both their own frames of reference and those of others.

• **Lack of Language Skill**. No matter how extraordinary the idea is, it won't be under- stood or fully appreciated unless the communicators involved have good language skills. Each individual needs an adequate vocabulary and skill in oral and written expression. Using unfamiliar words, jargon, and unrecognizable abbreviations can seriously impede the transmission of meaning.

• **Distractions.** Other communication barriers are emotional interference, physical distractions, and digital interruptions. Shaping an intelligent message is difficult when one is feeling joy, fear, resentment, hostility, sadness, or some other strong emotion. To reduce the influence of emotions on communication, both senders and receivers should focus on the content of the message and try to remain objective. Physical distractions such as faulty acoustics, noisy surroundings, or a poor mobile connection can disrupt oral communication. Similarly, sloppy appearance, poor printing, careless formatting, and typographical or spelling errors can disrupt written messages. What's more, technology doesn't seem to be helping. In this digital era, knowledge workers are increasingly distracted by multitasking, information overload, conflicting demands, and being constantly available digitally. Clear communication requires focusing on what is important and shutting out interruptions.

2.2 Analyzing and anticipating the audience

A good writer anticipates the audience for a message: What is the reader or listener like? How will that person react to the message? Although one can't always know exactly who the receiver is, it is possible to imagine some of that person's characteristics. Profiling your audience is a pivotal step in the writing process. The questions in Figure 2.2 will help you profile your audience.

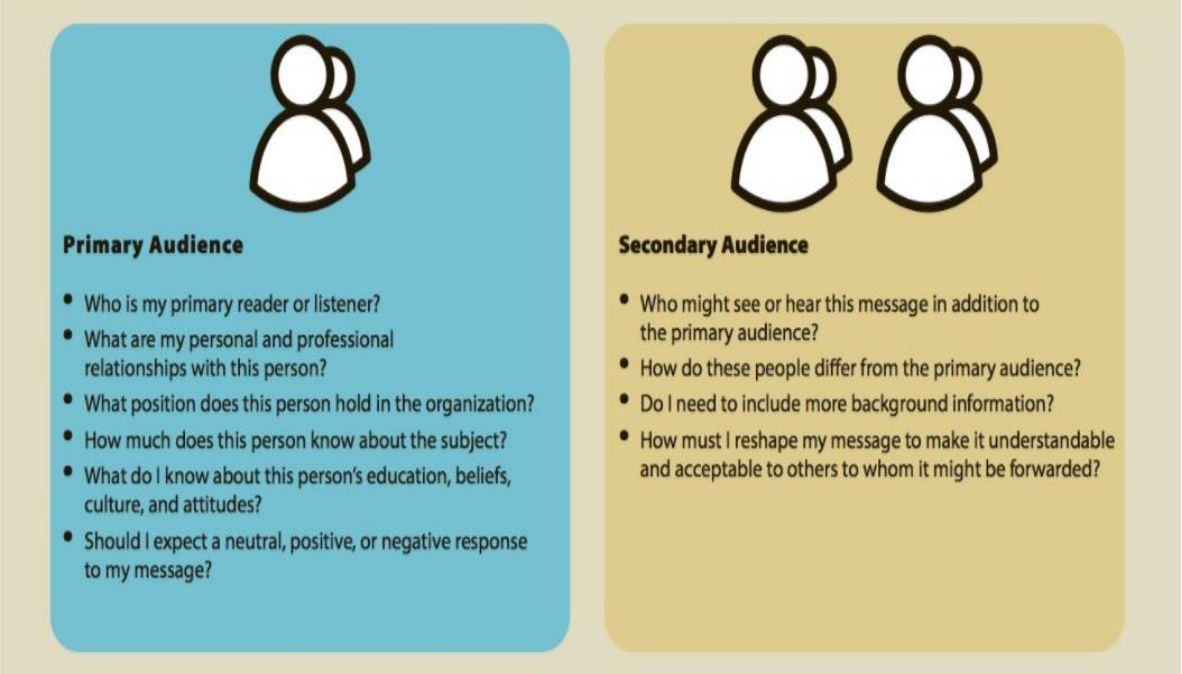


Figure 2.2: Asking the Right Questions to Profile Your Audience

Making Choices Based on the Audience Profile

Profiling your audience helps you make decisions about shaping the message. You will discover what language is appropriate, whether you are free to use specialized technical terms, whether you should explain the background, and so on. Profiling the audience helps you decide whether your tone should be formal or informal. Profiling helps you consider whether the receiver is likely to respond positively or negatively to your message, or be neutral about it.

Selecting the Best Channel

After identifying the purpose of your message, you will want to select the most appropriate communication channel. In this digital era, the number of channels continues to expand, as shown in Figure 2.3. Your decision to send an e-mail message, schedule a videoconference, post a note on the company intranet, or use some other channel depends on some of the following factors:

• Importance of the message

• Amount and speed of feedback and interactivity required

• Necessity of a permanent record

• Cost of the channel

• Degree of formality desired

• Confidentiality and sensitivity of the message

• Receiver's preference and level of technical expertise

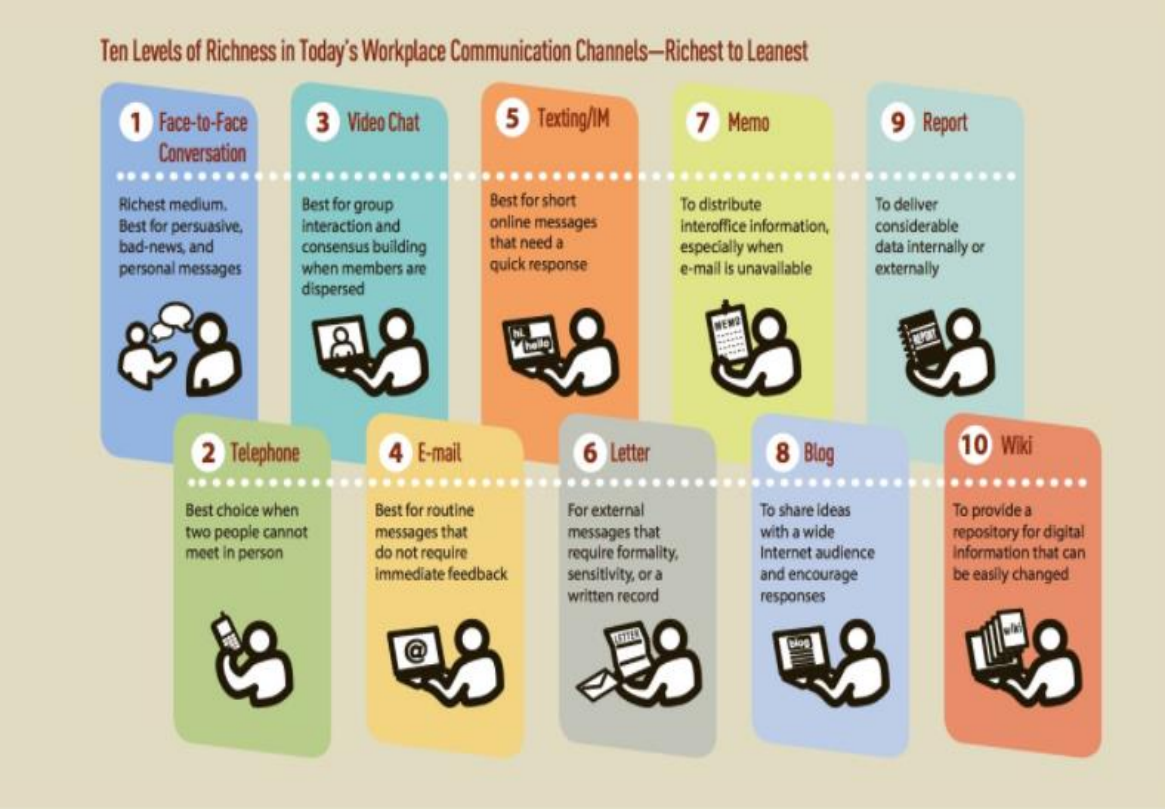


Figure 2.3: Comparing Rich and Lean Communication Channels

2.3 Using expert writing techniques to adapt to your audience

Adapting your message to the receiver's needs means putting yourself in that person's shoes. It's called empathy. Empathic senders think about how a receiver will decode a message. They try to give something to the receiver, solve the receiver's problems, save the receiver's money, or just understand the feelings and position of that person. Which version of each of the following messages is more appealing to the audience?

Sender Focus	Audience Focus
We are instructing herewith all employees to fill out the attached survey completely and immediately so that we can allocate our limited training resource funds appropriately.	By filling out the attached survey, you can be one of the first employees to sign up for our limited training resource funds.
Our warranty on our mobile device becomes effective only when we receive an owner's registration.	Your warranty on your mobile device begins working for you as soon as you return your owner's registration.
We are proud to announce our new real-time virus scanner that we think is the best on the market!	Now you can be sure that all your computers will be protected with our real-time virus scanner.

Sounding Conversational but Professional

Most of the business messages you write replace conversation. Thus, they are most effective when they convey an informal, conversational tone instead of a formal, pretentious tone. Just how informal you can be depends greatly on the workplace.

To project a professional image, you want to sound educated and mature. The overuse of expressions such as totally awesome, you know, and like, as well as a reliance on unnecessary abbreviations (BTW for by the way), make a businessperson sound like a teenager. Professional messages do not include texting-style abbreviations, slang, sentence fragments, and chitchat. We urge you to strive for a warm, conversational tone that avoids low-level diction. Levels of diction, as shown in Figure 2.4, range from unprofessional to formal.

Unprofessional (Low-level diction)	Conversational (Middle-level diction)	Formal (High-level diction)
badmouth	criticize	denigrate
guts	nerve	courage
pecking order	line of command	dominance hierarchy
ticked off	upset	provoked
rat on	inform	betray
rip off	steal	expropriate
If we just hang in there, we'll snag the contract.	If we don't get discouraged, we'll win the contract.	If the principals persevere, they will secure the contract.

Figure 2.4: Levels of Diction

Your goal is a warm, friendly tone that sounds professional. Although some writers are too casual, others are overly formal. To impress readers and listeners, they use big words, long sentences, legal terminology, and third-person constructions. Stay away from expressions such as the undersigned, the writer, and the affected party. You will sound friendlier with familiar pronouns such as I, we, and you. The following examples illustrate a professional yet conversational tone:

Unprofessional	Professional
Hey, boss, Gr8 news! Firewall now installed!! BTW, check with me b4 announcing it.	Mr. Lopez, our new firewall software is now installed. Please check with me before announcing it.
Look, dude, this report is totally bogus. And the figures don't look kosher. Show me some real stats. Got sources?	Because the figures in this report seem inaccurate, please submit the source statistics.

Overly Formal	Conversational
All employees are herewith instructed to return the appropriately designated contracts to the undersigned.	Please return your contracts to me.
Pertaining to your order, we must verify the sizes that your organization requires prior to consignment of your order to our shipper.	We will send your order as soon as we confirm the sizes you need.

Using Precise, Vigorous Words

Strong verbs and concrete nouns give receivers more information and keep them interested. Don't overlook the thesaurus (or the thesaurus program on your computer) for expanding your word choices and vocabulary. Whenever possible, use specific words, as shown here.

Imprecise, Dull	More Precise
a change in profits	a 25 percent hike in profits a 10 percent plunge in profits
to say	to promise, confess, understand to allege, assert, assume, judge
to think about	to identify, diagnose, analyze to probe, examine, inspect

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 4: Page 145

2.4 Beginning with research

No smart businessperson would begin drafting a message before gathering background information. We call this process research, a rather formal-sounding term. For our purposes, however, research simply means collecting information about a certain topic. This is an important step in the writing process because that information helps the writer shape the having to start over and reorganize. To avoid frustration and inaccurate messages, writers collect information that answers several questions:

• What does the receiver need to know about this topic?

• What is the receiver to do?

• How is the receiver to do it?

• When must the receiver do it?

• What will happen if the receiver doesn't do it?

What Are Informal Research Methods?

Many routine tasks—such as drafting e-mails, memos, letters, informational reports, and oral presentations—require information that you can collect informally. Where can you find information before starting a project? The following techniques are useful in informal research:

• **Search your company's files**. If you are responding to an inquiry or drafting a routine message, you often can find background information such as previous correspondence in your own files or those of the company. You might consult the company wiki or other digital and manual files. You might also consult colleagues.

• **Talk with the boss**. Get information from the individual making the assignment. What does that person know about the topic? What slant should you take? What other sources would that person suggest?

• **Interview the target audience**. Consider talking with individuals at whom the message is aimed. They can provide clarifying information that tells you what they want to know and how you should shape your remarks.

• **Conduct an informal survey**. Gather unscientific but helpful information through questionnaires, telephone surveys, or online surveys. In preparing a report predicting the success of a proposed company fitness center, for example, you might circulate a questionnaire asking for employee reactions.

What Are Formal Research Methods?

Long reports and complex business problems generally require formal research methods. To conduct formal research, consider the following research options:

• **Access digital sources**. Torrents of information are available online. A Google search for nearly any topic presents an overwhelming amount of information. Beyond Google, college and public libraries provide digital retrieval services that permit access to a wide array of books,

scholarly journals, magazines, newspapers, and other online literature. With so much data drowning today's researchers, they struggle to decide what is current, relevant, and credible.

• **Search manually**. Valuable background and supplementary information is available through manual searching of resources in public and college libraries. These traditional sources include books and newspaper, magazine, and journal articles. Other sources are encyclopedias, reference books, handbooks, dictionaries, directories, and almanacs.

• **Investigate primary sources**. To develop firsthand, primary information for a project, go directly to the source. In helping to launch a crowdsourcing program at MyEvent. com, you might check out competing sites. You would check blogs, Twitter, Facebook, and newspapers to learn about circumstances leading to crowdsourcing. You could also use questionnaires, interviews, or focus groups. Big companies about to launch a new product such as an energy drink might conduct extensive market research, including scientific sampling methods that enable them to make accurate judgments and valid predictions.

• **Conduct scientific experiments**. Another source of primary data is experimentation. Instead of merely asking for the target audience's opinion, scientific researchers present choices with controlled variables. Assume, for example, that the management team at Jamba Juice wants to know at what price and under what circumstances consumers would purchase smoothies from Jamba Juice instead of from Blenders in the Grass. Instead of smoothies, let's say that Lands' End management wants to study the time of year and type of weather conditions that motivate consumers to begin purchasing sweaters, jackets, and cold weather gear. The results of such experimentation would provide valuable data for managerial decision making.

2.5 Generating Ideas and Organizing Information

Not all information for making decisions is available through research. Often fresh ideas to solve problems must be generated. For example, how can we expand our business into mobile technologies? How can we cut costs without losing market share? Should we radically reinvent our website? For years organizations have tried to solve problems and generate ideas in group discussions. Two methods have prevailed.

Brainstorming and Brainwriting

Traditionally, groups have generated ideas by **brainstorming**, which may be defined as the spontaneous contribution of ideas from members of a group. Here's how the technique works. A group gathers to solve a problem, and every member strives to present as many ideas as possible. The emphasis is on quantity, not quality. The ideas are then evaluated, and the best are selected. Critics, however, charge that brainstorming in this traditional format doesn't work. It results in the "loudmouth meeting-hog phenomenon," in which one extrovert dominates the conversation. Not only can one person dominate the session, but early ideas tend to sway the group. "It's called anchoring, and it crushes originality," claimed Professor Leigh Thompson in a Fast Company interview. Brainstorming favors first ideas, thus promoting groupthink and limiting fresh avenues of thought.

To overcome the shortcomings of traditional brainstorming, some critics champion **brainwriting**. This creativity technique involves writing out ideas rather than speaking them.

Supporters claim that brainwriting generates far more creative ideas than traditional brainstorming. Its emphasis is on writing first and discussing afterward. Notice in Figure 2.5 that brainstorming and brainwriting have much in common. The chief difference is in how the ideas are presented: orally or in writing. Brainstorming can be a wild affair with visionary off-the-wall suggestions, whereas brainwriting is quieter and more thoughtful. Both techniques, however, end in the same place—with the selection of the best ideas.

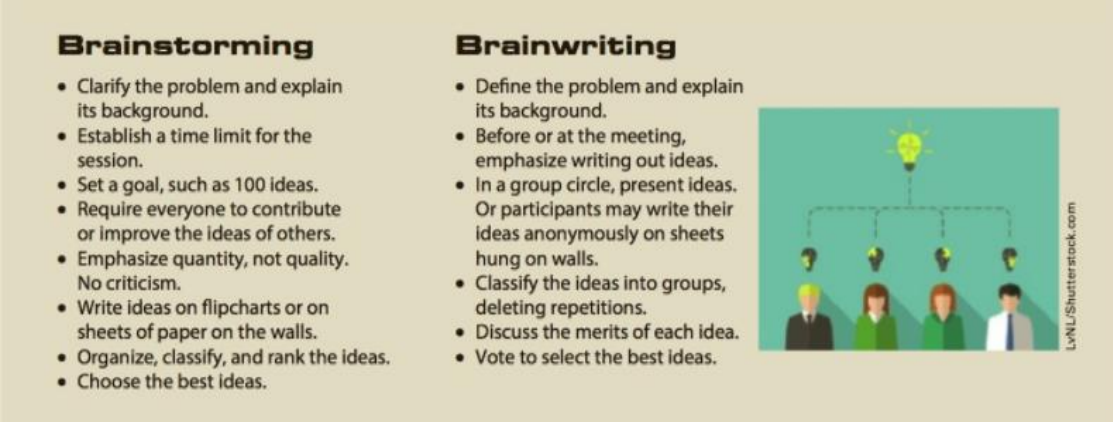


Figure 2.5: Comparing Brainstorming and Brainwriting to Solve Problems

Crowdsourcing, Crowdstorming, and Crowdfunding

Closely related to brainstorming and brainwriting are three collaborative efforts with similar-sounding names that arose with the spread of social media networks. **Crowdsourcing** describes the practice of requesting ideas or services online from unknown crowd members rather than from traditional employees or contractors. Crowdsourcing has become an appealing and inexpensive method of tapping into the collective knowledge of consumers. Coca-Cola, for instance, invited its 50 million Facebook fans to offer ideas to "promote positivity both online and in the real world." Toymaker Mattel asked what career its famous Barbie doll should pursue next. In conjunction with the University of Texas at Austin, computer giant Dell sponsored the Dell Social Innovation Challenge. This crowdsourcing program produced ideas such as recycling old tires to make rubber shoes for people in need. Another idea suggested a solar-powered food dehydrator to help farmers reduce food spoilage.

Crowdstorming moves beyond crowdsourcing by requiring the crowd to evaluate and filter the ideas into a viable product or plan. Constantly evolving, crowd- storming patterns are moving from simple searches for ideas to more complex interactions in which internal or external groups take on specialized tasks. Consider the collaboration between the Japanese Cuusoo website community and The Lego Group. Cuusoo challenged its viewers to create a Lego model demonstrating an idea, such as a model of the big bang theory or a model illustrating the Wizard of Oz. Posted at the Cuusoo website, eligible projects had to be supported by 10,000 viewers by a certain deadline before the project could be approved for Lego production. The community could also suggest refinements to help submitters increase their chances of success. Surprisingly successful for Lego, 9 model sets have been produced, and 13 more have been announced.

Crowdfunding is the practice of soliciting contributions, usually through the Internet, from a group of friends or strangers to finance a project, cause, or business venture. Capitalizing on the convenience of the Internet, the crowdfunding economy has exploded with requests to fund everything from fertility treatments to film projects and vacations. Musicians, filmmakers, and artists have raised huge amounts that not only finance projects but also raise awareness of worthy causes. Jumping on the bandwagon, college students recognized crowdfunding as way to have their tuition paid. However, donation-based sites such as Campus Slice and Smartn.me aren't terribly successful. Like other experts, MyEvent.com founder Rob Hirscheimer agrees that it's usually futile to try to raise money for your education from strangers. A far better plan is to use crowdfunding to raise funds from your friends and relatives.

Organizing Ideas into Strategies

Thus far, you have seen how to collect information, generate ideas, and prepare an outline. How you order the information in your outline, though, depends on the strategy you choose. Two organizational strategies provide plans of action for typical business messages: the direct strategy and the indirect strategy. The primary difference between the two strategies is where the main idea is placed.

• **Direct Strategy for Receptive Audiences.** In preparing to write any message, you need to anticipate the audience's reaction to your ideas and frame your message accordingly. When you expect the reader to be pleased, mildly interested, or neutral—use the direct strategy. That is, put your main point—the purpose of your message—in the first or second sentence. Explanations and details follow the direct opening. What's important is getting to the main idea quickly. This direct method, also called frontloading, has at least three advantages:

- Saves the reader's time. Many of today's businesspeople can devote only a few moments to each message. Messages that take too long to get to the point may lose their readers along the way.
- Sets a proper frame of mind. Learning the purpose up front helps the reader put the subsequent details and explanations in perspective. Without a clear opening, the reader may be thinking, "Why am I being told this?"
- Reduces frustration. Readers forced to struggle through excessive verbiage before reaching the main idea become frustrated. They resent the writer. Poorly organized messages create a negative impression of the writer.

Typical business messages that follow the direct strategy include routine requests and responses, orders and acknowledgments, non-sensitive memos, e-mails, informational reports, and informational oral presentations. All these tasks have one element in common: they do not address a sensitive subject that will upset the reader.

• **Indirect Strategy for Unreceptive Audiences.** When you expect the audience to be uninterested, unwilling, displeased, or perhaps even hostile, the indirect strategy is more appropriate. In this strategy you reveal the main idea only after you have offered an explanation and evidence. This approach works well with three kinds of messages: (a) bad news, (b) ideas that require persuasion, and (c) sensitive news, especially when being transmitted to superiors. The indirect strategy has these benefits:

- Respects the feelings of the audience. Bad news is always painful, but the trauma can be lessened by preparing the receiver for it.
- Facilitates a fair hearing. Messages that may upset the reader are more likely to be read when the main idea is delayed. Beginning immediately with a piece of bad news or a persuasive request, for example, may cause the receiver to stop reading or listening.
- Minimizes a negative reaction. A reader's overall reaction to a negative message is generally improved if the news is delivered gently.

Typical business messages that could be developed indirectly include e-mails, memos, and letters that refuse requests, deny claims, and disapprove credit. Persuasive requests, sales letters, sensitive messages, and some reports and oral presentations may also benefit from the indirect strategy.

Read
Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 5: Page 165

2.6 Developing business writing techniques

Business writers can significantly improve their messages by working on a few writing techniques. In this section we focus on emphasizing and de-emphasizing ideas, using active and passive voice strategically, using parallelism, and avoiding dangling and misplaced modifiers.

Emphasizing Important Ideas

When you are talking with someone, you can emphasize your main ideas by saying them loudly or by repeating them slowly. You could even pound the table if you want to show real emphasis! Another way you could signal the relative importance of an idea is by raising your eyebrows, shaking your head, or whispering. But when you write, you must rely on other means to tell your readers which ideas are more important than others. Emphasis in writing can be achieved primarily in two ways: mechanically and stylistically.

• **Achieving Emphasis Through Mechanics.** To emphasize an idea in print, a writer may use any of the following devices:

Underlining	Underlining draws the eye to a word.
Italics and Boldface	Using *italics* or **boldface** conveys special meaning.
Font changes	Selecting a large, small, or different font draws interest.
All caps	Printing words in ALL CAPS is like shouting them.
Dashes	Dashes—used sparingly—can be effective.
Tabulation	Listing items vertically makes them stand out: 1.First item 2.Second item 3.Third item

Other means of achieving mechanical emphasis include the arrangement of space, color, lines, boxes, columns, titles, headings, and subheadings. Today's software and color printers provide a wonderful array of capabilities for setting off ideas.

• **Achieving Emphasis Through Style.** Although mechanical devices are occasionally appropriate, more often a writer achieves emphasis stylistically. That is, the writer chooses words carefully and constructs sentences skilfully to emphasize main ideas and de-emphasize minor or negative ideas. Here are four suggestions for emphasizing ideas stylistically:

- **Use vivid, not general, words.** Vivid words are emphatic because the reader can picture ideas clearly.
- **Label the main idea.** If an idea is significant, tell the reader.
- **Give the important idea the spotlight.** Don't dilute the effect of the main idea by making it share the stage with other words and clauses. Instead, put it in a simple sentence or in an independent clause.

• **De-emphasizing When Necessary.** To de-emphasize an idea, such as bad news, try one of the following stylistic devices:

- Use general words.
- Place the bad news in a dependent clause connected to an independent clause that contains something positive.

Developing Parallelism

Parallelism is a skilful writing technique that creates balanced writing. Sentences written so that their parts are balanced, or parallel, are easy to read and understand. To achieve parallel construction, use similar structures to express similar ideas.

For example, the words computing, coding, recording, and storing are parallel because the words all end in -ing. To express the list as computing, coding, recording, and storage is

disturbing because the last item is not what the reader expects. Try to match nouns with nouns, verbs with verbs, and clauses with clauses. Avoid mixing active-voice verbs with passive-voice verbs. Your goal is to keep the wording balanced in expressing similar ideas.

Lacks Parallelism	Illustrates Parallelism
A wedding planner is in charge of arranging the venue, the flowers, and a person to take photographs.	A wedding planner is in charge of arranging the venue, the flowers, and a *photographer.* (Matches nouns.)
Our primary goals are to increase productivity, reduce costs, and the improvement of product quality.	Our primary goals are to increase productivity, reduce costs, and *improve product quality.* (Matches verbs.)
We are scheduled to meet in Tampa on January 5, we are meeting in Atlanta on the 15th of March, and in Columbus on June 3.	We are scheduled to meet in Tampa on January 5, *in Atlanta on March 15*, and in Columbus on June 3. (Matches phrases.)
Marcus audits accounts lettered A through L; accounts lettered M through Z are audited by Katherine.	Marcus audits accounts lettered A through L; *Katherine audits accounts lettered M through Z.* (Matches clauses.)
Our Super Bowl ads have three objectives: 1. We want to increase product use. 2. Introduce complementary products. 3. Our corporate image will be enhanced.	Our Super Bowl ads have three objectives: 1. *Increase* product use. 2. *Introduce* complementary products. 3. *Enhance* our corporate image. (Matches verbs in listed items.)

2.7 Stopping to revise: applying phase 3 of the writing process

In this fast-paced era of e-mailing, texting, and tweeting, the idea of stopping to revise a message seems almost alien to productivity. What? Stop to proofread? Crazy idea! No time! However, sending quick but sloppy business messages not only fails to enhance productivity but also often produces the opposite result. Those hurried messages can be confusing and frustrating. They often set into motion a maddening ping-pong series of back-and-forth queries and responses seeking clarification. To avoid messages that waste time, create confusion, and reduce your credibility, take time to slow down and revise—even for short messages.

The final phase of the 3-x-3 writing process focuses on editing, proofreading, and evaluating. Editing means improving the content and sentence structure of your message. Proofreading involves correcting its grammar, spelling, punctuation, format, and mechanics. Evaluating is the process of analysing whether your message achieves its purpose. One may not expect the restaurant business to require these kinds of skills. However, the new culinary product manager at Taco Bell—and many similar businesspeople—realize that bright ideas are worth little unless they can be communicated effectively to fellow workers and to management. In the communication process, revision can often mean the difference between the acceptance or rejection of ideas.

2.8 Polishing your messages by revising for conciseness

In business, time is indeed money. Translated into writing, this means that concise messages save reading time and, thus, money. In addition, messages that are written directly and efficiently are easier to read and comprehend. In the revision process, look for shorter ways to say what you mean. Examine every sentence you write. Could the thought be conveyed in fewer words? Your writing will be more concise if you eliminate flabby expressions, drop unnecessary introductory words, get rid of redundancies, and purge empty words.

Cutting Flabby Expressions

As you revise, focus on eliminating flabby expressions. This takes conscious effort. As one expert copyeditor observed, "Trim sentences, like trim bodies, usually require far more effort than flabby ones." Turning out slim sentences and lean messages means that you will strive to trim the fat. For example, notice the flabbiness in this sentence: Due to the fact that sales are booming, profits are good. It could be said more concisely: Because sales are booming, profits are good. Many flabby expressions can be shortened to one concise word, as shown here and illustrated in Figure 2.6.

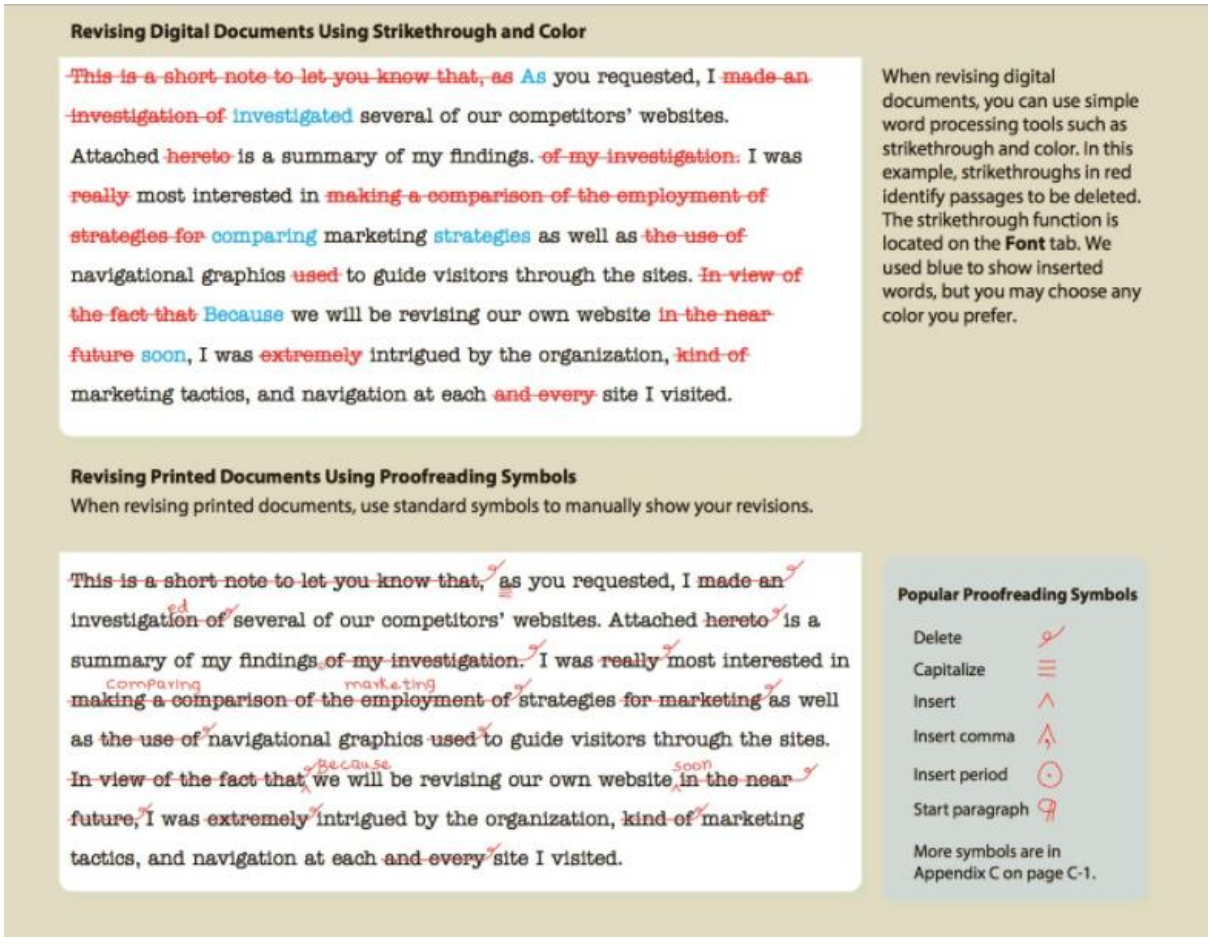


Figure 2.6 Revising Digital and Print Documents

Purging there is/are and it is/was Fillers

In many sentences the expressions there is/are and it is/was function as unnecessary fillers. In addition to taking up space, these fillers delay getting to the point of the sentence. Eliminate them by recasting the sentence. Many—but not all—sentences can be revised so that fillers are unnecessary.

Wordy	Concise
There are more women than men enrolled in college today.	More women than men are enrolled in college today.
There is an aggregator that collects and organizes blogs.	An aggregator collects and organizes blogs.
It was a Facebook post that revealed the news.	A Facebook post revealed the news.

Rejecting Redundancies

Expressions that repeat meaning or include unnecessary words are redundant. Saying unexpected surprise is like saying *surprise surprise* because unexpected carries the same meaning as surprise. Excessive adjectives, adverbs, and phrases often create redundancies and wordiness. Redundancies do not add emphasis, as some people think. Instead, they identify a writer as careless. As you revise, look for redundant expressions such as the following:

Redundant	Concise
absolutely essential	essential
adequate enough	adequate
basic fundamentals	fundamentals *or* basics
big in size	big
combine together	combine
exactly identical	identical
each and every	each *or* every
necessary prerequisite	prerequisite
new beginning	beginning
PIN number	PIN
refer back	refer
repeat again	repeat
true facts	facts

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 6: Page 190

2.9 Evaluating the effectiveness of your message

As part of applying finishing touches, take a moment to evaluate your writing. Remember that everything you write, whether for yourself or someone else, takes the place of a personal appearance. If you were meeting in person, you would be certain to dress appropriately and professionally.

The same standard applies to your writing. Evaluate what you have written to be certain that it attracts the reader's attention. Is it polished and clear enough to convince the reader that you are worth listening to? How successful will this message be? Does it say what you want it to? Will it achieve your purpose? How will you know whether it succeeds?

The best way to judge the success of your communication is through feedback. For this reason, you should encourage the receiver to respond to your message. This feedback will tell you how to modify future efforts to improve your communication technique.



Chapter Summary/Review

1. Understand the nature of communication and its barriers in the digital era.

- Although people are sending more messages and using new technologies in this digital era, the communication process still consists of the same basic elements.
- The sender encodes (selects) words or symbols to express an idea in a message. It travels verbally over a channel (such as e-mail, website, tweet, letter, text, or smartphone) or is expressed nonverbally with gestures or body language.

2. Analyse the purpose of a message, anticipate its audience, and select the best communication channel.

- Before drafting, communicators must decide why they are creating a message and what they hope to achieve. Although many messages only inform, some must also persuade.
- After identifying the purpose, communicators visualize both the primary and secondary audiences, which helps them choose the most appropriate language, tone, and content for a message.

3. Generate and organize ideas resulting from techniques such as brain- storming and brainwriting along with social media techniques such as crowdsourcing, crowdstorming, and crowdfunding.

- Work in groups to develop ideas using brainstorming or brainwriting techniques.
- Understand the trends toward crowdsourcing, crowdstorming, and crowdfunding, all of which depend on the Internet to generate, disseminate, and act on collective knowledge.

4. Evaluate a message to judge its effectiveness.

- Encourage feedback from the receiver of your message so that you can determine whether your communication achieved its goal.
- Be open to any advice from your instructor on how to improve your writing skills.

Review Questions (Short)

1. The use of digital communication has overtaken face-to- face and voice-to-voice communication in the workplace. Has this shift changed the fundamental process of communication?
2. Why do you think employers prefer messages that are not written like high school and college essays?
3. Why is audience analysis so important in the selection of the direct or indirect strategy of organization for a business message?
4. How are speakers different from writers in the way they emphasize ideas?
5. In this digital era of rapid communication, how can you justify the time it takes to stop and revise a message?

Review Questions (Long)

1. Following are ten words or phrases that bloggers have found particularly egregious. For each of these items, write your own definition.
   - thinking outside the box
   - circle back
   - peel back the layers of the onion
   - at the end of the day

2. Revise the following to make the tone conversational yet professional.
   a. As per your recent request, the undersigned is happy to inform you that we are sending you forthwith the procedure manuals you requested.
   b. Kindly be informed that it is necessary for you to designate the model number of the appliance before we can submit your order.

3. Business writing is more forceful when it uses active-voice verbs. Revise the following sentences so that verbs are in the active voice. Put the emphasis on the doer of the action. Add subjects if necessary.
   - **Example:** Laws were passed to protect homeowners from scams.
   - **Revision:** Governments passed laws homeowners from scams.

   a. Workers were asked to wear badges with tiny sensors to monitor their communication and activity patterns at Bank of America.
   b. Tracking devices are being installed by many companies to gather real-time information on how employees interact.

4. Revise the following sentences to avoid confusing clichés, slang, buzzwords, and wordiness.
   a. Although our last presentation bombed, we think that beyond the shadow of a doubt our new presentation will fly.

Our team must be willing to think outside the box in coming up with marketing ideas that pop. c. True to form, our competitor has made a snarky claim that we think is way below the belt.

Case Studies / Projects

MyEvent.com Moves from Weddings to Fundraising and Crowdsourcing

"It all started about 15 years ago at a poker game when one of the guys announced that he was getting married, and we decided to make him a website to plan and organize the affair," said Rob Hirscheimer, cofounder of MyEvent.com. What started as a one-time event eventually became one of the first wedding website builders on the Internet. Based on the idea that anyone can make a website with easy-to-use Web-based software, Rob and cofounder Mark Goldenberg brainstormed their wedding platform into a leading do-it-yourself event planning service.

Located in Montreal, MyEvent.com now provides complete Web packages that help individuals, businesses, and non-profits organize such events as class and family reunions, personal and group fund-raisers, and corporate events. What's remarkable about its business success is that MyEvent.com has managed to remain relevant despite its small size (only 16 core employees) and despite seismic upheavals in Internet industries, including the dawn of Google, social networks, the mobile revolution, Web 2.0, and countless other game-changing technology and behavioural shifts.

One of the most popular MyEvent.com programs is MyFunRun, which provides a step-by-step, turnkey system for schools to raise funds. Students participate in a walk, run, or other activity, and donations arrive via e-mail, via social networks, and in person.

REQUIRED:

• In what ways would research (gathering information) have helped the founders of MyEvent.com move beyond their original wedding platform and remain relevant in the rapidly changing world of Internet businesses?

• What techniques can business communicators at MyEvent.com and other companies use to generate ideas for new products as well as to improve business processes?

• Have you experienced any crowdsourcing or crowdfunding activity among your friends or relatives? Have you seen it in the news?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 5: Page 159



LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Understand e-mail, memos, and the professional standards for their usage, structure, and format in the digital era workplace.
- Prepare contemporary messages that make direct claims and voice complaints, including those posted online.
- Create adjustment messages that salvage customers' trust and promote further business.
- Distinguish between the direct and indirect strategies in conveying unfavourable news.
- Describe and apply effective techniques for delivering bad news within organizations
- Apply basic persuasive techniques in developing compelling press releases.

Introduction

Communication is rapidly changing in this digital era. The Web has evolved from a mere repository of passively consumed information to Web 2.0 and beyond—a dynamic, interactive, and highly networked environment. Users are empowered, active participants who create content, review products, and edit and share information.

Similarly, in the workplace new devices and technologies are transforming the way we exchange information and conduct business. Ever more data are stored on and accessed from remote networks, not individual computers. This storing and accessing of data along with software applications in remote networks (the cloud) is called cloud computing. In many businesses desktop computers, once the mainstay of the office, are becoming obsolete. They're being replaced with ever-smaller laptops, smartphones, tablets, and other powerful mobile devices. Virtual private networks (VPNs) offer secure access to organizations' information from any location in the world that provides an Internet connection. Whether they like it or not, businesspeople are increasingly connected 24/7.

3.1 Writing Digital Age E-Mail Messages and Memos

E-mail is appropriate for short, informal messages that request information and respond to inquiries. It is especially effective for messages to multiple receivers and messages that must be archived (saved). An e-mail is also appropriate as a cover document when sending longer attachments.

E-mail, however, is not a substitute for face-to-face conversations or telephone calls. These channels are much more successful if your goal is to convey enthusiasm or warmth, explain a complex situation, present a persuasive argument, or smooth over disagreements. One expert advises delivering messages in person when they "require a human moment"—that is, when they are emotional, require negotiation, and relate to personnel. Managers and employees echo this advice, as revealed in workplace surveys. They were adamant about using face-to- face contact, rather than e-mail, for critical work situations such as human resources annual reviews, discipline, and promotions.

Composing Professional E-Mails

Professional e-mails are quite different from messages you may send to friends. Instead of casual words tossed off in haste, professional e-mails are well-considered messages that involve all three stages of the writing process. They have compelling subject lines, appropriate greetings, well-organized bodies, and complete closing information.

• **Draft a Compelling but Concise Subject Line.** The most important part of an e-mail is its subject line — not surprising when writers can expect that their messages will be viewed on mobile devices. To improve your chances that your e-mails will actually be read, avoid meaningless statements such as Help, Important, or Meeting. Summarize the purpose of the message clearly and make the receiver want to open the message. Also, be sure to adjust the subject line if the topic changes after a thread of replies emerges.

• **Include a Greeting.** To help receivers see the beginning of a message and to help them recognize whether they are the primary or secondary receiver, include a greeting. The greeting sets the tone for the message and reflects your audience analysis. For friends and colleagues, try friendly greetings (*Hi, Sandra, Thanks, Sandra, Good morning, Sandra, or Greetings, Sandra*). For more formal messages and those to outsiders, include an honorific and last name (*Dear Ms. Stevens*).

• **Organize the Body for Readability and Tone.** In the revision phase, ask yourself how you could make your message more readable. Did you start directly? Did you group similar topics together? Could some information be presented with bulleted or numbered lists? Could you add headings—especially if the message contains more than a few paragraphs? Do you see any phrases or sentences that could be condensed? Get rid of wordiness, but don't sacrifice clarity. If a longer sentence is necessary for comprehension, then keep it. To convey the best tone, read the message aloud. If it sounds curt, it probably is.

• **Close Effectively.** At the end of your message, include an action statement with due dates and requests. Although complimentary closes are unnecessary, you might include a friendly closing such as Many thanks or Warm regards. Do include your name because messages

without names become confusing when forwarded or when they are part of a long string of responses.

For most messages, include full contact information in a signature block that can be inserted automatically. Figure 3.1 illustrates a typical e-mail with proper formatting.

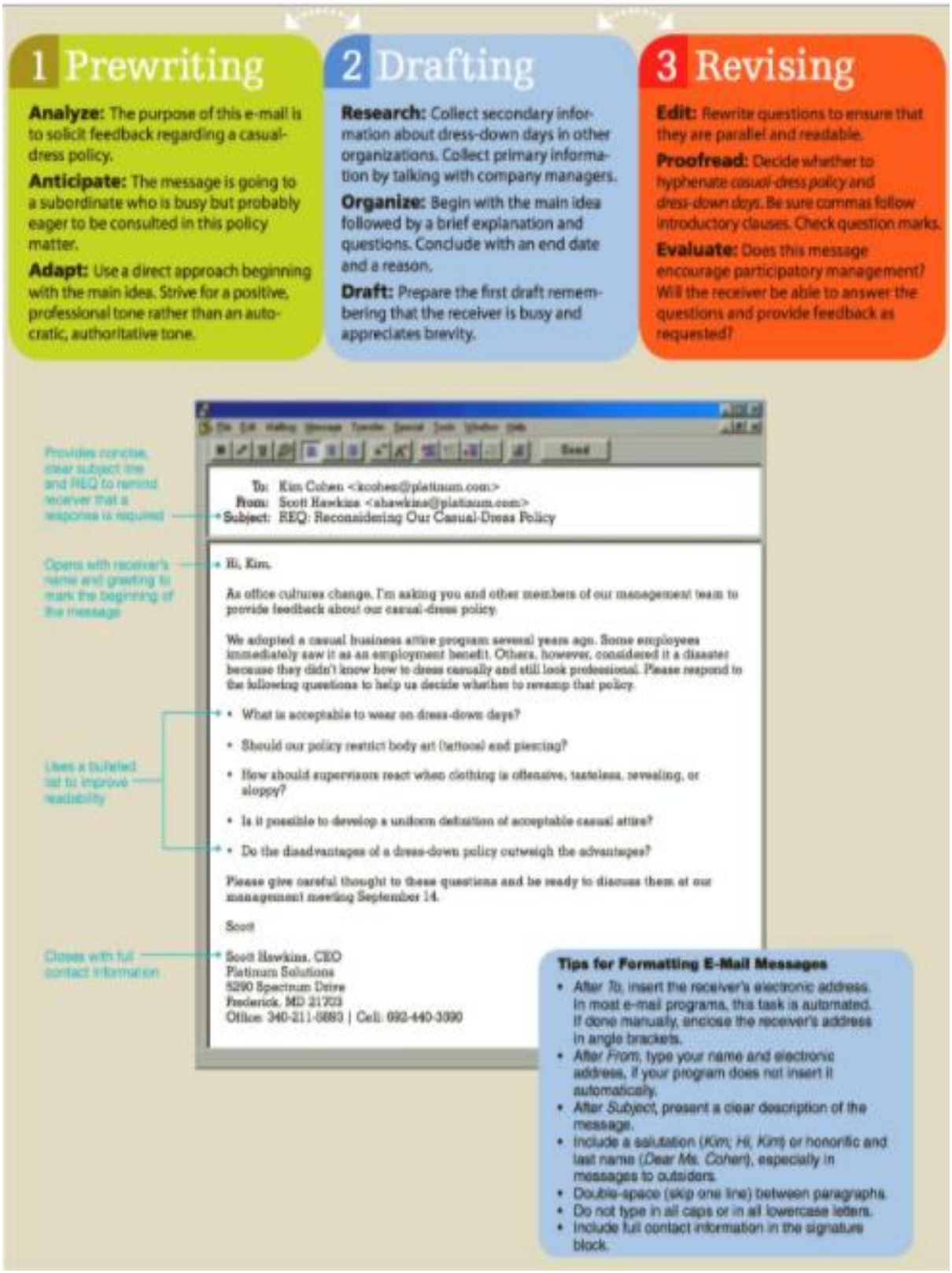


Figure 3.1: Formatting an E-Mail Request

Replying Efficiently with Down-Editing

When answering e-mail, a neat skill to develop is down-editing. This involves inserting your responses to parts of the incoming message. After a courteous opening, your reply message will include only the parts of the incoming message to which you are responding. Delete the sender's message headers, signature, and all unnecessary parts. Your responses can be identified with your initials, if more than one person will be seeing the response. Another efficient trick is to use a different colour for your down-edits. It takes a little practice to develop this skill, but the down-edited reply reduces confusion, saves writing and reading time, and makes you look super savvy.Figure 3.2 shows a number of additional best practices for managing your e-mail.

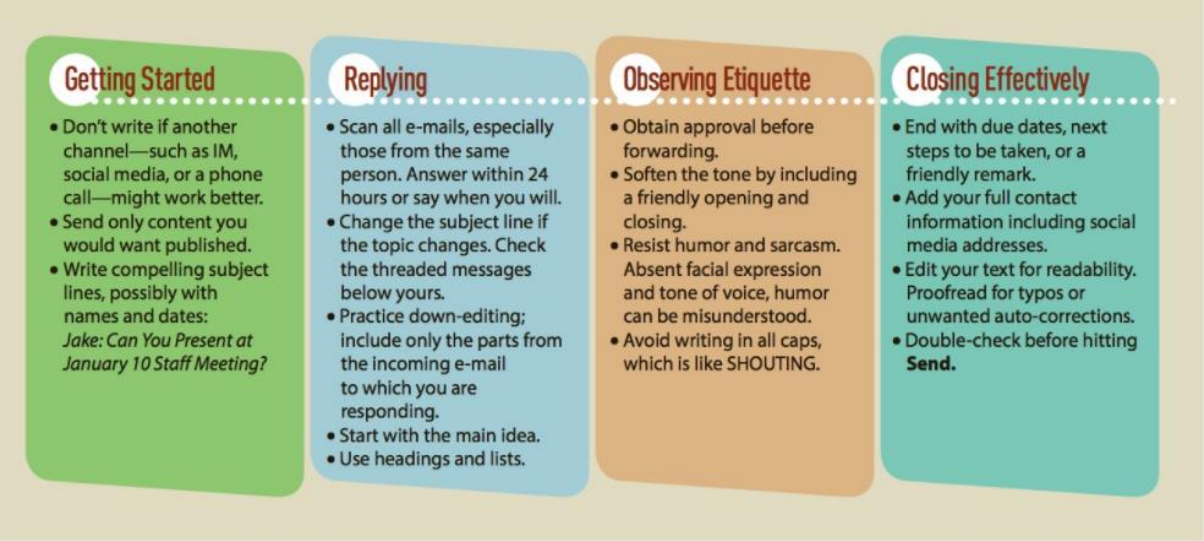


Figure 3.2: Best Practices for Better E-Mail

Writing Interoffice Memos

In addition to e-mail, you should be familiar with another workplace document type, the inter-office memorandum. Although e-mail has largely replaced memos, you may still be called on to use the memo format in specific instances.

Memos are necessary for important internal messages that:

- Are too long for e-mail
- Require a permanent record
- Demand formality
- Inform employees who may not have access to e-mail.

Within organizations, memos deliver changes in procedures, official instructions, and reports. The memo format is particularly necessary for complex internal messages that are too long for e-mail. Prepared as memos, long messages are then delivered as attachments to e-mail cover messages. Memos seem to function better as permanent records than e-mail messages because the latter may be difficult to locate and may contain a trail of confusing replies. E-mails also may change the origination date whenever the file is accessed, thus making it impossible to know the original date of the message.

Similarities Between Memos and E-Mails

Both usually carry non-sensitive information that may be organized directly with the main idea first. Both have guide words calling for a subject line, a dateline, and the identification of the sender and receiver. To enhance readability, both should be organized with headings, bulleted lists, and enumerated items whenever possible. E-mails and memos both generally close with: a.)action information, dates, or deadlines; b.)a summary of the message; or c.) a closing thought.In Figure 3.3, notice how interoffice memos are formatted and how they can be created to improve readability with lists and white space.

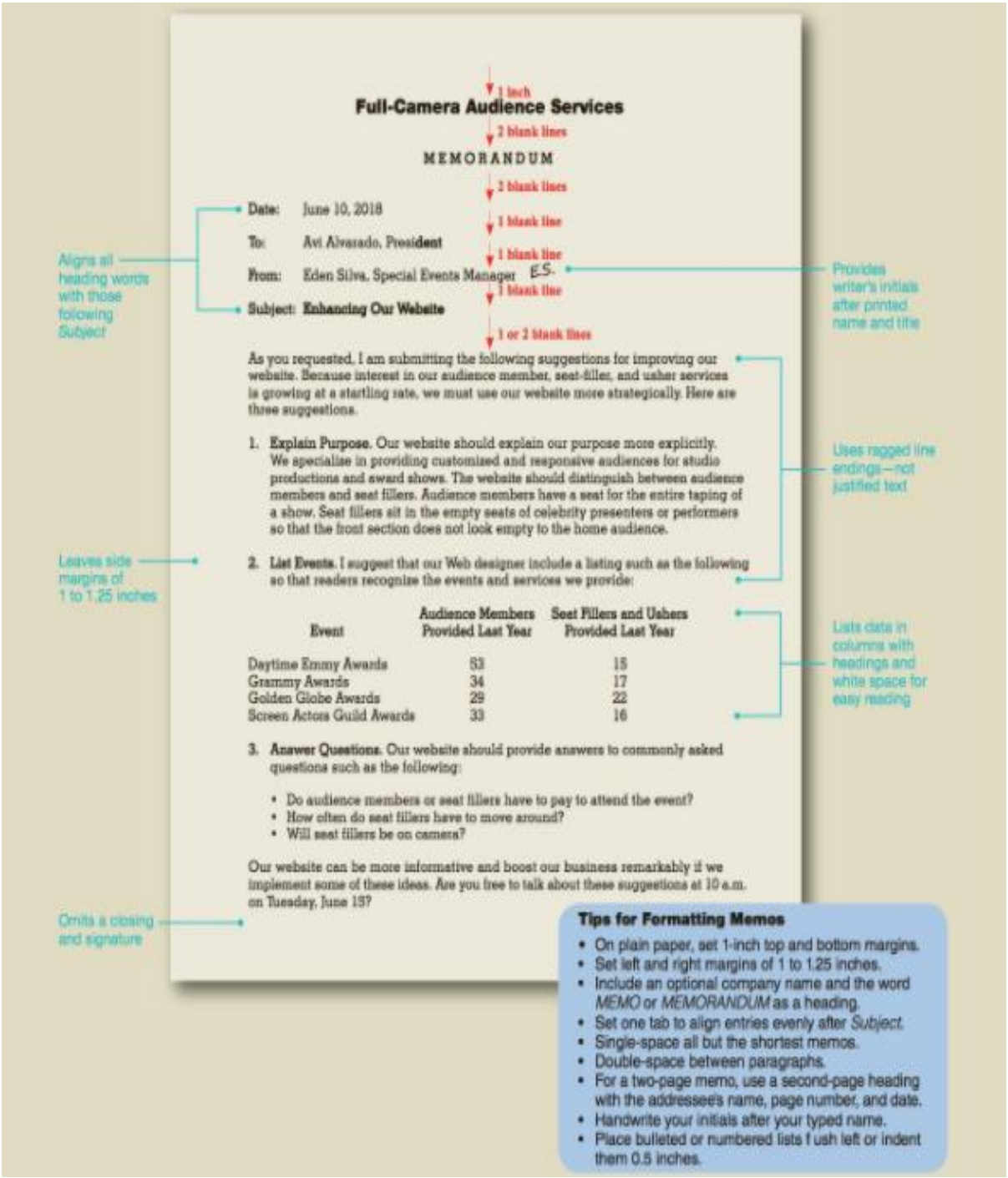


Figure 3.3: Formatting an Interoffice Memo

3.2 Workplace Messaging and Texting

Instant messaging (IM) and text messaging have become powerful tools beyond teens and twenty-somethings. IM enables two or more individuals to use the Internet or an intranet (an internal corporate communication platform) to chat in real time by exchanging brief text-based messages. Companies large and small now provide live online chats with customer service representatives during business hours, in addition to the usual contact options, such as telephone and e-mail.

Impact of Instant Messaging and Texting

Text messaging and IM are convenient alternatives to the telephone and are replacing e-mail for short internal communication. As many as 67 percent of business professionals use text and instant messaging.

• **Benefits of IM and Texting.** The major attraction of instant messaging is real-time communication with colleagues anywhere in the world — as long as a cell phone signal or a Wi-Fi connection is available. Because IM allows people to share information immediately and make decisions quickly, its impact on business communication has been dramatic. Group online chat capabilities in enterprise-grade IM applications allow co-workers on far-flung project teams to communicate instantly. An application such as Slack can replace e-mail for collaboration and real-time messaging.

Like IM, texting can be a low-cost substitute for voice calls, delivering a message between private mobile phone users fast, quietly, and discreetly. Organizations around the world provide news alerts, financial information, and promotions to customers via text. Credit card accounts can be set up to notify account holders by text or e-mail of approaching payment deadlines.

• **Risks of IM and Texting.** Despite their popularity among workers, some organizations forbid employees to use instant and text messaging for a number of reasons. Employers consider instant messaging yet another distraction in addition to the telephone, e-mail, and the Internet. Some organizations also fear that employees using free consumer-grade instant messaging systems will reveal privileged information and company records. The financial sector is particularly vulnerable to charges of impropriety such as insider trading; firms ranging from JPMorgan Chase, Barclays, and Citigroup to RBS have banned instant messaging for external use. Large corporations are protecting themselves by taking instant messaging behind the firewall where they can log and archive traffic. They are also warning employees to avoid clicking links within messages—even when those messages appear to be from high- ranking company officials.

Text Messaging and Business Etiquette

Texting is quick and unobtrusive, and for routine messages it is often the best alternative to a phone call or e-mail. Given the popularity of text messaging, etiquette experts are taking note. Figure 3.4 summarizes the suggestions they offer for the considerate and professional use of texting.

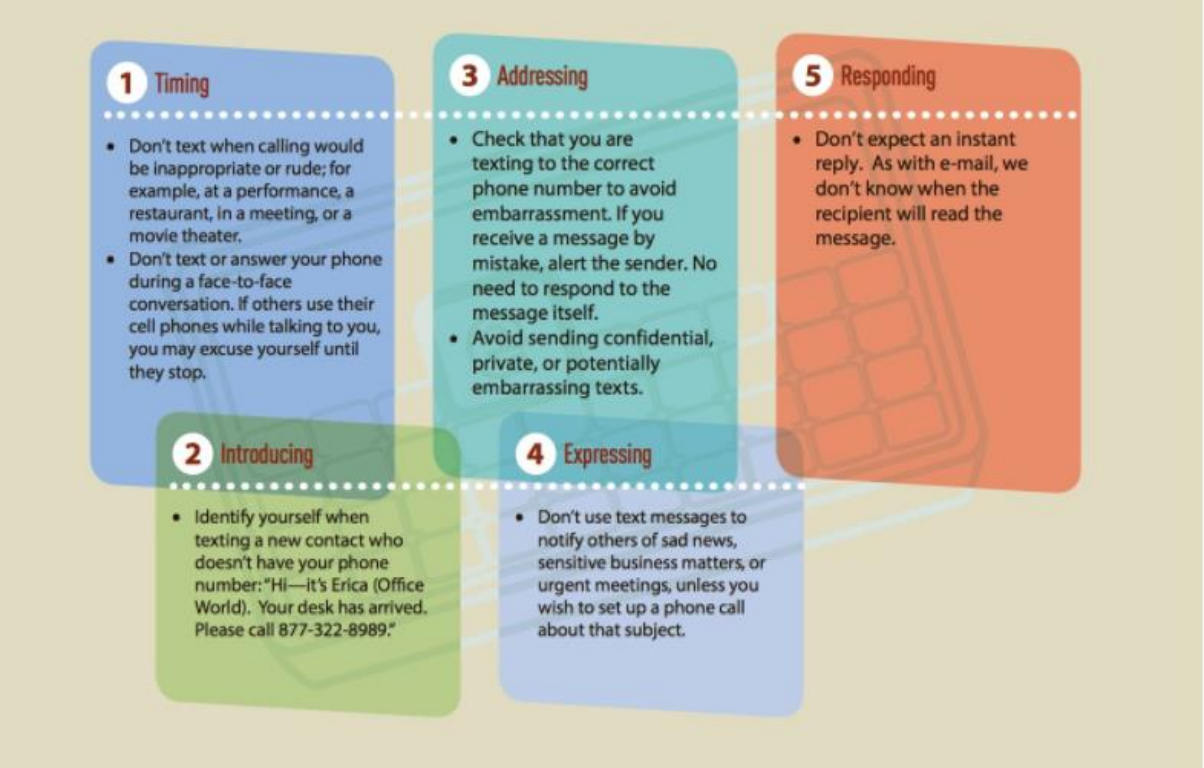


Figure 3.4: Texting Etiquette

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 7: Page 227

3.3 Neutral and Positive Messages: The Writing Process

In the workplace most messages are positive or neutral and, therefore, direct. Positive messages are routine and straightforward; they help workers conduct everyday business. Such routine messages include simple requests for information or action, replies to customers, and explanations to co-workers. Other types of positive messages are instructions, direct claims, and complaints. Here is a quick review of the 3-x-3 writing process to help you apply it to positive messages.

Phase 1: Analysing, Anticipating, and Adapting

In Phase 1, prewriting, you will need to spend some time analysing your task. It is amazing how many of us are ready to put our pens or computers into gear before engaging our minds. Too often, writers start messages without enough preparation. As you begin the writing process, ask yourself these important questions:

• Do I really need to write this e-mail, memo, or letter?

• Why am I writing?

• How will the reader react?

• What channel should I use?

• How can I save my reader's time?

Phase 2: Researching, Organizing, and Drafting

In Phase 2, drafting, you will first want to check the files, gather documentation, and prepare your message. Make an outline of the points you wish to cover. For short messages jot down notes on the document you are answering or make a scratch list on your computer or handheld device.

As you compose your message, avoid amassing huge blocks of text. Instead, group related information into paragraphs, preferably short ones. Paragraphs separated by white space look inviting. Be sure that each paragraph includes a topic sentence backed up by details and evidence. If you bury your main point in the middle of a paragraph, the reader may miss it. Also plan for revision, because excellence is rarely achieved on the first effort.

Phase 3: Editing, Proofreading, and Evaluating

Phase 3, revising, involves putting the final touches on your message. Careful and caring writers ask themselves the following questions:

• Is the message clear?

• Is the message correct?

• Did you plan for feedback?

• Will this message achieve its purpose?

3.4 Routine Request, Response, and Instruction Message

When you write messages that request information or action and you think your request will be received positively, start with the main idea. The most emphatic positions in a message are the opening and closing. Readers tend to look at them first. You should capitalize on this tendency by putting the most significant statement first. The first sentence of an information request is usually a question or a polite command. It should not be an explanation or justification, unless resistance to the request is expected. When the information or action requested is likely to be forthcoming, immediately tell the reader what you want.

Responding to Requests

Often, your messages will respond directly and favourably to requests for information or action. A customer wants information about a product, a supplier asks to arrange a meeting, an employee inquires about a procedure, or a manager requests your input on a marketing

campaign. In complying with such requests, you will want to apply the same direct strategy you used in making requests.

Reacting to Customer Comments Online

We live in an age when vocal individuals can start a firestorm of criticism online or become powerful brand ambassadors who champion certain products. Therefore, businesses must listen to social media comments about themselves and, if necessary, respond. You may ask, how do companies know when to respond, and how? This invaluable knowledge is an evolving field and, some would say, a minefield littered with disastrous missteps and missed opportunities. However, social media marketing experts are developing guidelines to provide organizations with tools for strategic decision making in various situations. Figure 3.5 shows a social media response flowchart, now increasingly common in for-profit and non-profit organizations alike.

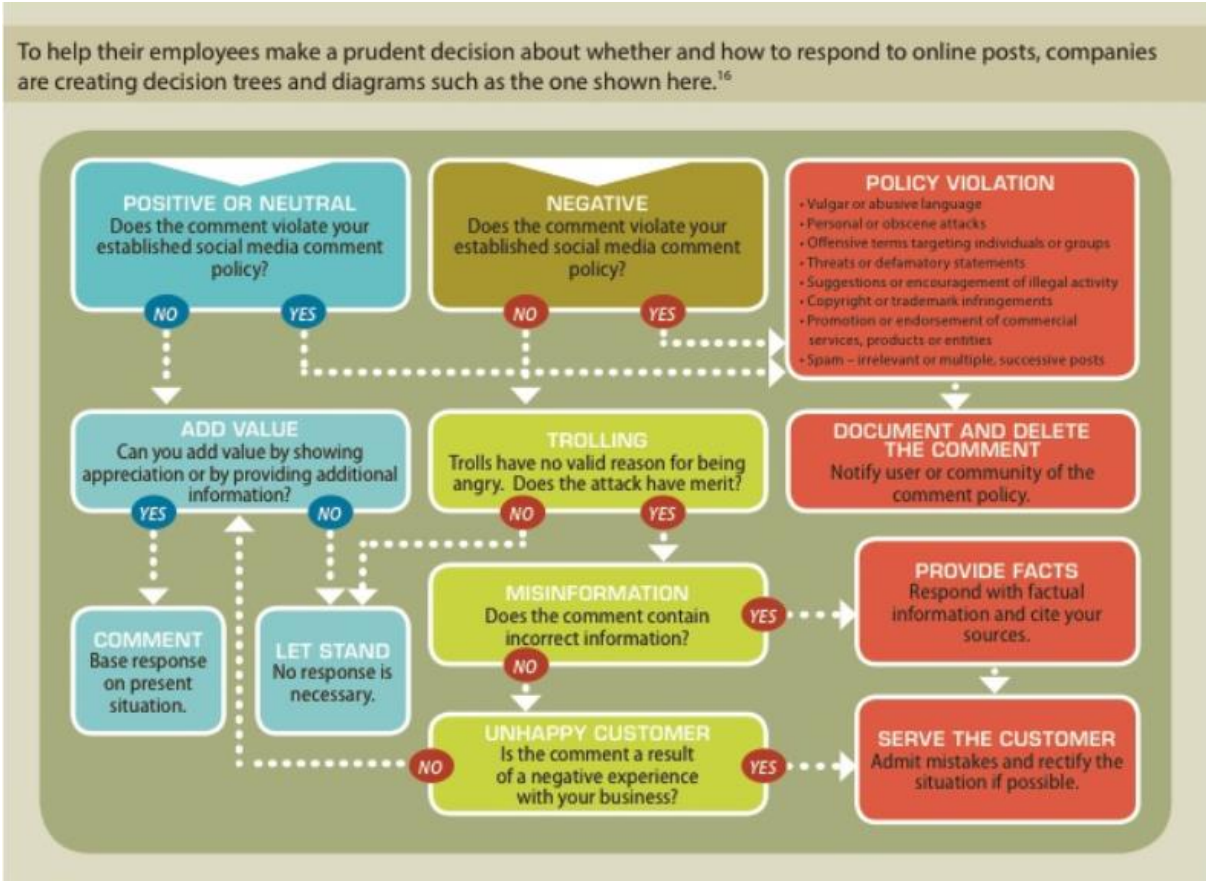


Figure 3.5: Social Media Response Flowchart

Composing Instruction Messages

Instruction messages describe how to complete a task. You may be asked to write instructions about how to repair a paper jam in the photocopier, order supplies, file a grievance, or hire new employees. Instructions are different from policies and official procedures, which establish

rules of conduct to be followed within an organization. We are most concerned with creating messages that clearly explain how to complete a task.

Like requests and responses, instruction messages follow a straightforward, direct approach. Before writing instructions for a process, be sure you understand the process completely. Practice doing it yourself. A message that delivers instructions should open with an explanation of why the procedure or set of instructions is necessary.

Creating Step-by-Step Instructions. The body of an instruction message should use plain English and familiar words to describe the process. Your messages explaining instructions will be most readable if you follow these guidelines:

• Divide the instructions into steps.

• List the steps in the order in which they are to be carried out.

• Arrange the items vertically with numbers.

• Begin each step with an action verb using the imperative (command) mood rather than the indicative mood.

In the closing of a message issuing instructions, try to tie following the instructions to benefits to the organization or individual. If you are asked to prepare a list of instructions that is not part of a message, include a title such as How to Clear Paper Jams. Include an opening paragraph explaining why the instructions are needed.

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 8: Page 263

3.5 Direct claims and complaints

In business, things can and do go wrong—promised shipments are late, warrantied goods fail, and service is disappointing. When you as a customer must write to identify or correct a wrong, the message is called a claim. Straightforward claims are those to which you expect the receiver to agree readily.

Stating a Clear Claim in the Opening

When you, as a customer, have a legitimate claim, you can expect a positive response from a company. Smart businesses want to hear from their customers. They know that retaining a customer is far less costly than recruiting a new customer.

Open your claim with a compliment, a point of agreement, a statement of the problem, a brief review of action you have taken to resolve the problem, or a clear statement of the action you want. You might expect a replacement, a refund, a new product, credit to your account,

correction of a billing error, free repairs, a free inspection, or cancellation of an order. When the remedy is obvious, state it immediately (Please correct an erroneous double charge of $59 to my credit card for LapLink migration software. I accidentally clicked the Submit button twice). When the remedy is less obvious, you might ask for a change in policy or procedure or simply for an explanation (*Because three of our employees with confirmed reservations were refused rooms September 16 in your hotel, would you please clarify your policy regarding reservations and late arrivals*).

Explaining and Supporting a Claim

In the body of a claim message, explain the problem and justify your request. Provide the necessary details so that the difficulty can be corrected without further correspondence. Avoid becoming angry or trying to fix blame. Bear in mind that the person reading your message is seldom responsible for the problem. Instead, state the facts logically, objectively, and unemotionally; let the reader decide on the causes. If you choose to send a letter by postal mail, include copies of all pertinent documents such as invoices, sales slips, catalog descriptions, and repair records. Of course, those receipts and other documents can also be scanned and attached to an e-mail.

If using paper mail, send copies and not your originals, which could be lost. When service is involved, cite the names of individuals you spoke to and the dates of calls. Assume that a company honestly wants to satisfy its customers—because most do. When an alternative remedy exists, spell it out (*If you are unable to offer store credit, please apply the second amount of $59 to your TurboSpeed software and a LapLink USB cable that I would like to buy too*).

Concluding With an Action Request

End a claim message with a courteous statement that promotes goodwill and summarizes your action request. If appropriate, include an end date (*I hope you understand that mistakes in ordering online sometimes occur. Because I have enjoyed your prompt service in the past, I hope that you will be able to issue a refund or store credit by May 2*).

Finally, in making claims, act promptly. Delaying claims makes them appear less important. Delayed claims are also more difficult to verify. By taking the time to put your claim in writing, you indicate your seriousness. A written claim starts a record of the problem, should later action be necessary. Be sure to save a copy of your message whether paper or electronic.

3.6 Analysing negative-news effectively

Delivering negative news is not the happiest communication task you may have, but it can be gratifying if you do it effectively. As a business communicator working with bad news, you will have many goals, the most important of which are summarized in Figure 3.6.

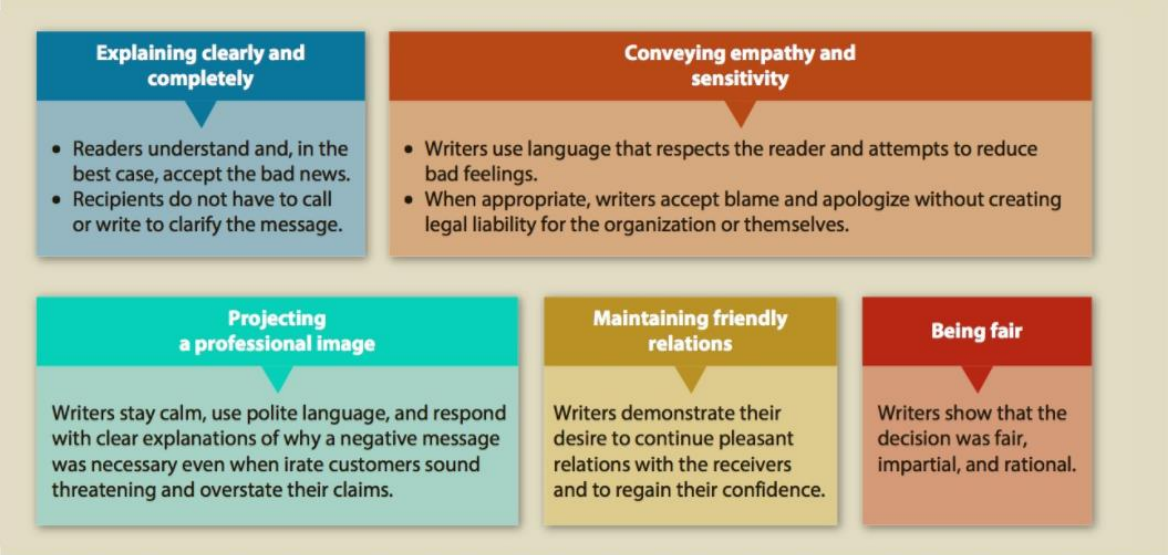


Figure 3.6: Goals Conveying Unfavourable News

Applying the 3-x-3 Writing Process

Thinking through the entire writing process is especially important when writing bad-news messages because the way bad news is revealed often determines how it is accepted. Certain techniques can help you deliver bad news sensitively, beginning with the familiar 3-x-3 writing process.

• **Analysing, Anticipating, and Adapting.** In Phase 1 (prewriting), you need to analyse the bad news and anticipate its effect on the receiver. When you have bad news to convey, one of your first considerations is how that message will affect its receiver. If the disappointment will be mild, announce it directly. Choose words that show that you respect the reader as a responsible, valuable person. Select the best channel to deliver the bad news. In many negative situations, you will be dealing with a customer. If your goal is retaining the goodwill of a customer, a letter on company stationery will be more impressive than an e-mail.

• **Researching, Organizing, and Drafting.** In Phase 2 (drafting), you will gather information and brainstorm for ideas. Jot down all the reasons you have that explain the bad news. If four or five reasons prompted your negative decision, concentrate on the strongest and safest ones. Avoid presenting any weak reasons; readers may seize on them to reject the entire message. Include an ample explanation of the negative situation, and avoid fixing blame. In composing any negative message, conduct research if necessary to help you explain what went wrong and why a decision or action is necessary.

• **Editing, Proofreading, and Evaluating.** In Phase 3 (revising), you will read over your message carefully to ensure that it says what you intend. Check your wording to be sure you are concise without being gruff. If you find that you have overused certain words, use a thesaurus to find synonyms. Read your sentences to see if they sound like conversation and flow smoothly. This is the time to edit and improve coherence and tone. In bad-news messages, the tone is especially important. Readers are more likely to accept negative messages if the tone is friendly and respectful. Even when the bad news can’t be changed, its effect can be

reduced somewhat by the way it is presented. In the last phase of the writing process, proofread to make sure your verbs agree with their subjects, your sentences are properly punctuated, and all words are spelled correctly. Pay attention to common mistakes.

Conveying Negative News Without Incurring Legal Liability

Before we examine the components of a negative message, let's look more closely at how you can avoid exposing yourself and your employer to legal liability in writing negative messages. Although we can't always anticipate the consequences of our words, we should be alert to three causes of legal difficulties:

• **Abusive Language.** Calling people names (*such as deadbeat, crook, or quack*) can get you into trouble. Defamation is the legal term for any false statement that harms an individual's reputation. When the abusive language is written, it is called *libel*; when spoken, it is *slander*.

• **Careless Language.** As the marketplace becomes increasingly litigious, we must be certain that our words communicate only what we intend. Take the case of a factory worker injured on the job. His attorney subpoenaed company documents and discovered a seemingly harmless letter sent to a group regarding a plant tour. These words appeared in the letter: "Although we are honored at your interest in our company, we cannot give your group a tour of the plant operations as it would be too noisy and dangerous." The court found in favor of the worker, inferring from the letter that working conditions were indeed hazardous. The letter writer did not intend to convey the impression of dangerous working conditions, but the court accepted that interpretation.

• **The Good-Guy Syndrome.** Most of us hate to have to reveal bad news—that is, to be the bad guy. To make ourselves look better, to make the receiver feel better, and to maintain good relations, we are tempted to make statements that are legally dangerous. Consider the case of a law firm interviewing job candidates. One of the firm's partners was asked to inform a candidate that she was not selected. The partner's letter said, "Although you were by far the most qualified candidate we interviewed, unfortunately, we have decided we do not have a position for a person of your talents at this time." To show that he personally had no reservations about this candidate and to bolster the candidate, the partner offered his own opinion. However, he differed from the majority of the recruiting committee. When the rejected interviewee learned later that the law firm had hired two male attorneys, she sued, charging sexual discrimination. The court found in favor of the rejected candidate. It agreed that a reasonable inference could be made from the partner's letter that she was the most qualified candidate.

3.7 Composing effective negative messages

Even though it may be impossible to make the receiver happy when delivering negative news, you can reduce bad feelings and resentment by structuring your message sensitively. Most negative messages contain some or all of these parts: buffer, reasons, bad news, and closing. This section also discusses apologies and how to convey empathy in delivering bad news.

Opening Indirect Messages with a Buffer

A buffer is a device to reduce shock or pain. To buffer the pain of bad news, begin with a neutral but meaningful statement that makes the reader continue reading. The buffer should be relevant and concise and provide a natural transition to the explanation that follows. The individual situation, of course, will help determine what you should put in the buffer. Avoid trite buffers such as Thank you for your letter. Not all business communication authors agree that buffers increase the effectiveness of negative messages. However, in many cultures softening bad news is appreciated. Following are buffer possibilities.

• **Best News.** Start with the part of the message that represents the best news. For example, a message to customers who purchased mobile device insurance announced a progressive rate increase that was tied to the replacement value of each smart device. Only customers with very expensive handsets will experience price increases. You might start by reminding customers about the value of insuring a mobile device, *As a reminder, your Premium Electronics Protection provides the benefit of a replacement device when your smartphone is accidentally damaged, including liquid damage, loss, theft, and malfunction. Although devices are becoming increasingly expensive, no changes will be made to your deductible amount or coverage.*

• **Compliment.** Praise the receiver's accomplishments, organization, or efforts, but do so with honesty and sincerity. For instance, in a letter declining an invitation to speak, you could write, *The Thalians have my sincere admiration for their fund-raising projects on behalf of hungry children. I am honored that you asked me to speak Monday, November 5.*

• **Appreciation.** Convey thanks for doing business, for sending something, for showing confidence in your organization, for expressing feelings, or simply for providing feedback. Suppose you had to draft a letter that refuses employment. You could say, *I appreciated learning about the hospitality management program at Cornell and about your qualifications in our interview last Friday*. Avoid thanking the reader, however, for something you are about to refuse.

• **Agreement.** Make a relevant statement with which both reader and receiver can agree. A letter that rejects a business loan application might read, *We both realize how much falling crude oil prices on the world market have devastated domestic oil production.*

• **Facts.** Provide objective information that introduces the bad news. For example, in a memo announcing cutbacks in the hours of the employees' cafeteria, you might say, *During the past five years, the number of employees eating breakfast in our cafeteria has dropped from 32 percent to 12 percent.*

• **Understanding.** Show that you care about the reader. Notice how in this letter to customers announcing a product defect, the writer expresses concern: *We know that you expect superior performance from all the products you purchase from OfficeCity. That's why we're writing person- ally about the Omega printer cartridges you recently ordered.*

Apologizing

An apology is defined as an "admission of blameworthiness and regret for an undesirable event." Apologies to customers are especially important if you or your company erred. They cost nothing, and they go a long way in soothing hard feelings. Professional writer John Kador recommends what he calls the Five Rs model for effective apologies in business messages summarized in Figure 3.7.

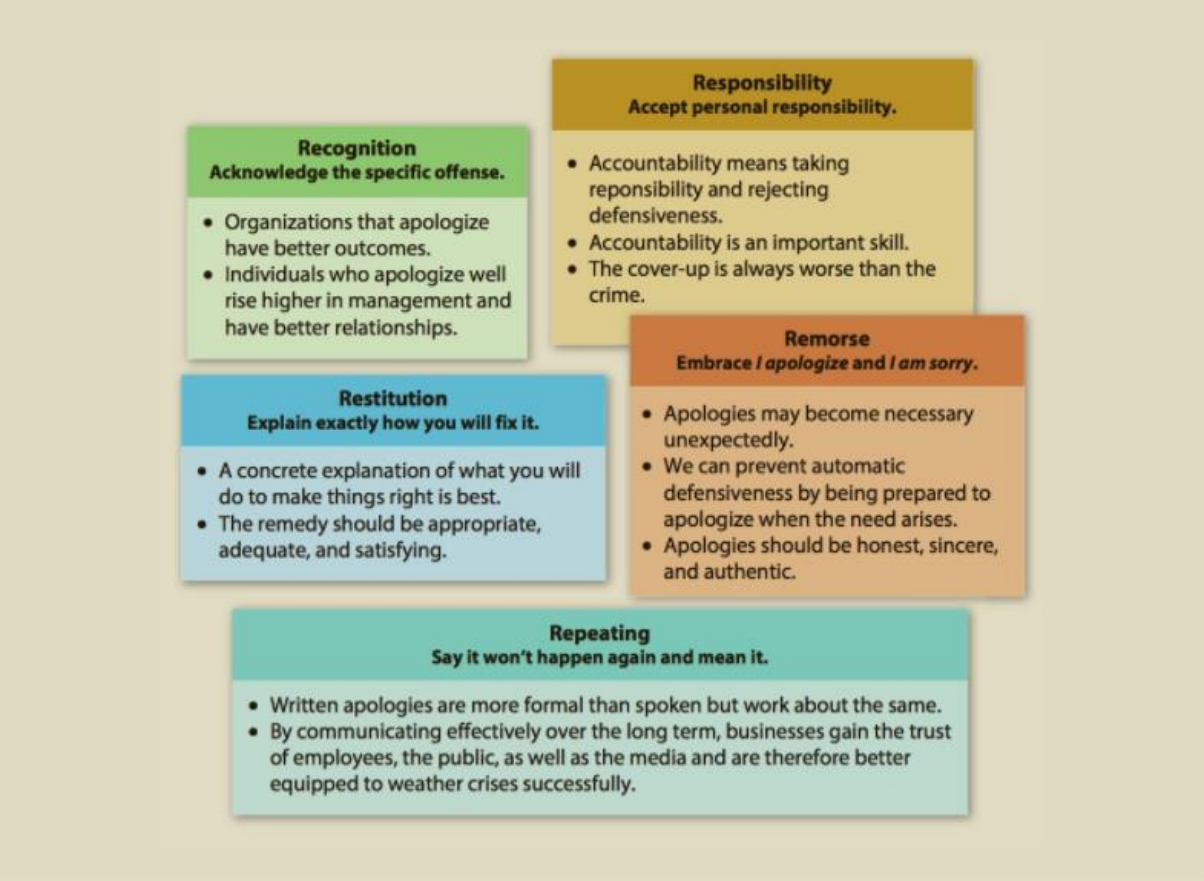


Figure 3.7 Apologising Effectively in the Digital Age: The Five Rs

Presenting the Reasons

Providing an explanation reduces feelings of ill will and improves the chances that readers will accept the bad news. Without sound reasons for denying a request, refusing a claim, or revealing other bad news, a message will fail, no matter how cleverly it is organized or written.

• **Explaining Clearly.** If the reasons are not confidential and if they will not create legal liability, you can be specific: *Growers supplied us with a limited number of patio roses, and our demand this year was twice that of last year.* In responding to a billing error, explain what happened: *After you informed us of an error on your January bill, we investigated the matter and admit the mistake was ours. Until our new automated system is fully online, we are still subject to the frailties of human error. Rest assured that your account has been credited, as you will see on your next bill.* In refusing a speaking engagement, tell why the date is

impossible: *On January 17 we have a board of directors meeting that I must attend.* Don't, however, make unrealistic or dangerous statements in an effort to be the good guy.

• **Citing Reader or Other Benefits, if Plausible.** Readers are more open to bad news if in some way, even indirectly, it may help them. In refusing a customer's request for free hemming of skirts and slacks, Lands' End wrote: "We tested our ability to hem skirts a few months ago. This process proved to be very time-consuming. We have decided not to offer this service because the additional cost would have increased the selling price of our skirts substantially, and we did not want to impose that cost on all our customers." Readers also accept bad news more readily if they recognize that someone or something else benefits, such as other workers or the environment: *Although we would like to consider your application, we prefer to fill managerial positions from within.* Avoid trying to show reader benefits, though, if they appear insincere: *To improve our service to you, we are increasing our brokerage fees.*

• **Explaining Company Policy.** Readers resent blanket policy statements prohibiting something: *Company policy prevents us from making cash refunds or Contract bids may be accepted from local companies only or Company policy requires us to promote from within.* Instead of hiding behind company policy, gently explain why the policy makes sense: *We prefer to promote from within because it rewards the loyalty of our employees. In addition, we have found that people familiar with our organization make the quickest contribution to our team effort.* By offering explanations, you demonstrate that you care about readers and are treating them as important individuals.

• **Choosing Positive Words.** Because the words you use can affect a reader's response, choose carefully. Remember that the objective of the indirect strategy is holding the reader's attention until you have had a chance to explain the reasons justifying the bad news. To keep the reader in a receptive mood, avoid expressions with punitive, demoralizing, or otherwise negative connotations. Stay away from such words as *cannot, claim, denied, error, failure, fault, impossible, mistaken, misunderstand, never, regret, rejected, unable, unwilling, unfortunately,* and *violate*.

• **Showing Fairness and Serious Intent.** In explaining reasons, show the reader that you take the matter seriously, have investigated carefully, and are making an unbiased decision. Receivers are more accepting of disappointing news when they feel that their requests have been heard and that they have been treated fairly. In cancelling funding for a program, board members provided this explanation: *As you know, the publication of Urban Artist was funded by a renewable annual grant from the National Endowment for the Arts. Recent cutbacks in federally sponsored city arts programs have left us with few funds. Because our grant has been discontinued, we have no alternative but to cease publication of Urban Artist. You have my assurance that the board has searched long and hard for some other viable funding, but every avenue of recourse has been closed before us. Accordingly, June's issue will be our last.*

Cushioning the Bad News

Although you can't prevent the disappointment that bad news brings, you can reduce the pain somewhat by breaking the news sensitively. Be especially considerate when the reader will suffer personally from the bad news. A number of thoughtful techniques can cushion the blow.

• **Positioning the Bad News Strategically.** Instead of spotlighting it, sandwich the bad news between other sentences, perhaps among your reasons. Don't let the refusal begin or end a paragraph; the reader's eye will linger on these high-visibility spots. Another technique that reduces shock is putting a painful idea in a subordinate clause: *Although another candidate was hired, we appreciate your interest in our organization and wish you every success in your job search.* Subordinate clauses often begin with words such as *although, as, because, if,* and *since.*

• **Using the Passive Voice.** Passive-voice verbs enable you to depersonalize an action. Whereas the active voice focuses attention on a person (*We don't give cash refunds*), the passive voice highlights the action (*Cash refunds are not given because . . .*). Use the passive voice for the bad news. In some instances you can combine passive-voice verbs and a subordinate clause: *Although franchise scoop shop owners cannot be required to lower their frozen yogurt prices, we are happy to pass along your comments for their consideration.*

• **Highlighting the Positive.** As you learned earlier, messages are far more effective when you describe what you can do instead of what you can't do. Rather than *We will no longer allow credit card purchases,* try a more positive appeal: *We are now selling gasoline at discount cash prices.*

• **Implying the Refusal.** It is sometimes possible to avoid a direct statement of refusal. Often, your reasons and explanations leave no doubt that a request has been denied. Explicit refusals may be unnecessary and at times cruel. In this refusal to contribute to a charity, for example, the writer never actually says no: *Because we will soon be moving into new offices in Glendale, all our funds are earmarked for relocation costs. We hope that next year we will be able to support your worthwhile charity.* The danger of an implied refusal, of course, is that it is so subtle that the reader misses it. Be certain that you make the bad news clear, thus preventing the need for further correspondence.

• **Suggesting a Compromise or an Alternative.** A refusal is not so depressing—for the sender or the receiver—if a suitable compromise, substitute, or alternative is available. In denying permission to a group of students to visit a historical private residence, for instance, this writer softens the bad news by proposing an alternative: *Although private tours of the grounds are not given, we do open the house and its gardens for one charitable event in the fall*. You can further reduce the impact of the bad news by refusing to dwell on it. Present it briefly (or imply it), and move on to your closing.

Closing Pleasantly

After explaining the bad news sensitively, close the message with a pleasant statement that promotes goodwill. The closing should be personalized and may include a forward look, an alternative, good wishes, freebies, resale information, or a sales promotion. Resale refers to mentioning a product or service favorably to reinforce the customer's choice. For example, you chose our best-selling model.

• **Forward Look.** Anticipate future relations or business. A letter that refuses a contract proposal might read: *Thanks for your bid. We look forward to working with your talented staff when future projects demand your special expertise.*

• **Alternative Follow-Up.** If an alternative exists, end your letter with follow-through advice. For example, in a letter rejecting a customer's demand for replacement of landscaping plants, you might say: *I will be happy to give you a free inspection and consultation. Please call 301-746- 8112 to arrange a date for my visit*. In a message to a prospective home buyer: *Although the lot you saw last week is now sold, we do have two excellent lots available at a slightly higher price. In reacting to an Internet misprint: Please note that our website contained an unfortunate misprint offering $850-per-night Bora Bora bungalows at $85. Although we cannot honor that rate, we are offering a special half-price rate of $425 to those who responded.*

• **Good Wishes.** A letter rejecting a job candidate might read: *We appreciate your interest in our company, and we extend to you our best wishes in your search to find the perfect match between your skills and job requirements.*

• **Freebies.** When customers complain—primarily about food products or small consumer items—companies often send coupons, samples, or gifts to restore confidence and to promote future business. In response to a customer's complaint about a frozen dinner, you could write: *Your loyalty and your concern about our frozen entrées are genuinely appreciated. Because we want you to continue enjoying our healthy and convenient dinners, we are enclosing a coupon that you can take to your local market to select your next Green Valley entrée.*

• **Resale or Sales Promotion.** When the bad news is not devastating or personal, references to resale information or promotion may be appropriate: *The computer workstations you ordered are unusually popular because of their stain-, heat-, and scratch-resistant finishes. To help you locate hard-to-find accessories for these workstations, we invite you to visit our website where our online catalog provides a huge selection of surge suppressors, multiple outlet strips, security devices, and PC tool kits.*

Avoid endings that sound canned, insincere, inappropriate, or self-serving. Don't invite further correspondence and don't refer to the bad news. Figure 3.8 reviews suggestions for delivering bad news sensitively.

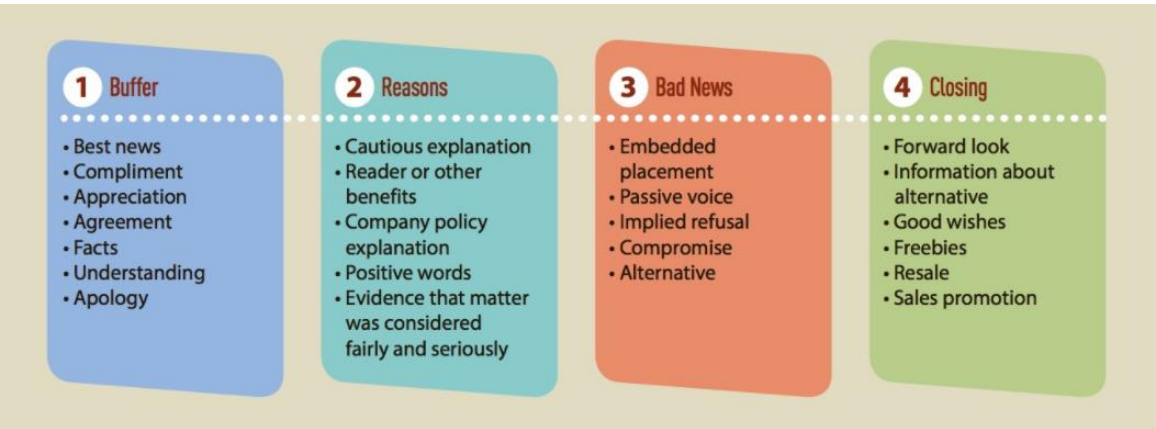


Figure 3.8 Delivering Bad News Sensitively

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 9: Page 308

3.8 Managing bad news with organizations

A tactful tone and a reasons-first approach help preserve friendly relations with customers. These same techniques are useful when delivering bad news within organizations. Interpersonal bad news might involve telling the boss that something went wrong or confronting an employee about poor performance. Organizational bad news might involve declining profits, lost contracts, harmful lawsuits, public relations controversies, and changes in policy. Whether you use a direct or an indirect strategy in delivering that news depends primarily on the anticipated reaction of the audience. Generally, bad news is better received when reasons are given first. Within organizations, you may find yourself giving bad news in person or in writing.

Delivering Bad News in Person

Whether you are an employee or a supervisor, you may have the unhappy responsibility of delivering bad news. First, decide whether the negative information is newsworthy. As a team leader or supervisor, you might be required to confront an underperforming employee. If you know that the news will upset the receiver, the reasons-first strategy is most effective. When the bad news involves one person or a small group nearby, you should generally deliver that news in person. Here are pointers on how to do so tactfully, professionally, and safely:

• **Gather all the information.** Cool down and have all the facts before marching in on the boss or confronting someone. Remember that every story has two sides.

• **Prepare and rehearse.** Outline what you plan to say so that you are confident, coherent, and dispassionate.

• **Explain: past, present, future.** If you are telling the boss about a problem such as the computer crash, explain what caused the crash, the current situation, and how and when you plan to fix it.

• **Consider taking a partner.** If you fear a shoot-the-messenger reaction, especially from your boss, bring a colleague with you. Each person should have a consistent and credible part in the presentation. If possible, take advantage of your organization's internal resources. To lend credibility to your view, call on auditors, inspectors, or human resources experts.

• **Think about timing.** Don't deliver bad news when someone is already stressed or grumpy. Experts also advise against giving bad news on Friday afternoon when people have the weekend to dwell on it.

• **Be patient with the reaction.** Give the receiver time to vent, think, recover, and act wisely.

3.9 Persuading effectively and ethically in the contemporary workplaces

Contemporary businesses have embraced leaner corporate hierarchies, simultaneously relying on teams, eliminating division walls, and blurring the lines of authority. As teams and managers are abandoning the traditional command structure, sophisticated persuasive skills are becoming ever more important at work. Businesspeople must try to influence others. Pushy hard-sell techniques are waning because today's consumers have many choices and can be fickle.

What Is Persuasion?

As communication scholar Richard M. Perloff defines it, persuasion is "a symbolic process in which communicators try to convince other people to change their attitudes or behaviors regarding an issue through the transmission of a message in an atmosphere of free choice." Helping us understand how persuasion works, this definition has five components, which are outlined in the following sections.

• **Persuasion Is a Symbolic Process.** Symbols are meaningful words, signs, and images infused with rich meaning—for example, words such as liberty, signs such as national flags, and images such as the red cross for rescue or the apple for computers. An ethical persuader under- stands the power of symbols and does not use them to trick others. Because people's attitudes change slowly, persuasion takes time.

• **Persuasion Involves an Attempt to Influence.** Persuasion involves a conscious effort to influence another person with the understanding that change is possible. For instance, when you ask your boss for permission to telecommute, you intend to achieve a specific outcome and assume that your boss can be swayed.

• **Persuasion Is Self-Persuasion.** Ethical communicators give others the choice to accept their arguments by making compelling, honest cases to support them. They plant the seed but do not coerce. They leave it to others to "self-influence"—that is, to decide whether to make the change. In the case of telecommuting, you would want to present to your boss clear benefits of working from home but definitely not push hard.

• **Persuasion Involves Transmitting a Message.** Persuasive messages can be verbal or nonverbal, and they can be conveyed face-to-face or via the Internet, TV, radio, and other media. Persuasive messages are not always rational. They often appeal to our emotions. Consider the car commercial playing your favorite tune and showing pristine landscapes, not a gridlocked interstate during rush hour.

• **Persuasion Requires Free Choice.** Although free is a difficult term to define, we can perhaps agree that people are free when they are not forced to comply, when they can refuse the idea suggested to them, and when they are not pressured to act against their own preferences. Many smart thinkers have tried to explain how savvy persuaders influence others. One classic model illustrating persuasion is shown in Figure 3.9.

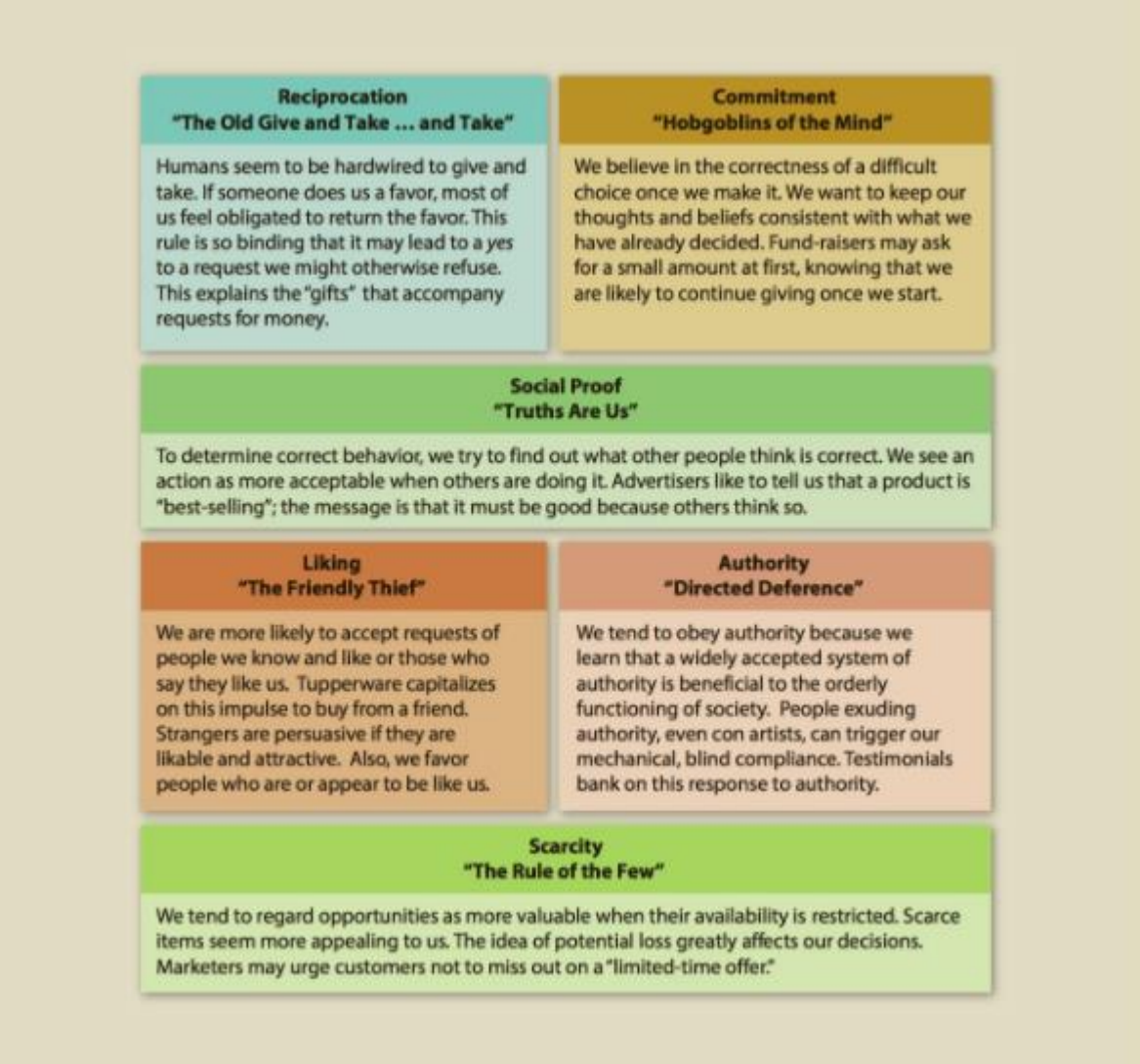


Figure 3.9 Six Basic Principles that Direct Human Behaviour

Applying the 3-x-3 Writing Process to Persuasive Messages

Changing people's views and overcoming their objections are difficult tasks. Pulling it off demands planning and being perceptive. The 3-x-3 writing process provides a helpful structure for laying a foundation for persuasion. Of particular importance here are (a) analyzing the purpose, (b) adapting to the audience, (c) collecting information, and (d) organizing the message.

• **Analyzing the Purpose: Knowing What You Want to Achieve.** The goal of a persuasive message is to convert the receiver to your ideas and motivate action. To accomplish this feat in the age of social media, persuaders seek to build relationships with their audiences. Even so, a message without a clear purpose is doomed. Too often, inexperienced writers reach the end of the first draft of a message before discovering exactly what they want the receiver to think or do.

• **Adapting to the Audience to Make Your Message Heard.** In addition to identifying the purpose of a persuasive message, you also need to concentrate on the receiver. A persuasive

message is futile unless it meets the needs of its audience. In a broad sense, you want to show how your request helps the receiver achieve some of life's major goals or fulfils key needs: money, power, comfort, confidence, importance, friends, peace of mind, and recognition, to name a few. On a more practical level, you want to show how your request solves a problem, achieves a personal or work objective, or just makes life easier for your audience.

• **Researching and Organizing Persuasive Data.** Once you have analyzed the audience and considered how to adapt your message to its needs, you are ready to collect data and organize it. You might brainstorm and prepare cluster diagrams to provide a rough outline of ideas. The next step in a persuasive message is organizing data into a logical sequence. If you are asking for something that you know will be approved, little persuasion is required. However, when you expect resistance or when you need to educate the receiver, the indirect strategy often works better. The classic indirect strategy known by the acronym AIDA works well for many persuasive requests, not just in selling. Figure 3.10 summarizes this four-part strategy for overcoming resistance and crafting successful persuasive messages.

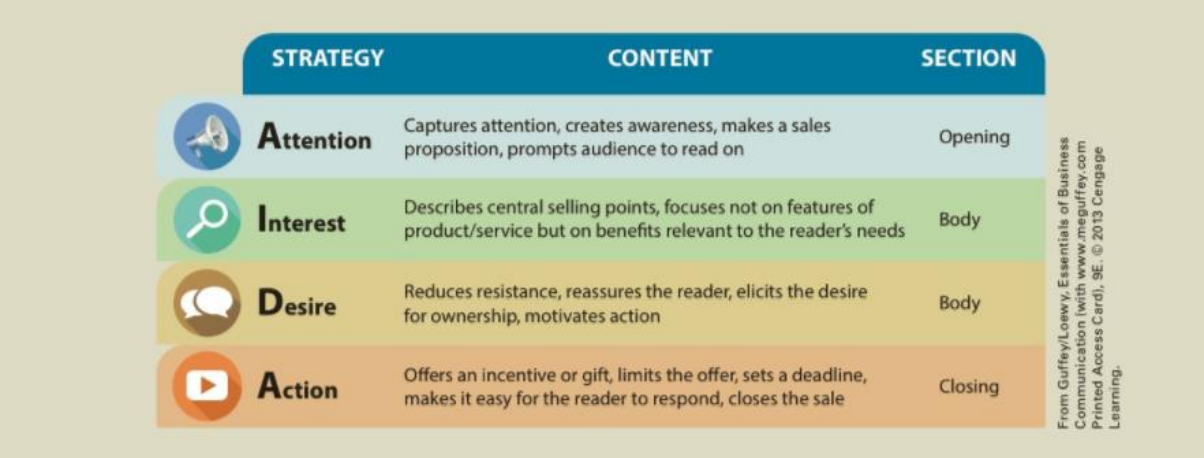


Figure 3.10: The AIDA Strategy for Persuasive Messages

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 10: Page 343

3.10 Creating effective sales messages in print and online

The best sales messages, whether delivered by direct mail or by e-mail, have much in common. They use persuasion to promote specific products and services. In our coverage we are most concerned with sales messages delivered by postal mail or by e-mail.

Applying the 3-x-3 Writing Process to Sales Messages

Marketing professionals analyse and perfect every aspect of a sales message to encourage consumers to read and act on the message. Like the experts, you will want to pay close attention to analysis and adaptation before writing the actual message.

• **Analysing the Product.** Prior to sitting down to write a sales message promoting a product, you must study the item carefully. What can you learn about its design, construction, raw materials, and manufacturing process? What can you learn about its ease of use, efficiency, durability, and applications? Be sure to consider warranties, service, price, premiums, exclusivity, and special appeals. At the same time, evaluate the competition so that you can compare your product's strengths with the competitor's weaknesses.

Determining the Purpose of a Sales Message. Equally as important as analysing the product is determining the specific purpose of your message. Do you want the reader to call for a free video and brochure? Listen to a podcast at your website? Fill out an order form? Send a credit card authorization? Before you write the first word of your message, know what response you want and what central selling point you will emphasize to achieve that purpose.

Adapting a Sales Message to Its Audience. Despite today's predominance of e-mail marketing over direct-mail letters, in terms of response rates, sales letters win by a mile. Direct mail achieves a 3.7 percent response rate compared with e-mail's paltry 0.1 percent. Even all digital channels combined achieve a response rate of 0.62 percent. Overall, though, despite its effectiveness, direct mail is used less and less; only half of respondents in a study said they are using this channel, primarily because of its cost and the effort it demands. The response rate can be increased dramatically by targeting the audience through selected database mailing lists.

Crafting Successful Sales Messages

Direct mail is usually part of multichannel marketing campaigns. These messages are a powerful means to make sales, generate leads, boost retail traffic, solicit donations, and direct consumers to websites. Direct mail is a great channel for personalized, tangible, three-dimensional messages that are less invasive than telephone solicitations and less reviled than unsolicited e-mail. A recent study shows that tangible direct mail appears to have a greater emotional impact than virtual mail. Figure 3.11 juxtaposes the most relevant features of traditional direct-mail and online sales messages.



Figure 3.11 Characteristics of Traditional Versus Online Sales Messages

3.11 Developing persuasive press releases

Press (news) releases announce important information to the media, whether traditional or digital. Such public announcements can feature new products, new managers, new facilities, sponsorships, participation in community projects, awards given or received, joint ventures, donations, or seminars and demonstrations. Naturally, organizations hope that the media will pick up this news and provide good publicity. However, purely self-serving or promotional information is not appealing to magazine and newspaper editors or to TV producers. To get them to read beyond the first sentence, press release writers follow these principles:

• Open with an attention-getting lead or a summary of the important facts.

• Include answers to the five Ws and one H (who, what, when, where, why, and how) in the

article—but not all in the first sentence!

• Appeal to the audience of the target media. Emphasize reader benefits written in the style of the focus publication or newscast.

• Present the most important information early, followed by supporting information. Don't put your best ideas last because they may be chopped off or ignored.

• Insert intriguing and informative quotations of chief decision makers to lend the news release credibility.



Chapter Summary/Review

1. Understand e-mail, memos, and the professional standards for their usage, structure, and format in the digital era workplace.

- The exchange of information in organizations today is increasingly digital and mobile.
- Office workers still send paper-based messages when they need a permanent record; wish to maintain confidentiality; and need to convey formal, long, and important messages.

2. Compose direct messages that make requests, respond to inquiries online and offline, and deliver step-by-step instructions.

- In messages requesting information or action, state the purpose in the opening; explain the request in the body; express any questions in a parallel and grammatically balanced form; and close by telling the reader courteously what to do while showing appreciation.
- In complying with requests, deliver the good news in the opening; explain and provide additional information in the body; and write a cordial, personalized closing that tells the reader how to proceed if action is needed.

3. Prepare contemporary messages that make direct claims and voice complaints, including those posted online.

- When you compose a message to identify a wrong and request a correction, you are writing a claim; direct claims are requests to which receivers are expected to readily agree.
- Begin by describing the problem or action to be taken; in the message body explain the request without emotion; in the closing summarize the request or action to be taken. Include an end date, if applicable, and express faith in future business if the problem is resolved.

4. Distinguish between the direct and indirect strategies in conveying unfavourable news.

- Use the direct strategy, with the bad news first, when the news is not damaging, when the receiver may overlook it, when the organization or receiver prefers directness, or when firmness is necessary.
- Use the indirect strategy, with a buffer and explanation preceding the bad news, when the bad news is personally upsetting, when it may provoke a hostile reaction, when it threatens the customer relationship, and when the news is unexpected.

5. Explain the components of effective negative messages, including opening with a buffer, apologizing, showing empathy, presenting the reasons, cushioning the bad news, and closing pleasantly.

- To soften bad news, start with a buffer such as the best news, a compliment, appreciation, agreement, facts, understanding, or an apology.
- Explain the reasons that necessitate the bad news, trying to cite benefits to the reader or others.



Review Questions (Short)

1. If facing the choice between safety and privacy, which would you choose? How concerned are you about privacy and security online? Do you watch your own privacy settings?
2. Why is it smart to keep your cool when making a claim, and how should you go about it?
3. Why is it important to regain the confidence of a customer in an adjustment message? How can it be done?
4. Respected industry analyst Gartner Research issued a report naming social networking as one of the top ten disruptive (i.e., innovative) influences shaping information technology in the next five years. Should organizations fear websites where consumers post negative messages about products and services? What actions can companies take in response to this disruptive influence?
5. How are direct-mail sales letters and e-mail sales messages similar, and how are they different?



Review Questions (Long)

1. Polychron, Inc., is considering launching an internship program, and Camille Montano, manager of Human Resources, seeks information from members of the management team.
Study the first draft of her hastily written message and list its weaknesses. Then revise it to create a concise, clear message.
To: Jackson Prewarski
From: Camille Montano
Subject: Interns?
Hi, Jackson,
You may remember that some time ago our management team here at Polychron talked about an internship program. The topic has come up again at this time, and I'm taking this opportunity to ask you to please answer some questions about whether this is a good idea or not. As our organization continues to expand, interns might make sense. But there are many points that we need to discuss, and I've put together a few questions that I think we

should cover at the next management meeting. Please mark your calendar to meet on March 14 at 9 a.m. in the morning.

First, we really need to discuss whether an internship program is advantageous to us here at Polychron. In addition, what are the disadvantages? Next, what are some of the ramifications legally of hosting an internship program here in our state? Another question that enters my mind is whether we should pay interns. Do they receive college credit instead? I wonder if that serves as satisfactory compensation. Finally, we need to discuss where this program would be launched within Polychron. What departments to pilot such a program?

I hope you will give careful thought to these questions and come prepared to discuss.

Camille
[Full contact information]

2. Select a product or service that has disappointed you. Write a claim letter requesting a refund, replacement, explanation, or whatever seems reasonable. Generally, such letters are addressed to customer service departments. For claims about food products, be sure to include bar code identification from the package, if possible. Give your ideas for improvement.

3. As a vice president of a financial services company, you serve many clients, and they sometimes ask your company to contribute to their favourite charities. You recently received a letter from Elliana Larios asking for a substantial contribution to the National Court Appointed Special Advocate (CASA) Association. On visits to your office, she has told you about its programs to recruit, train, and support volunteers in their work with abused children. She herself is active in your town as a CASA volunteer, helping neglected children find safe, permanent homes. She told you that children with CASA volunteers are more likely to be adopted and are less likely to re-enter the child welfare system.

You have a soft spot in your heart for children and especially for those who are mistreated. You sincerely want to support CASA and its good work. But times are tough, and you can't be as generous as you have been in the past. Ms. Larios wrote a special letter to you asking you to become a Key contributor, with a pledge of $2,000.

Write a refusal letter that maintains good relations with your client. Address it to Ms. Elliana Larios, 8569 East 39th Street, Phoenix, AZ 85730.

4. You saw an interesting article describing a Suitable Suits program at Barnard College. Its College of Career Development kept a closet filled with 21 crisp black suits that students could borrow for job interviews. Students made an appointment with the office and agreed to dry clean the suits before returning them. At Barnard the program was paid for with a grant from a

	prominent financial firm. You think that a Suitable Suits program is worth exploring with your dean. Write a persuasive message requesting an appointment with your dean to discuss a Suitable Suits program at your school. You don't have all the answers and you are not sure how such a program would operate, but you think the idea is worth discussing. Can you convince the dean to see you? Should you write an e-mail or a letter?



Case Studies / Projects

JetBlue: Speedy Customer Service with Humour

JetBlue, the low-cost airline renowned for its superior customer service, handles thousands of routine messages each day. Because the company's on-the-go travellers need real-time answers, one of JetBlue's primary channels for communicating with them is Twitter. The social media site allows the airline to quickly engage with customers who tweet typical business messages, from neutral inquiries about airline policies to positive messages about JetBlue's service — and the occasional complaint. How companies engage with negative messages.

Responses to routine messages use the direct strategy, which is well suited for brief tweets. JetBlue's 25 Twitter customer service reps analyse each situation, organize their ideas for coherence, and frame replies to yield positive outcomes. What's more, the goal is to do all that within ten minutes of receiving a tweet!

One of the reasons social media work so well for JetBlue's routine communication is that the one-on-one conversations are an excellent way to build goodwill. One happy customer recently wrote, "Great customer service and comfortable plane. I like the added space between seats," to which a JetBlue employee responded, "Thanks, Keara! Sit back, relax, and enjoy!" The cheerful response helps the customer connect with the airline and reinforces its reputation for superior customer service. JetBlue responders are also known for their humour. A customer about to take off recently sent a tweet emulating the flight attendant's distinctive Boston accent, "Ladies and gentlemen, we've now closed the boahrdin' doorah now depahting' off to Boston." The customer service rep continued the joke with the reply, "Wicked good. You got that accent down! Enjoy your flight to Boston!" Sprinkling in such informal dashes of humour reinforces JetBlue's strategy of using Twitter to build goodwill with its customers.

REQUIRED:

• Why are tweets particularly effective for composing direct responses to routine inquiries?

• When JetBlue customer service representatives engage with customers who have inquired about the airline's products or services, is it appropriate to do more than just answer the question?

• Why do organizations such as JetBlue, Walmart, and Amazon embrace customer comments, some of which may not be positive?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 8: Page 253



LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Locate and evaluate secondary sources such as databases and Internet resources, and understand how to conduct credible primary research.
- Analyse, sort, and interpret statistical data and other information using tables, measures of central tendency (mean, median, and mode), and decision matrices.
- Discuss the components of formal and grant proposals.
- Identify the components of typical business plans.
- Recognize various types of business presentations, and discuss two important first steps in preparing for any of these presentations.

Introduction

Digital age organizations compete in a world of constant change facilitated by innovative technology and the ability to generate and share vast amounts of data. Efficient reporting plays a critical role in helping organizations sift through data and make major decisions. Whether a company decides to launch a new product, expand into new markets, reduce expenses, improve customer service, or increase its social media presence, the decisions are usually based on information submitted in reports. Routine reports keep managers informed about work in progress. Focused, in-depth reports help managers analyse the challenges they face before recommending solutions.

4.1 Identifying secondary sources and conducting primary research

Research, or the gathering of information, is one of the most important steps in writing a report. As you analyse a report's purpose and audience and prepare your research strategy, you will identify and assess the data you need to support your argument or explain your topic. As you do, you will answer questions about your objectives and audience: Will the audience need a lot of background or contextual information? Will your readers value or trust statistics, case

studies, or expert opinions? Will they want to see data from interviews or surveys? Will summaries of focus groups be useful? Should you rely on organizational data?

Locating Secondary Sources

Data fall into two broad categories: primary and secondary. Primary data result from first- hand experience and observation. Secondary data come from reading what others have experienced or observed and written down.

• **Print Resources.** Although we are seeing a steady movement away from print data and toward electronic data, print sources are still the most visible part of most libraries. Much information is available only in print.

- **Books.** Although quickly outdated, books provide excellent historical, in-depth data. Like most contemporary sources, books can be located through online listings.
- **Online catalogs.** Most libraries today have digitized their card catalogs, allowing users to learn whether a book is located in the library and currently available. Moreover, online catalogs can help you trace and borrow items from other area libraries through inter- library loan if your college doesn't own them.
- **Card catalogs.** Very few libraries still maintain card catalogs with all books indexed on 3-by-5 cards alphabetized by author, title, and subject.
- **Periodicals.** Magazines, pamphlets, and journals are called periodicals because of their recurrent, or periodic, publication. Journals are compilations of scholarly articles. Articles in journals and other periodicals are extremely useful because they are concise, limited in scope, and current and can supplement information in books. Current publications are digitized and available in full text online, often as PDF documents.
- **Indexes.** University libraries today offer online access to *The Readers' Guide to Periodical Literature*, an index now offered by EBSCO, a major provider of online databases. Contemporary business writers rely almost totally on electronic indexes and research databases to locate references, abstracts, and full-text articles from magazines, journals, and newspapers, such as *The New York Times.*

• **Research Databases.** As a writer of business reports today, you will probably begin your secondary research with electronic resources. Online databases have become the staple of secondary research. Most writers turn to them first because they are fast and easy to use. You can conduct detailed searches without ever leaving your office, home, or dorm room. A database is a collection of information stored digitally so that it is accessible by computer or mobile electronic devices and searchable. Databases provide bibliographic information (titles of documents and brief abstracts) and full-text documents. Databases contain a rich array of magazine, newspaper, and journal articles, as well as newsletters, business reports, company profiles, government data, reviews, and directories. The five databases most useful to business writers are ABI/INFORM Complete (ProQuest), Business Source Premier (EBSCO), JSTOR Business, Factiva (Dow Jones), and LexisNexis Academic.

The Web

If you are like most adults today, you probably use the Web for entertainment and work every day. Chances are you have a Facebook or Instagram page, and perhaps you play one of the countless free online games. You have probably looked up directions on Google Maps and may have bid on or sold items on eBay. You are likely to download ringtones for your smartphone, and perhaps you listen to music streaming on Spotify or Pandora. In short, you rely on the Internet daily for information and entertainment. In this section we examine the Web as an effective research tool.

• **Web Search Tools.** Finding what you are looking for on the Web is hopeless without powerful, specialized search tools, such as Google, Bing, Yahoo Search, and Ask. These search tools can be divided into two types: subject (or Web) directories and search engines. In addition, some search engines (e.g., Dogpile and Search.com), also called aggregators, specialize in metasearching. This means that they combine several powerful search engines into one. Search engines differ in the way they trawl the vast amount of data on the Web. Google uses automated software, called bots, that regularly collect and index the information from each Web location visited. To get the most from Google, try the Advanced search feature. It resembles the query fields in research databases and allows you to narrow your searches more effectively than you can when you rely on a simple search and thus obtain only the most popular results that Google displays first. Some search tools (e.g., Ask) use natural-language-processing technology to enable you to ask questions to gather information.

• **Applying Internet Search Strategies and Techniques.** To conduct a thorough search for the information you need, build a (re)search strategy by understanding the tools available. Figure 4.1 outlines several effective search techniques.



Figure 4.1 Useful Internet Search Techniques

To improve your odds of discovering more relevant sources, try these additional research strategies used by successful Internet sleuths:

• **Learn basic Boolean search strategies.** You can save yourself a lot of time and frustration by narrowing your search with the following Boolean operators:

AND	Identifies only documents containing all of the specified words: employee AND productivity AND morale
OR	Identifies documents containing at least one of the specified words: employee OR productivity OR morale
NOT	Excludes documents containing the specified word: employee productivity NOT morale

• **Keep trying.** If a search produces no results, check your spelling. If you are using Boolean operators, check the syntax of your queries. Try synonyms and variations on words. Try to be less specific in your search term. If your search produces too many hits, try to be more specific. Use the Advanced feature of your search engine to narrow your search. Think of words that uniquely identify what you are looking for. Use as many relevant keywords as possible.

• **Repeat your search a week later.** For the best results, return to your search a couple of days or a week later. The same keywords will probably produce additional results. That's because millions of new pages are being added to the Web every day. The ranking of hits can also change depending on how often a link is accessed by Internet users.

Credibility of Internet Sources. Most Internet users tend to assume that any information turned up by a search engine has somehow been evaluated as part of a valid selection process. Wrong! Unlike library-based research, information at many sites has not undergone the editing or scrutiny of scholarly publication procedures. The information we read in journals and most reputable magazines is reviewed, authenticated, and evaluated. Information on the Web is much less reliable than information from traditional sources.

Conducting Primary Research

Although you will start nearly every business report assignment by sifting through secondary sources, you may sometimes need primary data to give a complete picture. Business reports that solve specific current problems typically rely on primary, firsthand data.

• **Surveys.** Surveys collect data from groups of people. Before developing new products, for example, companies often survey consumers to learn their needs. The advantages of surveys are that they gather data economically and efficiently.

- **Explain why the survey is necessary.** In a cover letter or an opening paragraph, describe the need for the survey. Suggest how someone or something other than you will benefit. If appropriate, offer to send recipients a copy of the findings.

- **Consider incentives.** If the survey is long, persuasive techniques may be necessary. Response rates can be increased by offering money, coupons, gift certificates, books, or other gifts.
- **Limit the number of questions.** Resist the temptation to ask for too much. Request only information you will use. Don't, for example, include demographic questions unless the information is necessary to evaluate responses.
- **Make it easy for respondents to return the survey.** Researchers often provide prepaid self-addressed envelopes or business-reply envelopes. Survey software such as SurveyMonkey helps users develop simple, template-driven questions and allows survey takers to follow a link to take the survey.
- **Conduct a pilot study.** Try the questionnaire with a small group so that you can remedy any problems. By adding a gender category, researchers could verify this finding. The pilot study also revealed the need to ensure an appropriate representation of male and female student in the survey.

• **Interviews.** Some of the best report information, particularly on topics about which little has been written, comes from individuals. These individuals are usually experts or veterans in their fields. Consider both in-house and outside experts for business reports. Tapping these sources will call for in-person, telephone, or online interviews. To elicit the most useful data, try these techniques:

- Locate an expert. Ask managers and individuals who are considered to be most knowledgeable in their areas. Check membership lists of professional organizations, and consult articles about the topic.
- Prepare for the interview. Learn about the individual you are interviewing, and make sure you can pronounce the interviewee's name. Research the background and terminology of the topic.
- Maintain a professional attitude. Call before the interview to confirm the arrangements, and then arrive on time. Be prepared to take notes if your recorder fails (and remember to ask permission beforehand if you want to record). Use your body language to convey respect.
- Make your questions objective and friendly. Adopt a courteous and respectful attitude. Don't get into a debating match with the interviewee, and don't interrupt. Remember that you are there to listen, not to talk! Use open-ended questions to draw experts out.
- Watch the time. Tell interviewees in advance how much time you expect to need for the interview. Don't overstay your appointment. If your subject rambles, gently try to draw him or her back to the topic; otherwise, you may run out of time before asking all your questions.
- End graciously. Conclude the interview with a general question, such as Is there anything you would like to add? Express your appreciation, and ask permission to telephone later if you need to verify points.

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 11: Page 408

4.2 Analyzing digital age data

Much of the information that allows decision makers to run their organizations efficiently in this digital age comes to them in the form of reports. To respond nimbly to changing economic times, Starbucks and other businesses need information to stay abreast of what is happening inside and outside of their firms.

Tabulating and Analyzing Data

After collecting numerical data and other information, you must tabulate and analyze them. Fortunately, several techniques can help you simplify, summarize, and classify large amounts of data. The most helpful summarizing techniques are tables, statistical concepts (mean, median, and mode), correlations, grids, and decision matrices.

Tables. Tables usually help researchers summarize and simplify data. Using columns and rows, tables make quantitative information easier to comprehend. After assembling your data, you will want to prepare preliminary tables to enable you to see what the information means. Here is a table summarizing the response to one question from a campus survey about student parking:

Question: Should student fees be increased to build parking lots?

	Number	Percentage	
Strongly agree	76	11.5	**To simplify the table, combine these items.**
Agree	255	38.5	**50 percent support the proposal**
No opinion	22	3.3	
Disagree	107	16.1	**To simplify the table, combine these items.**
Strongly disagree	203	30.6	**46.7 (nearly 47) percent oppose the proposal**
Total	**663**	**100.0**	

Notice that this preliminary table includes a total number of responses and a percentage for each response. (To calculate a percentage, divide the figure for each response by the total number of responses and then multiply the result by 100.)

Sometimes data become more meaningful when cross-tabulated. This process allows us to analyze two or more variables together. By breaking down our student survey data into male and female responses, shown in the following table, we make an interesting discovery.

Question: Should student fees be increased to build parking lots?

	Total		Male			Female		
	Number	Percentage	Number	Percentage		Number	Percentage	
Strongly agree	76	11.5	8	2.2	= 17.5 percent	68	22.0	= 87 percent
Agree	255	38.5	54	15.3		201	65.0	SUPPORT
No opinion	22	3.3	12	3.4		10	3.2	
Disagree	107	16.1	89	25.1	= 79.1 percent	18	5.8	= 9.8 percent
Strongly disagree	203	30.6	191	54.0		12	4.0	OPPOSE
Total	**663**	**100.0**	**354**	**100.0**		**309**	**100.0**	

By cross-tabulating the findings, you sometimes uncover data that may help answer your problem question or that may prompt you to explore other possibilities. Do not, however, undertake cross-tabulation unless it serves more than merely satisfying your curiosity. Tables also help you compare multiple data collected from questionnaires and surveys. Figure 4.2 shows, in raw form, responses to several survey items. To convert these data into a more usable form, you need to calculate percentages for each item. Then you can arrange the responses in some rational sequence, such as largest percentage to smallest.

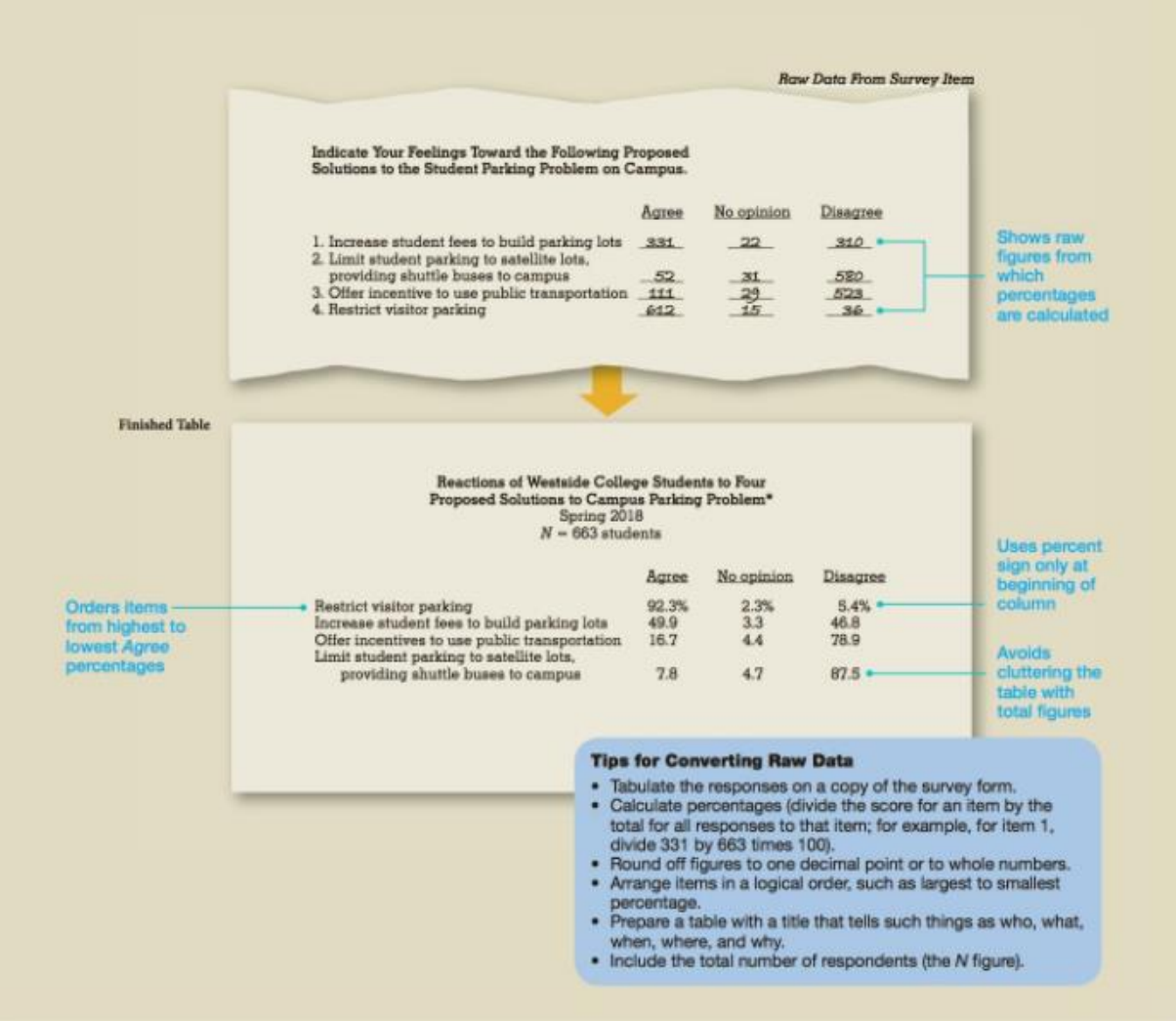


Figure 4.2 Converting Survey Data into Finished Tables

• **Measures of Central Tendency.** Tables help you organize data, and the three Ms—mean, median, and mode—help you describe data. These statistical terms are all occasionally used loosely to mean "average." To be safe, though, you should learn to apply these statistical terms precisely.

When people say average, they usually intend to indicate the mean, or arithmetic average. Let's say that you are studying the estimated starting salaries of graduates from disciplines ranging from education to medicine:

Education	$ 57,000	*Mode (figure occurring most frequently)*
Sociology	57,000	
Humanities	57,000	
Biology	63,000	
Health sciences	73,000	*Median (middle point in continuum)*
Business	76,000	*Mean (arithmetic average)*
Law	84,000	
Engineering	92,000	
Medicine	124,000	

To find the mean, you simply add all the salaries and divide by the total number of items. Therefore, the mean salary is $75,888 (almost $76,000). Means are very useful to indicate central tendencies of figures, but they have one major flaw: extremes at either end cause distortion. Notice that the $124,000 figure makes the mean salary of $76,000 deceptively high. Use means only when extreme figures do not distort the result.

The median represents the midpoint in a group of figures arranged from lowest to highest (or vice versa). In our list of salaries, the median is $73,000 (health sciences). In other words, half the salaries are above this point and half are below it. The median is useful when extreme figures may warp the mean.

The mode is simply the value that occurs most frequently. In our list $57,000 (for education, sociology, and the humanities) represents the mode because it occurs three times. The mode has the advantage of being easily determined—just a quick glance at a list of arranged values reveals it. Although researchers use mode infrequently, knowing the mode is useful in some situations; for example, to determine a group's preferences. To remember the meaning of mode, think about fashion: the most frequent response, the mode, is the most fashionable.

Mean, median, and mode figures are especially helpful when the range of values is also known. Range represents the span between the highest and lowest values. To calculate the range, you simply subtract the lowest figure from the highest. In starting salaries for graduates, the range is $67,000 (124,000 – 57,000). Knowing the range enables readers to put mean and median figures into perspective. This knowledge also prompts researchers to wonder why such a range exists, thus stimulating hunches and further investigation to solve problems.

4.3 Organizing data

After collecting sets of data, interpreting them, drawing conclusions, and thinking about the recommendations, you are ready to organize the parts of the report into a logical framework. Poorly organized reports lead to frustration. Readers will not understand, remember, or be persuaded. Wise writers know that reports rarely "just organize themselves." Instead, the report author must impose organization on the data and provide cues so the reader can follow the logic of the writer. As shown in Figure 4.3, informational reports typically consist of three parts. Analytical reports, which generally analyze data and draw conclusions, typically contain four parts.



Informational Reports	Analytical Reports	
Direct Strategy	**Direct Strategy**	**Indirect Strategy**
I. Introduction/background	I. Introduction/problem	I. Introduction/problem
II. Facts/findings	II. Conclusions/recommendations	II. Facts/findings
III. Summary/conclusion	III. Facts/findings	III. Discussion/analysis
	IV. Discussion/analysis	IV. Conclusions/recommendations

Figure 4.3 Organizational Strategies for Informational and Analytical Reports

Ordering Information Logically

Whether you are writing informational or analytical reports, you must structure the data you have collected. Five common organizational methods are by time, component, importance, criteria, and convention. Regardless of the method you choose, be sure that it helps the reader understand the data.

•**Time**. Ordering data by time means establishing a chronology of events. Agendas, minutes of meetings, progress reports, and procedures are usually organized by time. For example, a report describing an eight-week training program would most likely be organized by weeks. A plan for the step-by-step improvement of customer service would be organized by steps. A monthly trip report submitted by a sales rep might describe customers visited during Week 1, Week 2, and so on.

•**Component.** Especially for informational reports, data may be organized by components such as location, geography, division, product, or part. For instance, a report detailing company expansion might divide the plan into West Coast, East Coast, and Midwest expansion.

•**Importance.** Organization by importance involves beginning with the most important item and proceeding to the least important—or vice versa. For example, a report discussing the reasons for declining product sales would present the most important reason first followed by less important ones.

•**Criteria.** Establishing criteria by which to judge helps writers to treat topics consistently. Let's say your report compares health plans A, B, and C. For each plan you examine the same standards: cost per employee, amount of deductible, and patient benefits.

•**Convention.** Many operational and recurring reports are structured according to convention. That is, they follow a prescribed plan that everyone understands. For example, an automotive parts manufacturer might ask all sales reps to prepare a weekly report with these headings: Competitive observations (competitors' price changes, discounts, new products, product problems, distributor changes, product promotions), Product problems (quality, performance, needs), and Customer service problems (delivery, mailings, correspondence, social media, Web traffic).

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 12: Page 447

4.4 Writing short informational reports

Informational reports often describe periodic, recurring activities (such as monthly sales or weekly customer calls) as well as situational, nonrecurring events (such as trips, conferences, and special projects). Short informational reports may also take the form of summaries of longer publications. Most informational reports have one thing in common: a neutral or receptive audience. The readers of informational reports do not have to be persuaded; they simply need to be informed.

Summaries

A summary compresses the main points from a book, report, article, website, meeting, or convention. A summary saves time by reducing a report or article by 85 to 95 percent. In writing a summary, follow these general guidelines:

• Present the goal or purpose of the document being summarized. Why was it written?

• Highlight the research methods (if appropriate), findings, conclusions, and recommendations.

• Omit illustrations, examples, and references.

• Organize for readability by including headings and bulleted or enumerated lists.

• Include your reactions or an overall evaluation of the document if asked to do so.

Effective Document Design

Desktop publishing packages, sophisticated word processing programs, and high-quality laser printers now make it possible for you to turn out professional-looking documents and promotional materials. Resist the temptation, however, to overdo it by incorporating too many features in one document.

Periodic (Activity) Reports

Most businesses—especially larger ones—require periodic reports (sometimes called activity reports) to keep management informed of operations. These recurring reports are written at regular intervals—weekly, monthly, yearly—so that management can monitor business strategies and, if necessary, remedy any problems. In preparing a narrative description of their activities, employees writing periodic reports usually do the following:

• Summarize regular activities and events performed during the reporting period

• Describe irregular events deserving the attention of management

• Highlight special needs and problems

Trip, Convention, and Conference Reports

Employees sent on business trips or to conventions and conferences typically must submit reports when they return. Organizations want to know that their money was well spent in funding the travel. Here is a general outline for trip, conference, and convention reports:

• Begin by identifying the event (exact date, name, and location) and previewing the topics to be discussed.

• Summarize in the body three to five main points that might benefit the reader.

• Itemize your expenses, if requested, on a separate sheet.

• Close by expressing appreciation, suggesting action to be taken, or synthesizing the value of the trip or event.

Progress and Interim Reports

Continuing projects often require progress or interim reports to describe their status. These reports may be external (advising customers about the headway of their projects) or internal (informing management of the status of activities). Progress reports typically follow this pattern of development:

• Specify in the opening the purpose and nature of the project.

• Provide background information if the audience requires filling in.

• Describe the work completed.

• Explain the work currently in progress, including personnel, activities, methods, and locations.

• Describe current problems and anticipate future problems and possible remedies.

• Discuss future activities and provide the expected completion date.

Investigative Reports

Investigative reports deliver data for specific situations—without offering interpretations or recommendations. These nonrecurring reports are generally arranged using the direct strategy with three segments: introduction, body, and summary. The body—which includes the facts, findings, or discussion—may be organized by time, component, importance, criteria, or convention. What is important is dividing the topic into logical segments—say, three to five areas that are roughly equal and do not overlap.

4.5 Preparing short analytical reports

You may recall that informational reports generally provide data only. This section describes three common types of analytical business reports: (a) justification/recommendation reports, (b) feasibility reports, and (c) yardstick reports.

Justification/Recommendation Reports

Both managers and employees must occasionally write reports that justify or recommend actions, such as buying equipment, changing a procedure, hiring an employee, consolidating departments, or investing funds. These reports may also be called internal proposals because their persuasive nature is similar to that of external proposals.

• **Direct Strategy**. For no sensitive topics and recommendations that will be agreeable to readers, you can organize directly according to the following sequence:

- Identify the problem or need briefly.
- Announce the recommendation, solution, or action concisely and with action verbs.
- Explain more fully the benefits of the recommendation or steps necessary to solve the problem.
- Include a discussion of pros, cons, and costs.
- Conclude with a summary specifying the recommendation and necessary action.

•**Indirect Strategy**. When a reader may oppose a recommendation or when circumstances suggest caution, do not rush to reveal your recommendation. Consider using the following sequence for an indirect approach to your recommendations:

- Refer to the problem in general terms, not to your recommendation, in the subject line.
- Describe the problem or need your recommendation addresses. Use specific examples, supporting statistics, and authoritative quotes to lend credibility to the seriousness of the problem.
- Discuss alternative solutions, beginning with the least likely to succeed.
- Present the most promising alternative (your recommendation) last.
- Show how the advantages of your recommendation outweigh its disadvantages.
- Summarize your recommendation. If appropriate, specify the action it requires.
- Ask for authorization to proceed, if necessary.

Feasibility Reports

Feasibility reports examine the practicality and advisability of following a course of action. They answer this question: Will this plan or proposal work? Feasibility reports typically are internal reports written to advise on matters such as consolidating departments, offering a wellness program to employees, or hiring an outside firm to handle a company's accounting or social media presence. In writing feasibility reports, consider these suggestions:

• Announce your decision immediately.

• Provide a description of the background and problem necessitating the proposal.

• Discuss the benefits of the proposal.

• Describe the problems that may result.

• Calculate the costs associated with the proposal, if appropriate.

• Show the time frame necessary for implementing the proposal.

Yardstick Reports

Yardstick reports examine problems with two or more solutions. To determine the best solution, the writer establishes criteria by which to compare the alternatives. The criteria then act as a yardstick against which all the alternatives are measured.

The real advantage to yardstick reports is that alternatives can be measured consistently using the same criteria. Writers using a yardstick approach typically do the following:

• Begin by describing the problem or need.

• Explain possible solutions and alternatives.

• Establish criteria for comparing the alternatives; tell how the criteria were selected or developed.

• Discuss and evaluate each alternative in terms of the criteria

• Draw conclusions and make recommendations

4.6 Preparing formal proposals

Formal proposals differ from informal proposals not in style but in size and format. Formal proposals respond to big projects and may range from 5 to 200 or more pages. Because proposals are vital to the success of many organizations, larger businesses may maintain specialists who do nothing but write proposals. Smaller firms rely on in-house staff to write proposals.

Components of Formal Proposals

To help readers understand and locate the parts of a formal proposal, writers organize the project into a typical structure. In addition to the six basic components described for informal proposals, formal proposals may contain some or all of the following front matter and back matter components.

• **Copy of the RFP**.A copy of the request for proposals may be included in the front matter of a formal proposal. Large organizations may have more than one RFP circulating, in which case identification is necessary.

• **Letter of Transmittal**. A letter of transmittal, usually bound inside formal proposals, addresses the person who is designated to receive the proposal or who will make the final decision. The letter describes how you learned about the problem or confirms that the proposal responds to the enclosed RFP.

• **Abstract or Executive Summary**. An abstract is a brief summary (typically one page) of a proposal's highlights intended for specialists or technical readers. An executive summary also reviews the proposal's highlights, but it is written for managers and should be less technically oriented. An executive summary tends to be longer than an abstract, up to 10 percent of the original text.

•**Title Page**. The title page includes the following items, generally in this order: title of proposal, name of client organization, RFP number or other announcement, date of submission, and the authors' names and/or the name of their organization.

•**Table of Contents**. Because most proposals don't contain an index, the table of contents becomes quite important. A table of contents should include all headings and their beginning page numbers. Items that appear before the contents (copy of RFP, letter of transmittal, abstract, and title page) typically are not listed in the contents. However, any appendixes should be listed.

•**List of Illustrations.** Proposals with many tables and figures often contain a list of illustrations. This list includes each figure or table title and its page number. If you have just a few figures or tables, however, you may omit this list.

•**Appendix(es).** Ancillary material of interest to only some readers goes in appendixes. Appendix A might include résume of the principal investigators or testimonial letters. Appendix B might include examples or a listing of previous projects. Other appendixes could include audit procedures, technical graphics, or professional papers cited in the body of the proposal.

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 13: Page 488

4.7 Creating effective business plans

A business plan is critical for securing financial support of any kind. Such a plan also ensures that you have done your homework and know what you are doing in launching your business. It provides you with a detailed road map to chart a course to success.

Components of Typical Business Plans

A business plan may be defined as a description of a proposed company that explains how it expects to achieve its marketing, financial, and operational goals.

•**Letter of Transmittal**. A letter of transmittal provides contact information for all princi- pals and explains your reason for writing. If you are seeking venture capital or an angel investor, the transmittal letter may become a pitch letter. In that case you would want to include a simple description of your idea and a clear statement of what's in it for the investor. The letter should include a summary of the market, a brief note about the competition, and an explanation of why your business is worthy of investment.

•**Mission Statement**. A business plan mission statement explains the purpose of your business and why it will succeed. Because potential investors will be looking for this mission statement, consider highlighting it with a paragraph heading (Mission Statement) or use bolding or italics.

•**Executive Summary**. Your executive summary, which is written last, highlights the main points of your business plan and should not exceed two pages. It should conclude by introducing the parts of the plan and asking for financial backing.

•**Table of Contents and Company Description**. List the page numbers and topics included in your plan. Identify the form of your business (proprietorship, partnership, or corporation) and its type (merchandising, manufacturing, or service). For existing companies, describe the company's founding, growth, sales, and profit.

•**Product or Service Description**. In jargon-free language, explain what you are providing, how it will benefit customers, and why it is better than existing products or services. For start-ups, explain why the business will be profitable.

•**Market Analysis**. Discuss market characteristics, trends, projected growth, customer behavior, complementary products and services, and barriers to entry. Identify your customers and how you will attract, hold, and increase your market share. Discuss the strengths and weaknesses of your direct and indirect competitors.

•**Operations and Management.** Explain specifically how you will run your business, including location, equipment, personnel, and management. Highlight experienced and well-trained members of the management team and your advisors. Many investors consider this the most important factor in assessing business potential.

•**Financial Analysis**. Outline a realistic startup budget that includes fees for legal and professional services, occupancy, licenses and permits, equipment, insurance, supplies, advertising and promotions, salaries and wages, accounting, income, and utilities. Also present an operating budget that projects costs for personnel, insurance, rent, depreciation, loan payments, salaries, taxes, repairs, and so on. Explain how much money you have, how much you will need to start up, and how much you will need to stay in business.

•**Appendixes**. Provide necessary extras such as managers' résumés, promotional materials, and product photos in appendixes. Most appendixes contain tables that exhibit the sales fore-cast, a personnel plan, anticipated cash flow, profit and loss, and a balance sheet.

4.8 Final writing tips

Formal business reports are not undertaken lightly. They involve considerable effort in all three phases of writing, beginning with analysis of the problem and anticipation of the audience). Researching the data, organizing it into a logical presentation, and composing the first draft,

make up the second phase of writing. Editing, proof- reading, and evaluating are completed in the third phase. The following tips offer advice in problem areas faced by most writers of formal reports:

• **Allow sufficient time**. The main reason given by writers who are disappointed with their reports is "I just ran out of time." Develop a realistic timetable and stick to it.

• **Finish data collection**. Do not begin writing until you have collected all the data and drawn the primary conclusions. Starting too early often results in having to backtrack. For reports based on survey data, complete the tables and figures first.

•**Work from a good outline**. A big project such as a formal report needs the order and direction provided by a clear outline, even if the outline has to be revised as the project unfolds.

• **Create a proper writing environment**. You will need a quiet spot where you can spread out your materials and work without interruption. Formal reports demand blocks of concentration time.

• **Use the features of your computer wisely**. Your word processor enables you to keyboard quickly; revise easily; and check spelling, grammar, and synonyms readily. A word of warning, though: save your document often and keep backup copies in the cloud, on disks, or on other devices.

• **Write rapidly; revise later**. Some experts advise writers to record their ideas quickly and save revision until after the first draft is completed. They say that quick writing avoids wasted effort spent in polishing sentences or even sections that may be cut later.

• **Save difficult sections**. If some sections are harder to write than others, save them until you have developed confidence and a rhythm from working on easier topics.

• **Be consistent in verb tense**. Use past-tense verbs to describe completed action. Use present-tense verbs, however, to explain current actions.

• **Generally, avoid I and we**. To make formal reports seem as objective and credible as possible, most writers omit first-person pronouns. This formal style sometimes results in the overuse of passive-voice verbs.

• **Let the first draft sit**. After completing the first version, put it aside for a day or two. Return to it with the expectation of revising and improving it. Don't be afraid to make major changes.

• **Revise for clarity**, coherence, and conciseness. Read a printed copy out loud. Do the sentences make sense? Do the ideas flow together naturally? Can wordiness and flabbiness be cut out?

•**Proofread the final copy three times.** First, read a printed copy slowly for word meanings and content. Then read the copy again for spelling, punctuation, grammar, and other mechanical errors. Finally, scan the entire report to check its formatting and consistency.

4.9 Creating effective business presentations

A common part of a business professional's life is making presentations. Some presentations are informative, whereas others are persuasive. Some are face-to-face; others, virtual. Some

are performed before big audiences, whereas others are given to smaller groups. Some presentations are elaborate; others are simple. Figure 4.4 shows a sampling of business presentations you may encounter in your career.



Figure 4.4 Types of Business Presentations

Knowing Your Audience

As in any type of communication, a second key element in preparation is analyzing your audience, anticipating the reactions of audience members, and adjusting to their needs if necessary. Analyze the following questions to determine your organizational pattern, delivery style, and supporting material.

• How will this topic appeal to this audience?

• How can I relate this information to my listeners' needs?

• How can I earn respect so that they accept my message?

• What would be most effective in making my point? Facts? Statistics? Personal experiences? Expert opinion? Humor? Cartoons? Graphic illustrations? Demonstrations? Case histories? Analogies?

• What measures must I take to ensure that this audience remembers my main points?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 14: Page 523

4.10 Preparing engaging multimedia presentations

When operated by proficient designers and skilful presenters, PowerPoint, Keynote, or Prezi can add visual impact to any presentation. With any software program, of course, gaining expertise requires an investment of time and effort.

Adjusting Slide Design to Your Audience

Think about how you can design your presentation to get the most positive response from your audience. Audiences respond, for example, to the colors, images, and special effects you use.

• **The Meaning of Color**. Adapt the slide colors based on where you will give the presentation. Use light text on a dark background for presentations in darkened rooms. Use dark text on a light background for presentations in lighted rooms. Avoid using a dark font on a dark background, such as red text on a dark blue background. In the same way, avoid using a light font on a light background, such as white text on a pale blue background.

•**The Power of Images**. Adapt the amount of text on your slide to how your audience will use the slides. As a general guideline, most graphic designers encourage the 6-x-6 rule: "Six bullets per screen, max; six words per bullet, max." When using presentation software such as PowerPoint, try to avoid long, boring bulleted lists. You can alter layouts by repositioning, resizing, or changing the fonts for the placeholders in which your title, bulleted list, organization chart, video clip, photograph, or other elements appear. Figure 4.5 shows how to make your slides visually more appealing and memorable even with relatively small changes.



Figure 4.5 Using Images and Illustrations for Greater Impact

• **The Impact of Special Effects**. Just as you anticipate audience members' reactions to color, you can usually anticipate their reactions to special effects. Using animation and sound effects— flying objects, swirling text, clashing cymbals, and the like—only because they are available is not a good idea. Special effects distract your audience, drawing attention away from your main points. You should add animation features only if doing so helps convey your message or adds interest to the content.

Building Your Business Presentation

After considering design principles and their effects, you are ready to start putting together your presentation.

• **Organizing Your Presentation**. When you prepare your presentation, translate the major headings in your outline into titles for slides. Then build bullet points using short phrases. The slides (or canvas) you create to accompany your spoken ideas can be organized with visual elements that will help your audience understand and remember what you want to communicate.

•**Composing Your Presentation**. During the composition stage, many users fall into the trap of excessive formatting and programming. They fritter away precious time fine-tuning their slides or canvas and don't spend enough time on what they are going to say and how they will say it. To avoid this trap, set a limit for how much time you will spend making your slides or canvas visually appealing. Your time limit will be based on how many "bells and whistles" (a) your audience expects and (b) your content requires to make it understandable. Create a slide or canvas only if it accomplishes at least one of the following purposes:

- Generates interest in what you are saying and helps the audience follow your ideas
- Highlights points you want your audience to remember
- Introduces or reviews your key points
- Provides a transition from one major point to the next
- Illustrates and simplifies complex ideas

•**Working with Templates**. All presentation programs require you to (a) select or create a template that will serve as the background for your presentation and (b) make each individual slide by selecting a layout that best conveys your message.

•**Revising and Proofreading Your Presentation**. This is the time to focus on making your presentation as clear and concise as possible. If you are listing items, be sure they all use parallel grammatical form. As you are revising, check carefully to find spelling, grammar, punctuation, and other errors.

•**Evaluating Your Presentation**. The final stage in applying the 3-x-3 writing process to developing a PowerPoint, SlideRocket, or Prezi presentation involves evaluation. Is your message presented in a visually appealing way? Have you tested your slides on the equipment and in the room you will be using during your presentation? Do the colors you selected work in this new setting? Are the font styles and sizes readable from the back of the room?

4.11 Developing intercultural and team presentations

Most of the information presented thus far assumes you are a single presenter before a traditional audience. However, in this digital global world of work, presentations take on myriad forms and purposes. Now we'll explore effective techniques for adapting presentations to inter- cultural audiences and participating in team presentations.

Adapting Presentations to Intercultural Audiences

Every good speaker adapts to the audience, and intercultural presentations call for special adjustments and sensitivity. Most people understand that they must speak slowly, choose simple English, avoid jargon and clichés, use short sentences, and pause frequently when communicating with non-native speakers of English.

•**Understanding Different Values and Nonverbal Behaviors**. In addressing inter- cultural audiences, anticipate expectations and perceptions that may differ significantly from what you may consider normal. Remember, for example, that the North American emphasis on getting to the point quickly is not equally prized across the globe. Therefore, think twice about delivering your main idea up front. Many people (notably those in Japanese, Latin American, and Arabic cultures) consider such directness to be brash and inappropriate. Remember that others may not share our cultural emphasis on straightforwardness. Match your presentation and your nonverbal messages to the expectations of your audience.

•**Adjusting Visual Aids to Intercultural Audiences**. Although you may have to exercise greater caution with culturally diverse audiences, you still want to use visual aids to help communicate your message. Find out from your international contact whether you can present in English or will need an interpreter. To ensure clarity and show courtesy, provide handouts in both English and the target language. Never use numbers without projecting or writing them out for all to see.



Chapter Summary/Review

1. Locate and evaluate secondary sources such as databases and Internet resources, and understand how to conduct credible primary research.

- Secondary data may be located by searching for books, periodicals, and newspapers, mostly through electronic indexes and online research databases.
- Popular Internet search tools include Google, Bing, and Yahoo Search, but the retrieved information must be scrutinized for currency, authority, content, and accuracy.

2. Analyse, sort, and interpret statistical data and other information using tables, measures of central tendency (mean, median, and mode), and decision matrices

- To make sense of report information, writers sort it into tables or analyse it by mean (the arithmetic average), median (the midpoint in a group of figures), and mode (the most frequent response); range represents a span between the highest and lowest figures.
- Grids help organize complex data into rows and columns.

3. Discuss the components of formal and grant proposals.

- Formal proposals may include additional parts not found in informal proposals: (a) a copy of the RFP (request for proposals); (b) a letter of transmittal; (c) an abstract or executive summary; (d) a title page; (e) a table of contents; (f) a list of illustrations; and (g) an appendix.
- A grant proposal is a formal document submitted to a government agency or funding organization that explains a project, outlines its budget, and requests grant money that requires no repayment.

4. Identify the components of typical business plans.

- A business plan describes a proposed business and explains how it expects to achieve its marketing, financial, and operational goals.
- Typical business plans include a letter of transmittal, mission statement, executive summary, table of contents, company description, product or service description, market analysis, description of operations and management, financial analysis, and appendixes.

5. Recognize various types of business presentations, and discuss two important first steps in preparing for any of these presentations.

- Speaking skills rank high on employers' wish lists and are crucial to career success.
- Presentations can be informative or persuasive, face-to-face or virtual, performed in front of big audiences or smaller groups, and elaborate or simple.

Review Questions (Short)

1. Anecdotally, it seems a no-brainer that companies that provide perks such as free food, discounts, and generous vacation as well as maternity leave would attract top-notch talent. But more than perks, leadership expert Carmine Gallo claims in a Forbes article, employees love work that seems meaningful to them. The happiest workers are engaged because they believe they have purpose. Reflect on what work means to you and which companies you would like to work for. Do you agree with Gallo? What lends his claims credibility?

2. What technology trends do you think will affect business reporting and delivery in the future?

3. In what ways is a proposal similar to a persuasive sales message?

4. Why do many communication consultants encourage businesspeople to move beyond bullet points? What do they recommend instead, and why?

5. Discuss effective techniques for reducing stage fright.

Review Questions (Long)

1. In conducting research for the following reports, name at least one form of data you will need and questions you should ask to determine whether that set of data is appropriate.
a. A report about the feasibility of an employer-provided preschool day-care program
b. A report by a state boating and waterways commission providing information on the state marinas as they were operated during the most recent fiscal year

2. Nine homes recently sold in your community in the following order and for these amounts: $360,000; $460,000; $360,000; $380,000; $360,000; $420,000; $380,000; $520,000; and $360,000. Your boss, Andrew Santoso, a realtor with Hagen & Associates, wants you to compute the mean, median, and mode for this real estate market.
Compute the mean, median, and mode for the recently sold homes. Explain your analysis as well as the characteristics of each type of "average."

3. Let's say you are a member of a campus business club, such as the Society for the Advancement of Management (SAM), the Finance Association (FA), or the Association of Information Technology Professionals (AITP). Your organization has managed its finances well, and therefore, it is able to fund monthly activities. However, membership dues are insufficient to cover any extras. Identify a need such as a hardware or software purchase, a special

	one-time event that would benefit a great number of students, or officer training. Request one-time funding to cover what you need by writing an unsolicited letter or memo proposal to your assistant dean, who oversees student business clubs. Identify your need or problem, show the benefit of your request, support your claims with evidence. 4. What scares you the most about making a presentation in front of your class? Being tongue-tied? Fearing all eyes on you? Messing up? Forgetting your ideas and looking unprofessional? Discuss the ways to overcome these fears.



Case Studies / Projects

Starbucks: Innovate or Die! The Global Chain That Wants to Remain Local

Amid fierce global competition, Starbucks is reinventing itself with innovative store concepts, constant expansion, and new beverages. The company continues to reign as the world's largest coffee shop chain by number of outlets and revenue, having soared to more than 24,000 retail locations in 70 countries. The specialty coffee roaster and retailer has bolstered its presence in China, its second-largest and fastest-growing market. The company has also entered India, a traditionally tea-loving country. In its own words, Starbucks set out to be "a different kind of company" by providing a unique experience to customers and trying to create a connection "one person, one cup, and one neighborhood at a time." Yet the global behemoth serves a whopping 60 million customers a week and employs almost 240,000 people. With annual sales of $20.2 billion and a market capitalization of $85.3 billion, the company is "firing on all cylinders," according to The Wall Street Journal, even when its stock dips, as it has lately.

Adding to its accolades, Starbucks consistently ranks among the top ten in the Fortune magazine list of the World's Most Admired Companies. It is known for its social responsibility initiatives such as fair-trade coffee sourcing, energy conservation, farmer loans, and ethical employment practices. More- over, the retailer is regularly named among the top 100 on the Forbes list of America's Best Employers, not least because Starbucks gives health insurance and stock options to all employees, whom it calls partners.

REQUIRED:

- Howard Schultz is betting on constant reinvention of his company. He said, "Innovation is in our DNA." What kind of information should Starbucks gather to help it decide whether and how to introduce a new product to avoid pitfalls such as the failed Sorbetto beverage?
- How could Howard Schultz test his assumption that the intimate communal coffee-drinking experience is intact at Starbucks?
- How can collected information be transmitted to Starbucks' decision makers?

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LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Begin a job search by recognizing emerging trends and technologies, exploring your interests, evaluating your qualifications, and investigating career opportunities.
- Develop savvy search strategies by recognizing how job seekers find their jobs and how they use digital tools to explore the open job market.
- Expand your job-search strategies by using both traditional and digital tools in pursuing the hidden job market.
- Organize your qualifications and skills into effective résumé categories.
- Enhance your job search and résumé by taking advantage of today's digital tools.
- Understand the value of cover messages and how to draft and submit a customized message to highlight your candidacy.

Introduction

A successful job search today requires a blend of old and new job-hunting skills. Traditional techniques are still effective, but savvy job candidates must also be ready to act on emerging trends, some of which are presented in Figure 5.1. Job boards, social networks, and mobile technologies have all become indispensable tools in hunting for a job. Surprisingly, however, even in this digital age, personal networking, referrals, and who you know continue to be primary routes to hiring.

If you are fearful of entering a highly competitive job market, think of the many advantages you have. "Organizations are very interested in hiring young people because they have a lot of energy and are willing to do whatever it takes to get the job done," says one career specialist.9 Think about your recent training, current skills, and enthusiasm. Remember, too, that you are less expensive to hire than older, experienced candidates.



Figure 5 .1 Looking at the Latest Trends in Job Searching and Résumés

5.1 Job searching in the digital age

Technology is increasingly an integral part of the job-search process. Nearly every job hunter today has at least one mobile device, and the number of apps for these devices is overwhelming. You can download apps to plan your career, organize the job-search process, scour numerous job boards, receive immediate job alerts, and even arrange lunch dates to network and meet others in your field. Working from a smartphone, you can create, store, and send a résumé at the beach, on the train, or whenever a terrific opening pop up.

Your best plan for completing a successful job search involves a four-step process:

(1) Analyzing yourself

(2) Developing a job-search strategy

(3) Preparing a résumé

(4) Knowing the hiring process, as illustrated in Figure 5.2.



Figure 5.2 Four Steps in a Successful Job Search

Launching Your Job Search with Self-Analysis

The first step in a job search is analyzing your interests and goals and evaluating your qualifications. This means looking inside yourself to explore what you like and dislike so that you can make good employment choices.

Evaluating Your Qualifications

Remember that today's job market is not so much about what you want, but what the employer wants. What assets can you offer? Your responses to the following questions will target your thinking as well as prepare a foundation for your résumé. Always keep in mind, though, that employers seek more than empty assurances; they will want proof of your qualifications.

• What technology skills can you present? What specific software programs are you familiar with, what Internet experience do you have, and what social media skills can you offer?

• Do you communicate well in speech and in writing? Do you know another language? How can you verify these talents?

• What other skills have you acquired in school, on the job, or through activities? How can you demonstrate these skills?

• Do you work well with people? Do you enjoy teamwork? What proof can you offer? Consider extracurricular activities, clubs, class projects, and jobs.

• Are you a leader, self-starter, or manager? What evidence can you offer? What leadership roles have you held?

• Do you learn quickly? Can you think critically? How can you demonstrate these characteristics?

Investigating Career Opportunities

In exploring job opportunities, you will make the best decisions when you can match your interests and qualifications with the requirements and rewards of specific careers. Where can you find the best career data? Here are some suggestions:

• **Visit your campus career center.** Most campus career centers have literature, inventories, career-related software programs, and employment or internship databases that allow you to explore such fields as accounting, finance, office technology, information systems, and hotel management.

• **Search for apps and online help**. Many job-search sites—such as Indeed, Monster, and CareerBuilder—offer career-planning information and resources. One popular app is iPQ Career Planner, a free tool with a 52-question assessment test to zero in on your strengths and weaknesses.

•**Use your library**. Print and online resources in your library are especially helpful. Consult O*NET Occupational Information Network, Dictionary of Occupational Titles, Occupational Outlook Handbook, and Jobs Rated Almanac for information about job requirements, qualifications, salaries, and employment trends.

•**Take a summer job, internship, or part-time position in your field**. Nothing is better than trying out a career. Many companies offer internships and temporary or part- time jobs to begin training college students and to develop relationships with them. An amazing number of interns are hired into full-time positions—57 percent in one recent study.

• **Interview someone in your chosen field**. People are usually flattered when asked to describe their careers. Inquire about needed skills, required courses, financial and other rewards, benefits, working conditions, future trends, and entry requirements.

• **Volunteer with a nonprofit organization**. Many colleges and universities encourage service learning. In volunteering their services, students gain valuable experience, and nonprofits appreciate the expertise and fresh ideas that students bring.

• **Monitor the classified ads.** Early in your college career, begin monitoring want ads and the websites of companies in your career area. Check job availability, qualifications sought, duties, and salary ranges. Don’t wait until you are about to graduate to explore the job market.

5.2 Unlocking the hidden job market with networking

The most successful job candidates seek to transform themselves from unknown into known quantities through networking. More jobs today are found through referrals and person- to-person contacts than through any other method. That's because people trust what they know. Therefore, your goal is to become known to a large network of people, and this means going beyond close friends.

Building a Personal Network

Because most candidates find jobs today through networking, be prepared to work diligently to build your personal networks. This effort involves meeting people and talking to them about your field or industry so that you can gain information and locate job vacancies. Here are three steps that will help you establish your own network:

Step 1. Develop a contact list. Make a list of anyone who would be willing to talk with you about finding a job.

Step 2. Make contacts in person and online. Call the people on your list or connect online. To set up a meeting in person, say, *Hi,_____. I'm looking for a job and I wonder if you could help me out. When could I come over to talk about it?* During your visit be friendly, well organized, polite, and interested in what your contact has to say. Provide a copy of your résumé, and try to keep the conversation centered on your job search. Your goal is to get two or more referrals.

Step 3. Follow up on your referrals. Call or contact the people on your list. You might say something like*, Hello. I'm Stacy Rivera, a friend of Jason Tilden. He suggested that I ask you for help. I'm looking for a position as a marketing trainee, and he thought you might be willing to spare a few minutes and steer me in the right direction*. Don't ask for a job. During your referral interview, ask how the individual got started in this line of work, what he or she likes best (or least) about the work, what career paths exist in the field, and what problems a newcomer must overcome. Most important, ask how a person with your background and skills might get started in the field. Send an informal thank-you note to anyone who helps you in your job search, and stay in touch with the most promising people. Ask whether you could stay in contact every three weeks or so during your job search.

Targeting Social Media in a Job Search

As digital technology continues to change our lives, job candidates have powerful new tools at their disposal: social media networks. These networks have become critical in a job search. If you just send out your résumé blindly, not much will happen. However, if you have a referral, your chances of landing an interview multiply. Today's expansion of online networks has produced an additional path to developing those coveted referrals.

• **Letting LinkedIn Help You Find a Job**. This social media site dominates the world of job searching and recruiting. In a recent poll of 1,855 recruiting and staffing professionals, 95 percent said that they used LinkedIn as a recruiting tool. It's truly the place to find and be found, especially for new grads. It lists well over a million and a half student jobs and

internships in addition to millions of full-time jobs. Developing an online presence at LinkedIn enables you to post information about yourself in one central place where it's available to potential employers, graduate schools, future colleagues, and people you will want to stay connected to. A LinkedIn page tells the working world that you are a professional, and it remains significant even after you obtain a position.

• **Enlisting Other Social Networks in a Job Hunt.** Job seekers can join Facebook, Twitter, and Google+ to find job opportunities, market themselves to companies, showcase their skills, highlight their experience, and possibly land that dream job. Because organizations may post open jobs to their Facebook or Twitter pages prior to advertising them elsewhere, you might gain a head start on submitting an application by following them on these sites. Employers often use these social media sites to check the online presence of a candidate. One report revealed that nine out of ten recruiters use social media to search, keep tabs on, and vet candidates before the interview. Make sure your social networking accounts represent you professionally. You can make it easy for your potential employer to learn more about you by including an informative bio in your Twitter or Facebook profile that has a link to your LinkedIn profile. You can also make yourself more discoverable by posting thoughtful blog posts and tweets on topics related to your career goal.

Read
Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 15: Page 573

5.3 Customizing your résumé

In today's highly competitive job market, the focus is not so much on what you want but on what the employer needs. That's why you must customize your résumé for every position you seek. The competition is so stiff today that you cannot get by with a generic, one-size-fits-all résumé. Although you can start with a basic résumé, you should customize it to fit each company and position if you want it to stand out from the crowd.

Choosing a Résumé Style

The first step in preparing a winning, customized résumé that appeals to both the human reader and the ATS screening device is to decide what style to use. Résumés usually fall into two categories: chronological and functional.

• **What Is a Chronological Résumé?** The chronological résumé lists work history job by job but in reverse order, starting with the most recent position. Recruiters favor the chronological format because they are familiar with it and because it quickly reveals a candidate's education and experience. The chronological style works well for candidates who have experience in their field of employment and for those who show steady career growth, but it is less helpful for people who have changed jobs frequently or who have gaps in their employment records. For

college students and others who lack extensive experience, the functional résumé format may be preferable.

•**What Is a Functional Résumé?** The functional résumé focuses on a candidate's skills rather than on past employment. Like a chronological résumé, a functional résumé begins with the candidate's name, contact information, job objective, and education. Instead of listing jobs, though, the functional résumé groups skills and accomplishments in special categories, such as Supervisory and Management Skills or Retailing and Marketing Experience. This résumé style highlights accomplishments and can de-emphasize a negative employment history.

•**How Long Should a Résumé Be?** Experts disagree on how long a résumé should be. Conventional wisdom has always held that recruiters prefer one-page résumés. However, recruiters who are serious about candidates often prefer the kind of details that can be provided in a two-page or longer résumé. What's more, with today's digital résumés, length is no longer restricted. The best advice is to make your résumé as long as needed to present your skills to recruiters and hiring managers. Individuals with more experience will naturally have longer résumés. Those with fewer than ten years of experience, those making a major career change, and those who have had only one or two employers will likely have one-page résumés. Those with ten years or more of related experience may have two-page résumés. Finally, some senior-level managers and executives with a lengthy history of major accomplishments might have résumés that are three pages or longer.

Organizing Your Information Into Effective Résumé Categories

Although résumés have standard categories, their arrangement and content should be strategically planned. A customized résumé emphasizes skills and achievements aimed at a particular job or company. It shows a candidate's most important qualifications first, and it de-emphasizes weaknesses. No two résumés are ever exactly alike, but most writers include all or some of these categories:

•**Main Heading.** Your résumé, whether chronological or functional, should start with an uncluttered and simple main heading. The first line should always be your name; add your middle initial for an even more professional look. Format your name so that it stands out on the page. Following your name, list your contact information, including your address, area code and phone number, and e-mail address. Your telephone should be one where you can receive messages. The outgoing message at this number should be in your voice, it should state your full name, and it should be concise and professional. If you include your cell phone number and are expecting an important call from a recruiter, pick up only when you are in a quiet environment and can concentrate.

•**Career Objective.** Although experts don't agree on whether to include an objective on a résumé, nearly all agree that if you do, it should be very specific. A well-written objective—customized for the job opening—makes sense, especially for new grads with fresh training and relevant skills. Strive to include strategic keywords from the job listing because these will help tracking systems select your résumé. Focus on what you can contribute to the organization, not on what the organization can do for you. Using a customized objective or a job title makes it clear that you have taken the time and made the effort to prepare your résumé for the position.

If you decide to omit a career objective, be sure to discuss your career goals in your cover message.

•**Optional Summary of Qualifications.** Once a job is advertised, a hiring manager may receive hundreds or even thousands of résumés. A summary ensures that your most impressive qualifications are not overlooked by a recruiter who is skimming résumés quickly. A summary also enables you to present a concentrated list of many relevant keywords for a tracking system to pick up, thus boosting your chance of selection. Additionally, because résumés today may be viewed on tablets and smartphones, the summary spotlights your most compelling qualifications in a highly visible spot.

•**Education**. In this section you should include the name and location of schools, dates of attendance, major fields of study, and degrees received. By the way, once you have attended college, you don't need to list high school information on your résumé. Under Education you might be tempted to list all the courses you took, but such a list makes for dull reading and consumes valuable space. Include a brief list of courses only if you can relate them to the position sought. When relevant, include certificates earned, seminars attended, workshops completed, scholarships awarded, and honors earned. If your education is incomplete, include such statements as BS degree expected 6/18 or 80 units completed in 120-unit program. Title this section Education, Academic Preparation, or Professional Training.

•**Work Experience or Employment History**. When your work or volunteer experience is significant and relevant to the position sought, this information should appear before your education. List your most recent employment first and work backward, including only those jobs that you think will help you win the targeted position. A job application form may demand a full employment history, but your résumé may be selective. Be aware, though, that time gaps in your employment history will probably be questioned in the interview. For each position show the following:

- Employer's name, city, and state
- Dates of employment (month and year)
- Most important job title
- Significant duties, activities, accomplishments, and promotions

Be sure to include relevant volunteer work.

5.4 Enhancing your job search with today's digital tools

Just as electronic media have changed the way candidates seek jobs, these same digital tools are trans- forming the way employers select qualified candidates. As discussed earlier, the first reader of your résumé may very well be an applicant tracking system (ATS). As many as 90 percent of large companies and scores of smaller companies are now employing these systems. Why have they become so popular? In this digital era, the process of applying for jobs has become so effortless that organizations are flooded with résumés. Screening systems whittle down the cumbersome applicant pool to just a handful of qualified applicants for the human hiring managers to review more closely. The sad truth for applicants, however, is that up to 75 percent of résumés don't make it past the ATS screening.

Maximizing the Rank of Your Résumé

The higher your résumé ranks when it is evaluated by an applicant tracking system, the more likely it will be reviewed by a recruiter or hiring manager. The following techniques, in addition to those cited earlier, can boost the probability that your résumé will rank high enough to qualify for review by a human reader.

•**Include specific keywords or phrases in context**. Study carefully any advertisements and job descriptions for the position you want. Describe your experience, education, and qualifications in terms associated with the job advertisement or job description for this position.

•**Focus on nouns**. Although action verbs will make your résumé appeal to a recruiter, the applicant tracking system will often be looking for nouns in three categories: (a) a job title, position, or role; (b) a technical skill or specialization and (c) a certification, a tool used, or specific experience.

•**Use variations of the job title**. Tracking systems may seek a slightly different job title from what you list. To be safe, include variations and abbreviations (*e.g., occupational therapist, certified occupational therapist, or COTA*). If you don't have experience in your targeted area, use the job title you list in your objective.

•**Concentrate on the Skills section**. A majority of keywords sought by employees relate to specialized or technical skill requirements. Therefore, be sure the Skills section of your résumé is loaded with nouns that describe your skills and qualifications.

•**Keep the formatting simple**. Stay away from logos, pictures, symbols, and shadings.

•**Use conventional headings**. Include familiar headings such as *Skills, Qualifications*, and *Education*. ATS software may not recognize headings such as *Professional Engagement* or *Core Competencies.*

Submitting Your Résumé

The format you choose for submitting your résumé depends on what is required. If you are responding to a job advertisement, be certain to read the listing carefully to learn how the employer wants you to submit your résumé. Not following the prospective employer's instructions can eliminate you from consideration before your résumé is even reviewed. If you have any doubt about what format is desired, send an e-mail inquiry to a company representative, or call and ask. Most organizations request one of the following submission formats:

• **Word document.** Some organizations ask candidates to send their résumés and cover messages by surface mail. Others request that résumés be submitted as Word documents attached to e-mail messages, despite the fear of viruses.

• **Plain-text document**. As discussed earlier, many employers expect applicants to submit résumés and cover letters as plain-text documents. This format is also widely used for posting to an online job board or for sending by e-mail. Plain-text résumés may be embedded within or attached to e-mail messages.

• **PDF document**. For safety reasons some employers prefer PDF (portable document format) files. A PDF résumé looks exactly like the original and cannot be altered. Most computers have Adobe Acrobat Reader installed for easy reading of PDF files. Converting your résumé to a PDF file can be easily done by saving it as a PDF file, which preserves all formatting.

• **Company database**. Larger organizations and the government may prefer that you complete an online form with your résumé information. This enables them to plug your data into their template categories for rapid searching. You might be able to cut and paste the information from your résumé into the form; however, uploading the information is less likely to choke a scanning device.

Because your résumé is probably the most important message you will ever write, you will revise it many times. With so much information in concentrated form and with so much riding on its outcome, your résumé demands careful polishing, proofreading, and critiquing. The following checklist will help you review the primary steps in creating and submitting a customized résumé.



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Chapter Summary/Review

1. Begin a job search by recognizing emerging trends and technologies, exploring your interests, evaluating your qualifications, and investigating career opportunities.

- Recognize that searching for a job in this digital age now includes such indispensable tools as job boards, social networks, and mobile technologies.
- Start the process by learning about yourself, your field of interest, and your qualifications. How do your skills match what employers seek?

2. Develop savvy search strategies by recognizing how job seekers find their jobs and how they use digital tools to explore the open job market.

- Research reveals that job seekers found their best jobs through personal networking, online social networking, online job boards, classified advertisements, recruiters, college fairs, and other connections.
- In searching the open job market—that is, jobs that are listed and advertised—explore the big job boards, such as Indeed, CareerBuilder, Monster, and CollegeGrad.

3. Expand your job-search strategies by using both traditional and digital tools in pursuing the hidden job market.

- Estimates suggest that as many as 80 percent of jobs are in the hidden job market— that is, never advertised. Successful job candidates find jobs in the hidden job market through networking.
- An effective networking procedure involves (a) developing a contact list, (b) reaching out to these contacts in person and online in search of referrals, and (c) following up on referrals.

4. Organize your qualifications and skills into effective résumé categories, and use that information to prepare a personalized LinkedIn résumé.

- Because of intense competition, you must customize your résumé to appeal to an applicant tracking system (ATS) as well as to a human reader.
- Chronological résumés, which list work and education by dates, rank highest with recruiters. Functional résumés, which highlight skills instead of jobs, may be helpful for people with little experience, those changing careers, and those with negative employment histories.

5. Enhance your job search and résumé by taking advantage of today's digital tools.

- To maximize the rank of your résumé when it is evaluated by an automated tracking system, include specific keywords such as nouns that name job titles, technical skills, and tools used or specific experience.
- Consider preparing a career e-portfolio to showcase your qualifications. This collection of digital files can feature your talents, accomplishments, and technical skills. It may include examples of academic performance, photographs, multimedia files, and other items beyond what can be shown in a résumé.

6. Understand the value of cover messages and how to draft and submit a customized message to highlight your candidacy.

- Although applicant tracking systems may accept only a résumé, cover messages still play an important role in the job application process, especially to hiring managers.
- Cover messages help recruiters make decisions, and they enable candidates to set themselves apart from others.



Review Questions (Short)

1. The way candidates search for jobs and the way they are hired has changed dramatically in the digital age. Name some of the changes that have taken place. In your opinion, have the changes had a positive or a negative effect? Why?

2. Why do you think some businesses avoid advertising job openings? If jobs are unlisted, how can candidates locate them?

3. Some employment authors claim that the paper résumé is dead or dying. What's behind this assertion, and how should current job candidates respond?

4. Why might it be more effective to apply for unsolicited jobs than for advertised jobs? Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of letters that prospect for jobs.

5. Ethical Issue: Some jobs are advertised even when a leading candidate has the position nailed down. The candidate could be an internal applicant or someone else with an inside track. Although not required by law, management policies and human resources departments at many companies demand that hiring managers list all openings on job boards or career sites. Often, hiring managers have already selected candidates for these phantom jobs. Do you believe it is ethical to advertise jobs that are not really available?



Review Questions (Long)

1. Analyze the following poor résumé. List at least eight weaknesses.

Résumé
Camille Elena Montano
1340 East Phillips Ave., Apt. D Littleton, CO 80126
Phone 455-5182 | E-Mail: Hotchilibabe@gmail.com | LinkedIn

OBJECTIVE
I'm dying to become an accounting associate in the "real world" with a big profitable company that will help me get the experience I need to become a CPA.

SKILLS
Microsoft Word, MS Outlook, Powerpoint, Excel, spread- sheets Excel; experienced with QuickBooks, great compo- sure in stressful situations; 3 years as leader and supervisor and 4 years in customer service

EDUCATION
Arapahoe Community College, Littleton, Colorado. AA degree, Fall 2015
Now I am pursuing a BA in Accounting at CSU-Pueblo, major- ing in Accounting; my minor is Finance. Completed 64 units of upper-level units. My expected degree date is June 2018; I received a Certificate of Completion in Entry Level Accounting in December 2015. My overall GPA is 3.5 on a 4.0 = A system.
I graduated East High School, Denver, CO in 2011.

Highlights:
- Named Line Manger of the Month at Target, 10/2014 and 03/2015
- Obtained a Certificate in Entry Level Accounting, June 2015
- Chair of Accounting Society, Spring and fall 2017
- Dean's Honor List, Fall 2017 • Financial advisor training completed through Primerica (May 2016)
- Webmaster for M.E.Ch.A, Spring 2017

Part-Time Employment

Financial Consultant, 2016 to present I worked only part-time (January 2016-present) for Primerica Financial Services, Pueblo, CO to assist clients in refinancing a mortgage or consolidating a current mortgage loan and also to advice clients in assessing their need for life insurance.

Target, Littleton, CO. As line manager, from September 2014 - August 2015, I supervised 12 cashiers and front-end associates. I helped to write schedules, disciplinary action notices, and performance appraisals. I also kept track of change drawer and money exchanges; occasionally was manager on duty for entire store. Named line manager of the month August 2014 and March 2015.

Mr. K's Floral Design of Denver. I taught flower design from August, 2013 to September, 2014. I supervised 5 florists, made floral arrangements for big events like weddings, send them to customers, and restocked flowers.

2. Analyze each section of the following cover letter and list its weaknesses.

To Whom It May Concern:

I saw your accounting associate position listing yesterday and would like to apply right away. It would be so exiting to work for your esteemed firm! This position would really give me much needed real-world experience and help me become a CPA.

I have all the qualifications you require in your add and more. I am a senior at Colorado State University-Pueblo and an Accounting major (with a minor in Finance) and have completed 64 units of upper-level course work. Accounting and Finance are my passion and I want to become a CPA and a financial advisor. I have taken eight courses in accounting and now work as a part-time financial advisor with Primerica Financial Services in Pueblo. I should also tell you that I was at Target for four years. I learned alot, but my heart is in accounting and finance.

I am a team player, a born leader, motivated, reliable, and I show excellent composure in stressful situations, for example, when customers complain. I put myself through school and always carry at least 12 units while working part time.

You will probably agree that I am a good candidate for your accounting position, which I understand should start about July 1. I feel that my motivation, passion, and strong people skills will serve your company well.

Sincerely,

3. Write a résumé. Aim it at the full-time job, part-time position, or internship. Attach the job listing to your résumé. Also prepare a list of references.

Case Studies / Projects

Graduating From Classroom to Career

You've been in school for a long time, but the end is in sight. Now, however, you begin to worry about the job market and how to land a dream job.

"Hiring managers expect young professionals to be job-hunting experts," observes career expert and experienced hiring manager Heather Huhman in her ebook #ENTRYLEVELtweet: Taking Your Career From Classroom to Cubicle. The truth is, however, that most college students and recent grads don't know how to search for a job or what to expect. It's easy to be misled by misconceptions and myths.

One myth is that all job openings are posted on job boards. This is definitely not true, she says. Many hiring managers refuse to post job openings because they fear receiving too many applications from unqualified candidates. Instead, large numbers of positions become part of the hidden job market, which is why Huhman passionately encourages recent grads to network vigorously. She agrees with other job- search experts who claim that as many as 80 percent of jobs are found through networking. Another myth is that simply applying for jobs will land an interview. In the current tough job market, however, candidates must actively network and maintain a positive presence online.

REQUIRED:

- You are still in college, and the world of work may be way off in the future. Why, then, is it important to research the job market and even prepare a résumé if you are not in the market at this time?
- What do you know about the hidden job market, and how does networking help a new grad find a job in this elusive market?
- How many résumés should a recent grad prepare? What format is preferable?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 15: Page 565



LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Section of the guide, the learner should be able to:

Learning Objectives

- Explain the purposes, sequence, and types of job interviews, including screening, one-on-one, panel, group, sequential, and video interviews.
- Describe what to do before an interview, including ensuring professional phone techniques, researching the target company, rehearsing success stories, cleaning up digital dirt, dressing properly, and fighting fear.
- Describe what to do during an interview, including controlling nonverbal messages and answering typical interview questions.
- Describe what to do after an interview, including thanking the interviewer, contacting references, and writing follow-up messages.
- Prepare additional employment documents such as applications, rejection follow-up messages, acceptance messages, and resignation letters.

Introduction

Whether you are completing your education and searching for your first serious position or are in the workforce and striving to change jobs—a job interview can be life changing. Because employment is a major part of everyone's life, the job interview takes on enormous importance. Most people consider job interviews extremely stressful, eliciting as much or more anxiety than making a speech or going on a first date. However, the more you learn about the process and the more prepared you are, the less stress you will feel.

6.1 Interviewing effectively in today's competitive job market

A job interview is a two-way street. It is not just about being judged by the employer. You, the applicant, will be using the job interview to evaluate the employer. Do you really want to work for this organization? To be successful in a highly competitive market, you must keep up with the latest trends and techniques that recruiters use to choose the very best candidates. Figure 6.1 illustrates six hot trends in today's employment scene.



Figure 6.1 Latest Trends in Interviewing

Purposes and Sequencing of Employment Interviews

An interview has several purposes for you as a job candidate. It is an opportunity to:

(a) convince the employer of your potential

(b) learn more about the job and the company

(c) expand on the information in your résumé.

This is the time for you to gather information to determine whether you would fit into the company culture. You should also be thinking about whether this job suits your career goals.

From the employer's perspective, the interview is an opportunity to:

(a) assess your abilities in relation to the requirements for the position

(b) discuss your training, experience, knowledge, and abilities in more detail

(c) see what drives and motivates you

(d) decide whether you would fit into the organization.

The hiring process often follows a six-stage sequence, as illustrated in Figure 6.2. Following the application, interviews proceed from screening interviews to hiring interviews.



Figure 6.2 Six Stages of the Hiring Process

Screening Interviews

Screening interviews do just that—they screen candidates to eliminate those who fail to meet minimum requirements. Companies use screening interviews to save time and money by weeding out lesser-qualified candidates before scheduling final face-to-face or video interviews. Although initial screening interviews may be conducted during job fairs or on college campuses, they usually take place by telephone or video.

Hiring/Placement Interviews

The most promising candidates selected from screening interviews are invited to hiring/ placement interviews. Hiring managers want to learn whether candidates are motivated, qualified, and a good fit for the position. Their goal is to learn how the candidate would fit into their organization. Conducted in depth, hiring/placement interviews take many forms.

• **One-on-One Interviews.** In one-on-one interviews, which are most common, you can expect to sit down with a company representative and talk about the job and your qualifications. If the representative is the hiring manager, questions will be specific and job related.

•**Panel Interviews.** Panel interviews are typically conducted by people who will be your supervisors and colleagues. Usually seated around a table, interviewers take turns asking questions. Panel interviews are advantageous because they save the company time and money, and they show you how the staff works together.

•**Group Interviews.** Group interviews occur when a company interviews several candidates for the same position at the same time. Some employers use this technique to evaluate

leadership skills and communication styles. During a group interview, stay focused on the interviewer, and treat the other candidates with respect. Even if you are nervous, try to remain calm, take your time when responding, and express yourself clearly. The key during a group interview is to make yourself stand out from the other candidates in a positive way.

•**Sequential Interviews**. In a sequential interview, you meet individually with two or more interviewer's one-on-ones over the course of several hours or days. You must listen carefully and respond positively to all interviewers. Promote your qualifications to each one; don't assume that any interviewer knows what was said in a previous interview. Keep your responses fresh, even when repeating yourself many times over.

•**Video Interviews.** Perhaps the hottest trend in interviewing is the rush to video inter- views. One-way (asynchronous) video interviewing enables a candidate to respond to a list of prescripted questions prepared by the hiring organization. When convenient, the candidate creates a video recording of the answers. The interviewer can view the job seeker, but the job seeker cannot see the interviewer.

- One-way interviewing benefits employers by cutting the time needed to meet lots of candidates; it benefits candidates by enabling them to be interviewed at their leisure without traveling to distant locations. Candidates also can practice and perfect their responses by rerecording.
- Two-way video interviewing is similar to regular face-to-face interviewing, but it is typically conducted through video chat. A key advantage of two-way interviewing is that it provides an interactive forum enabling hiring companies to better assess a candidate's communication skills, body language, and personality.

6.2 Before the interview

Once you have sent out at least one résumé or filled out at least one job application, you must consider yourself an active job seeker. Being active in the job market means that you should be prepared to be contacted by potential employers. As discussed earlier, employers often use screening interviews to narrow the list of candidates. If you do well in the screening interview, you will be invited to an in-person or video meeting.

Making the First Conversation Impressive

Whether you answer the phone directly or return an employer's call, make sure you are prepared for the conversation. Remember that this is the first time the employer has heard your voice. How you conduct yourself on the phone will create a lasting impression. To make that first impression a positive one, follow these tips:

• Keep a list on your cellphone or near the telephone of positions for which you have applied.

• Treat any call from an employer just like an interview. Use a professional tone and business-like language. Be polite and enthusiastic, and sell your qualifications.

• If caught off guard by the call, ask whether you can call back in a few minutes. Take that time to organize your materials and yourself.

• Take good notes during the phone conversation. Obtain accurate directions, and verify the spelling of your interviewer's name. If you will be interviewed by more than one person, get all of their names.

• Before you hang up, reconfirm the date and time of your interview.

Cleaning Up Digital Dirt

Potential employers definitely screen candidates' online presence using Google and social media sites. A recent CareerBuilder survey revealed that 49 percent of hiring managers who screen candidates via social networks said they had found information that caused them not to hire a candidate. What turned them off? The top reasons cited were

- Provocative or inappropriate photographs, videos, or information;
- Content about drinking or doing drugs;
- Discriminatory comments related to race, religion, and other protected categories;
- Criticism of previous employers or colleagues; and
- Poor communication skills.

Teasing photographs and provocative comments about drinking, drug use, and sexual exploits make students look immature and unprofessional. Think about cleaning up your online presence by following these steps:

• Remove questionable content. Remove any incriminating, provocative, or distasteful photos, content, and links that could make you look unprofessional to potential employers.

• Stay positive. Don't complain about things in your professional or personal life online. Even negative reviews you have written on sites such as Amazon can turn employers off.

• Be selective about who is on your list of friends. You don't want to miss out on an opportunity because you seem to associate with negative, immature, or unprofessional people. Your best bet is to make your personal social networking pages private. Monitor your settings because they often change.

• Don't discuss your job search if you are still employed. Employees can find themselves in trouble with their current employers by writing status updates or sending tweets about their job searches.

Dressing for, Traveling to, and Arriving at Your Interview

The big day has arrived! Ideally, you are fully prepared for your interview. Now you need to make sure that everything goes smoothly. On the day of your interview, give yourself plenty of time to groom and dress.

•**Deciding What to Wear.**What to wear may worry you because business attire today ranges from ultracasual to formal suits. The best plan is to ask your interviewer what is appropriate,

advises career counselor Liz Ryan. Ask this when the interview is arranged, and you will be greatly relieved. Here's what you definitely should not wear:

- Ill-fitting clothes;
- Overly casual attire, such as jeans, tennis shoes, shorts, T-shirts, hats, flip- flops, and any item promoting messages or brands;
- Distracting items;
- Excessive accessories; or
- Something very different from what the interviewer suggested.

•**Make sure you can arrive at the employer's office without being rushed**. If something unexpected happens that will to cause you to be late, such as an accident or bridge closure, call the interviewer right away to explain what is happening. Most interviewers will be understanding, and your call will show that you are responsible. On the way to the interview, don't smoke, don't eat anything messy or smelly, and don't load up on perfume or cologne. Arrive at the interview five or ten minutes early, but not earlier. If you are very early, wait in the car or in a café nearby. If possible, check your appearance before going in.

•**Being Polite and Pleasant**. When you enter the office, be courteous and congenial to everyone. Remember that you are being judged not only by the interviewer but also by the receptionist and anyone else who sees you before and after the interview. They will notice how you sit, what you read, and how you look. Introduce yourself to the receptionist, and wait to be invited to sit. You may be asked to fill out a job application while you are waiting. You will find tips for doing this effectively later in this chapter.

•**Greeting the Interviewer and Making a Positive First Impression**. Greet the interviewer confidently, and don't be afraid to initiate a handshake. Doing so exhibits professionalism and confidence. Extend your hand, look the interviewer directly in the eye, smile pleasantly, and say, *I'm pleased to meet you, Mr. Thomas. I am Constance Ferraro*. In this culture a firm, not crushing, handshake sends a nonverbal message of poise and assurance. Once introductions have taken place, wait for the interviewer to offer you a chair. Make small talk with upbeat. Don't immediately begin rummaging in your briefcase for your résumé. Being at ease and unrushed suggests that you are self-confident.

Read
Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 16: Page 620

6.3 During the interview

Throughout the interview you will be answering questions and asking your own questions. Your demeanour, body language, and other nonverbal cues will also be on display. The interviewer will be trying to learn more about you, and you should be learning more about the job and the organization. Although you may be asked some unique questions, many

interviewers ask standard, time-proven questions, which means that you can prepare your answers ahead of time. You can also prepare by learning techniques to control those inevitable butterflies in the tummy.

Sending Positive Nonverbal Messages and Acting Professionally

You have already sent nonverbal messages to your interviewer by arriving on time, being courteous, dressing appropriately, and greeting the receptionist confidently. You will continue to send nonverbal messages throughout the interview. Remember that what comes out of your mouth and what is written on your résumé are not the only messages an interviewer receives from you. Nonverbal messages also create powerful impressions. You can send positive nonverbal messages during face-to-face and online interviews by following these tips:

• **Control your body movements.** Keep your hands, arms, and elbows to yourself. Don't lean on a desk. Keep your feet on the floor. Don't cross your arms in front of you. Keep your hands out of your pockets.

• **Exhibit good posture.** Sit erect, leaning forward slightly. Don't slouch in your chair; at the same time, don't look too stiff and uncomfortable. Good posture demonstrates confidence and interest.

• **Practice appropriate eye contact**. A direct eye gaze, suggests interest and trustworthiness. If you are being interviewed by a panel, remember to maintain eye contact with all interviewers.

• **Use gestures effectively.** Nod to show agreement and interest. Gestures should be used as needed, but not overused.

• **Listen attentively**. Show the interviewer you are interested and attentive by listening carefully to questions. This will also help you answer questions appropriately.

• **Turn off your cellphone or other electronic devices**. Avoid the embarrassment of having your device ring, or even as much as buzz, during an interview. Turn off your electronic devices completely; don't just switch them to vibrate.

• **Sound enthusiastic and interested—but sincere**. The tone of your voice has an enormous effect on the words you say. Avoid sounding bored, frustrated, or sarcastic during an interview. Employers want employees who are enthusiastic and interested.

• **Be confident, but not cocky**. Most recruiters want candidates who are self-assured but not too casual or even arrogant. Let your body language, posture, dress, and vocal tone prove your confidence. Speak at a normal volume and enunciate words clearly without mumbling.

Preparing to Answer Interview Questions

One way you can compensate for lack of experience is to have carefully prepared and well-rehearsed responses to typical interview questions. In addition, the way you answer questions can be almost as important as what you say. Use the interviewer's name and title from time to time when you answer. Avoid answering questions with a simple yes or no; elaborate on your

answers to better promote yourself and your assets. Keep your answers positive; don't criticize anything or anyone.

During the interview it may be necessary to occasionally refocus and clarify vague questions. Always aim your answers at the key characteristics interviewers seek: expertise, competence, motivation, interpersonal skills, decision-making skills, enthusiasm for the company and the job, and a pleasing personality. Remember to stay focused on your strengths. Don't reveal weaknesses, even if you think they make you look human. You won't be hired for your weaknesses, only for your strengths. As you respond, be sure to use good English and enunciate clearly. You can't expect to be perfect in an employment interview. No one is. But you can avert sure disaster by avoiding certain topics and behaviors such as those described in Figures 6.3



Figure 6.3 Ten Interview Actions to Avoid

6.4 After the interview

After leaving the interview, immediately make notes of what was said in case you are called back for a second interview. Write down key points that were discussed, the names of people you spoke with, and other details of the interview. Ask yourself what went really well and what you could improve. Note your strengths and weaknesses during the interview so that you can work to improve in future interviews.

Sending a Thank-You Message

After a job interview, you should always send a thank-you message. Why? This courtesy sets you apart from other applicants, most of whom will not bother. In addition, more than one in five hiring managers say they are less likely to hire a candidate who doesn't follow up an interview with a message. Your message also reminds the interviewer of your visit and shows your good manners and genuine enthusiasm for the job.If you have been interviewed by more than one person, send a separate thank-you message to each interviewer.

Contacting Your References

Once you have thanked your interviewer, it is time to alert your references that they may be contacted by the employer. You might also have to request a letter of recommendation to be sent to the employer by a certain date. You should have already asked permission to use these individuals as references, and you should have supplied them with a copy of your résumé and information about the types of positions you are seeking.

Following Up

If you don't hear from the interviewer within five days, or at the specified time, consider following up. Of course, if you have remembered to ask the interviewer when a decision is expected and whether you may follow up, you are all set. Otherwise, the standard advice to job candidates is to contact the interviewer with a follow-up e-mail or phone call.An e-mail to find out how the decision process is going may be your best bet because such a message is less intrusive than a phone call.

6.5 Preparing additional employment documents

Although the résumé are your major tasks, other important documents and messages are often required during the job-search process. You may need to complete an employment application form and write follow-up letters. You might also have to write a letter of resignation when leaving a job. Because each of these tasks reveals something about you and your communication skills, you will want to put your best foot forward. These documents often subtly influence company officials to offer a job.

Application Form

Some organizations require job candidates to fill out application forms instead of, or in addition to, submitting résumés. This practice permits them to gather and store standardized data about each applicant. Whether the application is on paper or online, follow the directions carefully and provide accurate information. The following suggestions can help you be prepared:

•**Carry a card summarizing vital statistics not included on your résumé**. If you are asked to fill out an application form in an employer's office, you will need a handy reference to the following data: graduation dates;

- beginning and ending dates of all employment;
- salary history
- full names
- present work addresses of former supervisors
- full addresses and phone numbers of current and previous employers

•**Look over all the questions before starting.** If filling out a paper form, write neatly using blue or black ink. Many career counselors recommend printing your responses; cursive handwriting can be difficult to read. Answer all questions honestly. Write Not applicable or N/A if appropriate. Don't leave any sections blank.

•**Be prepared to explain the reasons for leaving previous positions**. Use positive or neutral phrases such as Relocation, Seasonal, To accept a position with more responsibility, Temporary position, To continue education, or Career change. Avoid words or phrases such as Fired, Quit, Didn't get along with supervisor, and Pregnant.

Look over the application before submitting to make sure it is complete and that you have followed all instructions.

Job Acceptance and Rejection Message

When all your hard work pays off, you will be offered the position you want. Although you will likely accept the position over the phone, it is a good idea to follow up with an acceptance e-mail or letter to confirm the details and to formalize the acceptance.

If you must turn down a job offer, show your professionalism by writing a sincere letter. This letter should thank the employer for the job offer and explain briefly that you are turning it down. Taking the time to extend this courtesy could help you in the future if this employer has a position you really want

Resignation Letter

After you have been in a position for a period of time, you may find it necessary to leave. Perhaps you have been offered a better position, or maybe you have decided to return to school full-time. Whatever the reason, you should leave your position gracefully and tactfully. Although you will likely discuss your resignation in person with your supervisor, it is a good idea to document your resignation by writing a formal letter. Some resignation letters are brief, while others contain great detail. Remember that many resignation letters are placed in personnel files; therefore, you should format and write yours using the professional business letter–writing techniques.

Writing job acceptance, job rejection, and resignation letters requires effort. That effort, however, is worth it because you are building bridges that may carry you to even better jobs in the future.

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 16: Page 638



Chapter Summary/Review

1. Explain trends, purposes, sequence, and types of job interviews, including screening, one-on-one, panel, group, sequential, and video interviews.

- Current trends in interviewing include (a) early-stage screening by technology; (b) longer, multiple interviews; (c) on-the-spot interviewing; (d) psychometric and skills tests; (e) behavioural and situational questions; and (f) group interviews.
- As a job candidate, you have the following purposes in an interview: (a) convince the employer of your potential, (b) learn more about the job and the company, and (c) expand on the information in your résumé.

2. Describe what to do before an interview, including ensuring professional phone techniques, researching the target company, rehearsing success stories, cleaning up digital dirt, dressing properly, and fighting fear.

- Prepare for telephone screening interviews by ensuring professional answering techniques and screening incoming calls.
- Make the first conversation impressive by using professional, business-like language, and having your résumé, a calendar, and a list of your references handy.

3. Describe what to do during an interview, including controlling nonverbal messages and answering typical interview questions.

- During your interview send positive nonverbal messages by controlling body movements, showing good posture, maintaining eye contact, using gestures effectively, and smiling enough to convey a positive, professional attitude.
- Listen attentively, turn off your cell phone or other electronic devices, don't chew gum, and sound enthusiastic and sincere.

4. Describe what to do after an interview, including thanking the interviewer, contacting references, and writing follow-up messages.

- After leaving the interview, immediately make notes of the key points discussed.
- Note your strengths and weaknesses during the interview so that you can work to improve in future interviews.

5. Prepare additional employment documents such as applications, rejection follow-up messages, acceptance messages, and resignation letters.

- When filling out an application form, look over all the questions before starting.
- If asked for a salary figure, provide a salary range or write Negotiable or Open.

Review Questions (Short)

1. Online psychometric and skills tests with multiple-choice questionnaires have become a hot trend in interviewing today. Employers may ask not only how applicants would handle tricky situations, but also how happy they are or how much they have stolen from their previous employer. The multiple-choice format poses a dilemma for applicants because they don't know whether to be truthful or say what the employer might want to hear. Is this practice fair? What are some advantages and disadvantages of this practice?

2. Like criminal background checks and drug tests, social media background checks have become commonplace in today's recruiting. What are the pros and cons of conducting such checks as a primary or sole means of screening applicants?

3. If you are asked an illegal interview question, why is it important to first assess the intentions of the interviewer?

4. Why is it a smart strategy to thank an interviewer, to follow up, and even to send a rejection follow-up message? Are any risks associated with this strategy?

5. Ethical Issue: A recruiter for an organization has an outstanding prospect for a position. As part of his screening process, the recruiter checks the online presence of the candidate and discovers from her social networks that she is 18 weeks pregnant—and happily so. He knows that the target position involves a big project that will go live just about the time she will be taking maternity leave. He decides not to continue the hiring process with this candidate. Is his action legal? Ethical? What lesson could be learned about posting private information online?



Review Questions (Long)

1. Consider a position for which you are eligible now or one for which you will be eligible when you complete your education. Identify the skills and traits necessary for this position. Prepare interview worksheets listing at least ten technical and other skills or traits you think a recruiter will want to discuss in an interview for your targeted position.

2. Locate lists of behavioural questions on the Internet. Select five skill areas such as communication, teamwork, and decision making. For each skill area, find three behavioural questions that you think would be effective in an interview.

3. A month has passed since you sent your résumé and cover letter in response to a job advertisement. You are still interested in the position and would like to find out whether you still have a chance. Write a follow-up e-mail or letter to an employer of your choice that does not offend the reader or damage your chances of employment.

4. Your dream has come true: you have just been offered an excellent position. Although you accepted the position on the phone, you want to send a formal acceptance letter. Write a job acceptance letter to an employer of your choice. Include the job title, your starting date, and details about your compensation package. Make up any necessary details.

Case Studies / Projects

Achieving Interview Success in Today's Competitive Job Market

The job market has become remarkably complicated and competitive, especially for recent grads. If you are new to the job market or changing careers, career coach Don Georgevich offers practical advice. A leading authority in job interviewing and résumé writing, Georgevich helps job candidates cut through the red tape of interviews so that they are hired for the jobs they want. The author of three top-selling career books plus e-tools, blogs, YouTube videos, and Internet articles, Georgevich shares special advice for those who are new to the job-search process. "For new grads, being aware of recent trends and preparing diligently for the interview is crucial," he stressed in an e-mail message to Mary Ellen Guffey. "The more you study the company and the job description, combined with how you believe your skills and experiences fit in, the more prepared you will be. You can even predict what to expect in a typical interview because interviewers tend to repeat common questions."

When asked how new grads and career changers can gain traction in a highly competitive job market, Georgevich stressed demonstrating transferable skills. For example, candidates can say, "I have [blank] skills and I can use them to do [blank] for you." Job seekers need to connect the dots for employers and show how their qualifications fit the targeted position. "All too often," he said, "job seekers leave it up to the interviewer to figure out what they are good at doing instead of taking a proactive stance."

REQUIRED:

- Can novice job seekers predict what a job interview will involve?
- How is interviewing a two-way street? What does this mean for job candidates?
- How can job seekers show recruiters or hiring managers that they are invested in a position during the job interview?

Read

Business Communication: Process & Product 9th Edition, *Mary Ellen Guffey & Dana Loewy,* Chapter 16: Page 613